Litmus: detecting persuasion techniques in meme text

COSC2779 Deep Learning, Assignment 2 (Sequence Modelling) · Student: s4271512

The tool reads the text extracted from a meme and returns **(A)** the set of persuasion techniques it uses (20-way multi-label classification) and **(B)** where each technique sits in the text (multi-label span tagging). **(C)** then answers the curriculum committee's four questions with experiments.

How to read this notebook. Every design decision is made at the point where the evidence for it appears. Each experiment states its *hypothesis and the decision it feeds* **before** it runs, so it is clear what result would have changed our mind. All numbers are produced by this notebook (`Restart & Run All`), except the zero-shot LLM responses for C2, which were collected outside it as the specification allows, are embedded here, and are parsed and scored here.

Section	Content
0	Setup, reproducibility, data
1	Understanding the data and where it came from
2	Evaluation framework: metrics, splits, baselines
3	Model: shared encoder with two self-built heads
4	Experiments E1–E8: encoder, adaptation strategy, architecture, head, loss, hyper-parameters, thresholds, robustness
5	Final model on the held-out test set, error analysis, explainability
6	Part C: C1 bias, C2 zero-shot comparison, C3 head agreement, C4 Australian deployment
7	Ultimate judgement, limitations, declarations

0. Setup

A fixed seed is set for Python, NumPy and PyTorch, and cuDNN is put into deterministic mode. GPU kernels can still introduce tiny non-determinism; for that reason every model comparison below is made across five folds rather than on a single run, so conclusions never hinge on one lucky seed.

In [1]:
```
import os, sys, json, re, math, time, random, copy, hashlib, itertools,
collections, subprocess, gc
os.environ.setdefault("HF_HUB_DISABLE_SYMLINKS_WARNING", "1")
os.environ.setdefault("HF_HUB_DISABLE_PROGRESS_BARS", "1")
from pathlib import Path

IN_COLAB = "google.colab" in sys.modules
import warnings
warnings.filterwarnings("ignore", category=UserWarning, module="tqdm")
import numpy as np
import pandas as pd
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
import torch
import torch.nn as nn
import torch.nn.functional as F
from transformers import AutoTokenizer, AutoModel, get_linear_schedule_with_warmup
from transformers.utils import logging as hf_logging
```

```
from sklearn.metrics import f1_score, precision_score, recall_score

hf_logging.set_verbosity_error(); hf_logging.disable_progress_bar()
pd.set_option("display.max_colwidth", 120)
plt.rcParams.update({"figure.dpi": 110, "axes.spines.top": False,
"axes.spines.right": False})

SEED = 42


def seed_everything(seed: int = SEED) -> None:
    random.seed(seed); np.random.seed(seed); torch.manual_seed(seed);
torch.cuda.manual_seed_all(seed)
    os.environ["PYTHONHASHSEED"] = str(seed)
    torch.backends.cudnn.deterministic = True
    torch.backends.cudnn.benchmark = False


seed_everything()
DEVICE = torch.device("cuda" if torch.cuda.is_available() else "cpu")
# Local smoke-test switch (tiny encoder, 2 folds, 1 epoch). Always False for the
submitted run.
FAST_DEV_RUN = os.environ.get("A2_FAST", "0") == "1"
print("torch", torch.__version__, "| device:", DEVICE,
      torch.cuda.get_device_name(0) if DEVICE.type == "cuda" else "", "|
FAST_DEV_RUN:", FAST_DEV_RUN)
```

```
torch 2.11.0+cu128 | device: cuda Tesla T4 | FAST_DEV_RUN: False
```

Data

The assignment subset `data_2026_A2.zip` contains the six official SemEval-2021 Task 6 files for subtasks 1 and 2. We verified byte-for-byte that they are identical to the public corpus on GitHub. So if the files are not next to the notebook, they are downloaded from a pinned commit, which keeps the notebook runnable anywhere. `task1` files hold the label set per meme (Part A) and `task2` files hold the character-offset spans (Part B).

In [2]:

```
CORPUS_COMMIT = "796b32fa76b7a5814a48d1870d163058e81e4ce1"
CORPUS_URL = f"https://raw.githubusercontent.com/di-dimitrov/SEMEVAL-2021-task6-
corpus/{CORPUS_COMMIT}"
SPLIT_FILES = {"train": "training_set", "dev": "dev_set", "test": "test_set"}


def download(url, path, attempts=6):
    """urlretrieve with retries: public mirrors occasionally time out (seen: HTTP
504 from Zenodo)."""
    import urllib.request
    for i in range(attempts):
        try:
            urllib.request.urlretrieve(url, path)
            return
        except Exception as exc:
            if i == attempts - 1:
                raise
            print(f"download failed ({exc}); retrying in {15 * (i + 1)} s")
            time.sleep(15 * (i + 1))
```

```
def find_data_dir() -> Path:
    for cand in [Path("data"), Path("Assignment 2/data"), Path("/content/data")]:
        if (cand / "training_set_task2.txt").exists():
            return cand
    target = Path("data"); target.mkdir(exist_ok=True)
    for stem in SPLIT_FILES.values():
        for task in (1, 2):
            download(f"{CORPUS_URL}/data/{stem}_task{task}.txt", target / f"
{stem}_task{task}.txt")
    download(f"{CORPUS_URL}/techniques_list_task1-2.txt", target /
"techniques_list_task1-2.txt")
    return target


DATA_DIR = find_data_dir()
raw = {split: json.loads((DATA_DIR / f"
{stem}_task2.txt").read_text(encoding="utf8"))
       for split, stem in SPLIT_FILES.items()}
raw_t1 = {split: json.loads((DATA_DIR / f"
{stem}_task1.txt").read_text(encoding="utf8"))
          for split, stem in SPLIT_FILES.items()}

# The 20 text techniques, in the official order (Transfer and Appeal to (Strong)
Emotions are image-only).
TECHNIQUES = [
    "Appeal to authority", "Appeal to fear/prejudice", "Black-and-white
Fallacy/Dictatorship",
    "Causal Oversimplification", "Doubt", "Exaggeration/Minimisation", "Flag-
waving",
    "Glittering generalities (Virtue)", "Loaded Language", "Misrepresentation of
Someone's Position (Straw Man)",
    "Name calling/Labeling", "Obfuscation, Intentional vagueness, Confusion",
    "Presenting Irrelevant Data (Red Herring)", "Reductio ad hitlerum",
"Repetition", "Slogans", "Smears",
    "Thought-terminating cliché", "Whataboutism", "Bandwagon",
]
T2I = {t: i for i, t in enumerate(TECHNIQUES)}
K = len(TECHNIQUES)
SHORT = {  # compact names for plots
    "Appeal to authority": "Authority", "Appeal to fear/prejudice":
"Fear/prejudice",
    "Black-and-white Fallacy/Dictatorship": "Black&white", "Causal
Oversimplification": "Causal oversimpl.",
    "Doubt": "Doubt", "Exaggeration/Minimisation": "Exagg./Minim.", "Flag-waving":
"Flag-waving",
    "Glittering generalities (Virtue)": "Glittering gen.", "Loaded Language":
"Loaded language",
    "Misrepresentation of Someone's Position (Straw Man)": "Straw man", "Name
calling/Labeling": "Name calling",
    "Obfuscation, Intentional vagueness, Confusion": "Obfuscation",
    "Presenting Irrelevant Data (Red Herring)": "Red herring", "Reductio ad
hitlerum": "Ad hitlerum",
    "Repetition": "Repetition", "Slogans": "Slogans", "Smears": "Smears",
    "Thought-terminating cliché": "Thought-term.", "Whataboutism": "Whataboutism",
"Bandwagon": "Bandwagon",
}


def to_frame(split: str) -> pd.DataFrame:
    rows = []
```

```
    for m in raw[split]:
        spans = [(l["start"], l["end"], l["technique"]) for l in m["labels"]]
        y = np.zeros(K, dtype=np.float32)
        for _, _, t in spans:
            y[T2I[t]] = 1
        rows.append({"id": m["id"], "split": split, "text": m["text"], "spans":
spans, "y": y})
    return pd.DataFrame(rows)


df_all = pd.concat([to_frame(s) for s in SPLIT_FILES], ignore_index=True)
print(df_all.groupby("split").size().to_dict(), "| unknown techniques:",
      {l["technique"] for s in raw for m in raw[s] for l in m["labels"]} -
set(TECHNIQUES))
```

```
{'dev': 63, 'test': 200, 'train': 688} | unknown techniques: set()
```

1. Understanding the data and where it came from

Provenance (Dimitrov et al., 2021, §4 and App. A). The memes were collected over several months in **2020** from **26 public Facebook groups**. 23 of them are about **US and Canadian politics** (left, right, centrist, anti-government, gun control) and 3 are about COVID-19, vaccines and gender equality. All memes are in English. The text was extracted with Google Vision and corrected by hand. **Six annotators** labelled it, three per meme, using the text alone, *before* seeing the image. Disagreements were settled by **discussion with a consolidator**, not by majority vote. Agreement of the three annotators against the consolidated labels had Krippendorff's α = 0.83, 0.91 and **0.56**, so one annotator diverged substantially from the final consensus.

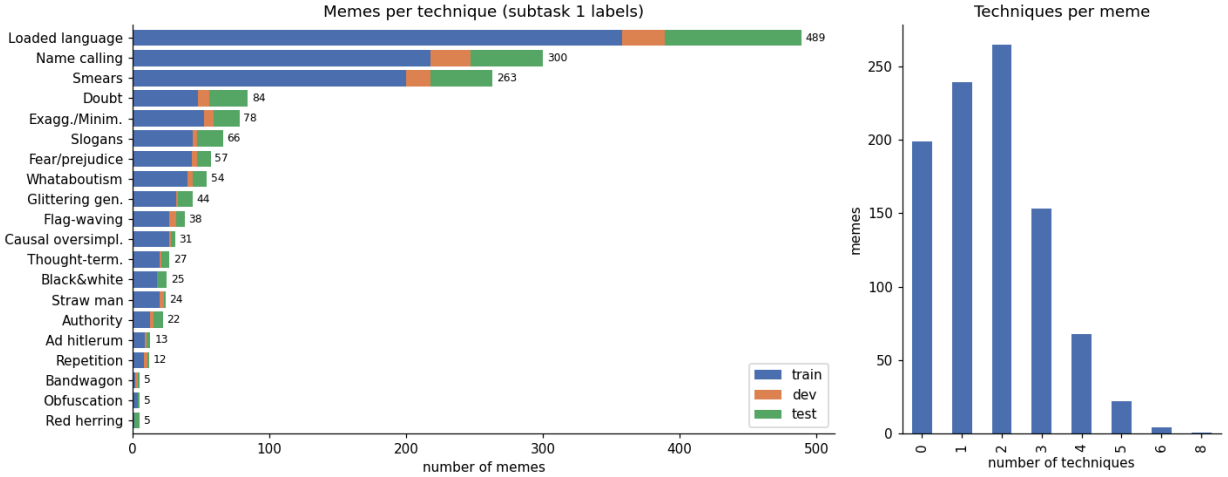
Three consequences follow. They shape later sections:

1. The gold labels are *one team's negotiated reading* of US/Canadian political memes from 2020. "Correct" means agreeing with that team, which matters for C1 (whose reading?) and C4 (Australia, 2026, teenagers).
2. Text labels were assigned without the image, which matches our deployment: we also only get the extracted text.
3. Moderate agreement puts a ceiling on achievable scores. A model cannot reliably beat human consistency.

In [3]:

```
fig, axes = plt.subplots(1, 2, figsize=(13, 5.2), gridspec_kw={"width_ratios":
[2.2, 1]})
counts = pd.DataFrame({s: np.stack(df_all[df_all.split == s].y).sum(0) for s in
SPLIT_FILES},
                      index=[SHORT[t] for t in TECHNIQUES]).astype(int)
counts = counts.loc[counts.sum(axis=1).sort_values().index]
counts.plot.barh(stacked=True, ax=axes[0], color=["#4C72B0", "#DD8452", "#55A868"],
width=0.8)
for i, v in enumerate(counts.sum(axis=1)):
    axes[0].text(v + 3, i, str(v), va="center", fontsize=8)
axes[0].set_title("Memes per technique (subtask 1 labels)");
axes[0].set_xlabel("number of memes")
n_labels = df_all.y.apply(lambda y: int(y.sum()))
n_labels.value_counts().sort_index().plot.bar(ax=axes[1], color="#4C72B0")
axes[1].set_title("Techniques per meme"); axes[1].set_xlabel("number of
```

```
techniques"); axes[1].set_ylabel("memes")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
print(f"mean techniques/meme = {n_labels.mean():.2f}; memes with none = {(n_labels
== 0).sum()} "
      f"({(n_labels == 0).mean():.0%}); train-set counts below 10: "
      f"{[SHORT[t] for t in TECHNIQUES if
np.stack(df_all[df_all.split=='train'].y).sum(0)[T2I[t]] < 10]}")
```



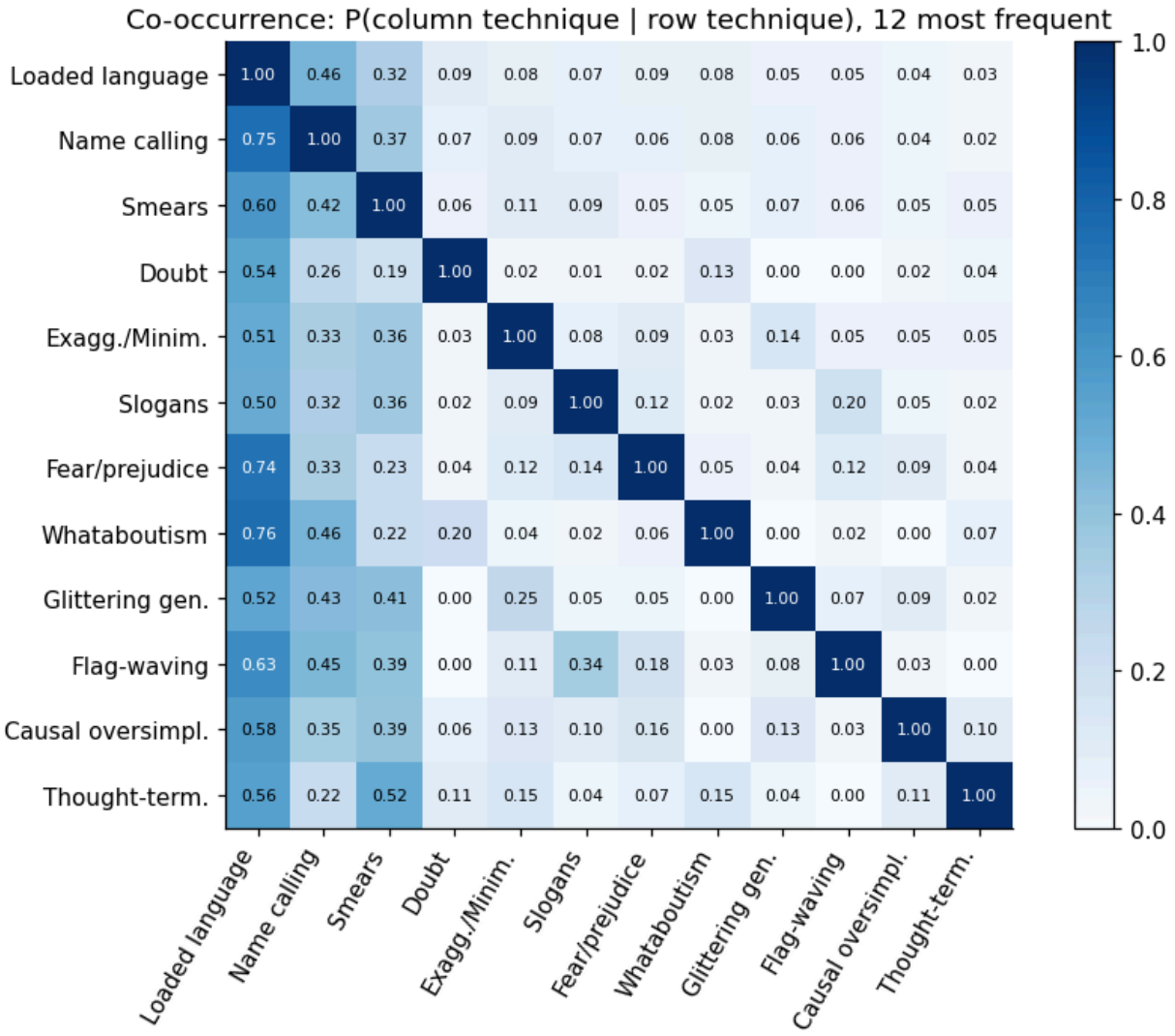

```
mean techniques/meme = 1.73; memes with none = 199 (21%); train-set counts below 10: ['Obfuscation',
'Red herring', 'Ad hitlerum', 'Repetition', 'Bandwagon']
```

Reading. The label distribution is extremely long-tailed. Three techniques (Loaded Language, Name calling, Smears) account for 64% of all labels. Five techniques have fewer than ten training memes, and *Red Herring* has a single one. Two consequences:

- **Metrics.** Micro-F1, the official metric, is dominated by the head classes, so we also report macro-F1 and per-technique F1. A tool that only ever says "Loaded Language" would look acceptable on micro-F1.
- **Expectations.** No method can learn a technique from one to four examples. We expect F1 ≈ 0 on those and plan for the tool to say so honestly rather than guess (Section 7).

In [4]:

```
Y_all = np.stack(df_all.y)
co = Y_all.T @ Y_all
cond = co / np.maximum(np.diag(co)[:, None], 1)  # P(column | row)
order = np.argsort(-np.diag(co))[:12]
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(8.5, 6.5))
im = ax.imshow(cond[np.ix_(order, order)], cmap="Blues", vmin=0, vmax=1)
ax.set_xticks(range(len(order)), [SHORT[TECHNIQUES[i]] for i in order],
rotation=60, ha="right")
ax.set_yticks(range(len(order)), [SHORT[TECHNIQUES[i]] for i in order])
for a, i in enumerate(order):
    for b, j in enumerate(order):
        ax.text(b, a, f"{cond[i, j]:.2f}", ha="center", va="center", fontsize=7,
                color="white" if cond[i, j] > 0.6 else "black")
ax.set_title("Co-occurrence: P(column technique | row technique), 12 most
frequent")
plt.colorbar(im, fraction=0.04); plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
```



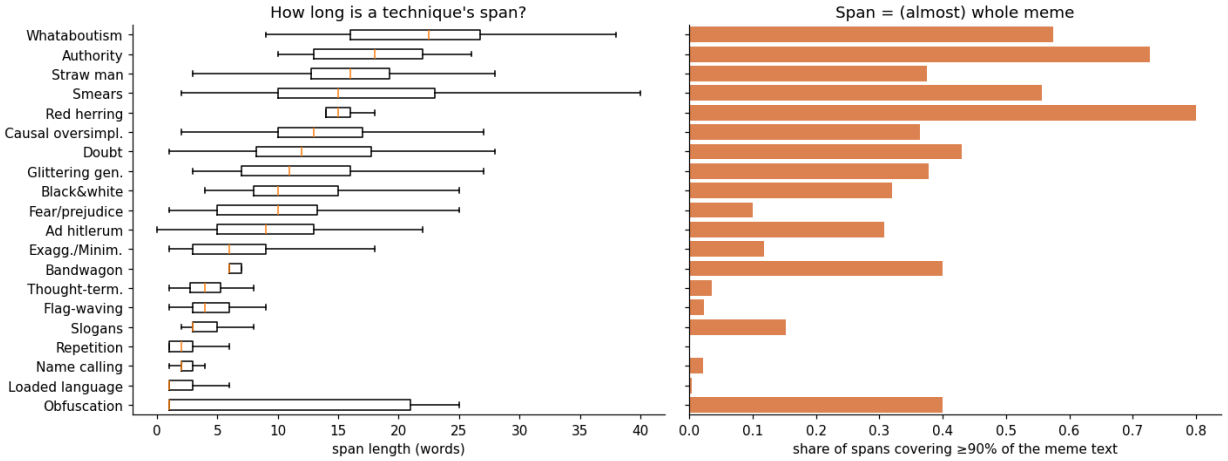
Reading. Techniques co-occur strongly. For example, a meme with *Name calling* very often also has *Loaded Language*, and *Smears* travels with both. The labels are therefore not independent, but the dependence is soft (conditional probabilities well below 1). That supports **20 independent sigmoid outputs on a shared representation**: the shared encoder can learn the correlations, and no technique is forced to exclude another (a softmax would do exactly that).

In [5]:

```
def word_len(s, e, text):
    return len(text[s:e].split())


span_rows = []
for _, r in df_all.iterrows():
    clean_len = max(len(r.text.strip()), 1)
    for s, e, t in r.spans:
        span_rows.append({"technique": SHORT[t], "words": word_len(s, e, r.text),
                          "frac_of_text": (e - s) / clean_len, "split": r.split})
spans_df = pd.DataFrame(span_rows)
stats = spans_df.groupby("technique").agg(spans=("words", "size"), median_words=
("words", "median"),
                                          whole_text_share=("frac_of_text", lambda
f: (f >= 0.9).mean()))
stats = stats.sort_values("median_words")
fig, ax = plt.subplots(1, 2, figsize=(13, 5), sharey=True)
data = [spans_df[spans_df.technique == t].words.values for t in stats.index]
```

```
ax[0].boxplot(data, orientation="horizontal", showfliers=False);
ax[0].set_yticks(range(1, len(stats) + 1), stats.index)
ax[0].set_xlabel("span length (words)"); ax[0].set_title("How long is a technique's
span?")
ax[1].barh(range(1, len(stats) + 1), stats.whole_text_share, color="#DD8452")
ax[1].set_xlabel("share of spans covering ≥90% of the meme text");
ax[1].set_title("Span = (almost) whole meme")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
print(f"{len(spans_df)} spans; {(spans_df.frac_of_text >= 0.9).mean():.0%} of them
cover ≥90% of the meme text")
```




```
2083 spans; 16% of them cover ≥90% of the meme text
```

Reading. The techniques split into two kinds:

- **Lexical** techniques (Loaded Language, Name calling, Repetition, Slogans) have spans of 1–4 words. A tagger can point at them precisely.
- **Discourse-level** techniques (Whataboutism, Doubt, Causal oversimplification, Smears, Black-and-white) usually span most of the meme. "Where is it?" is then answered by "the whole message".

This drives two things. For Part B the evaluation must accept that a span can be the whole text. For C3 we expect the label head and the span head to agree easily on lexical techniques and to disagree more on discourse-level ones, which is a hypothesis we can test.

In [6]:

```
def overlap_stats(df):
    cross, same_overlap, same_adjacent, same_pairs = 0, 0, 0, 0
    for _, r in df.iterrows():
        sp = r.spans
        for i in range(len(sp)):
            for j in range(i + 1, len(sp)):
                if sp[i][0] < sp[j][1] and sp[j][0] < sp[i][1] and sp[i][2] !=
sp[j][2]:
                    cross += 1
        by = collections.defaultdict(list)
        for s, e, t in sp:
            by[t].append((s, e))
        for v in by.values():
            v.sort()
            for a, b in zip(v, v[1:]):
                same_pairs += 1
                if b[0] < a[1]:
                    same_overlap += 1
```

```
                elif re.fullmatch(r"[\s\W]*", r.text[a[1]:b[0]]):
                    same_adjacent += 1
    return cross, same_pairs, same_overlap, same_adjacent


cross, same_pairs, same_ov, same_adj = overlap_stats(df_all)
n_spans = sum(len(s) for s in df_all.spans)
print(f"overlapping span pairs with DIFFERENT techniques: {cross}")
print(f"consecutive spans of the SAME technique in a meme: {same_pairs};
overlapping: {same_ov}; "
      f"separated only by spaces/punctuation: {same_adj} ({(same_ov + same_adj) /
n_spans:.1%} of all spans)")
```

```
overlapping span pairs with DIFFERENT techniques: 1379
consecutive spans of the SAME technique in a meme: 441; overlapping: 13; separated only by
spaces/punctuation: 51 (3.1% of all spans)
```

Decision: tagging scheme for Part B. Spans of *different* techniques overlap all the time. Standard BIO tagging gives every token a single label, so it cannot represent this. We therefore tag **each technique independently**: every token gets 20 binary "inside technique *k*?" decisions (IO tagging, one sigmoid per technique per token).

IO tagging cannot separate two *adjacent* spans of the same technique. Per-technique BIO could, at the cost of 3× the outputs and sparser B tags. The table above shows this case affects only about 3% of spans. The official scorer also gives partial credit by character overlap: one merged prediction covering two adjacent gold spans still collects almost all of their recall and precision. IO is therefore the simpler choice and loses almost nothing. We check this claim numerically once the metric is implemented (Section 2).

In [7]:
```
dupe_groups = df_all.assign(norm=df_all.text.str.lower().str.replace(r"\W+", " ",
regex=True).str.strip()) \
    .groupby("norm").filter(lambda g: len(g) > 1)
show = dupe_groups.assign(labels=dupe_groups.y.apply(lambda y:
[SHORT[TECHNIQUES[i]] for i in np.where(y)[0]]))
display(show[["id", "split", "text", "labels"]])
t1_mismatch = sum(set(a["labels"]) != {l["technique"] for l in b["labels"]}
                  for s in SPLIT_FILES for a, b in zip(raw_t1[s], raw[s]))
frag_mismatch = [m["id"] for s in raw for m in raw[s] for l in m["labels"]
                 if m["text"][l["start"]:l["end"]] != l["text_fragment"]]
print("task1 label sets that differ from the techniques present in task2 spans:",
t1_mismatch)
print("spans whose stored fragment differs from text[start:end]:",
len(frag_mismatch), sorted(set(frag_mismatch)))
```

	id	split	text	labels
55	93	train	The Real Virus Threatening America\n	[Loaded language]
91	110	train	THE REAL VIRUS THREATENING AMERICA\n	[Fear/prejudice, Flag-waving]
436	474_batch_2	train	JOE BIDEN'S LIFETIME ACCOMPLISHMENTS.	[]
466	549_batch_2	train	STILL MORE COHERENT THAN JOE BIDEN\n	[]
504	588_batch_2	train	HOW TO KILL THE CORONOVIRUS\n\nHey Hillary, I hear the Coronavirus is going to testify against you.	[Loaded language, Smears]
683	501_batch_2	train	HOW TO KILL THE CORONOVIRUS...\nHey Hillary, I hear the Coronavirus is going to testify against you.	[Smears]
704	30_batch_2	dev	STILL MORE COHERENT THAN JOE BIDEN	[]
890	474_batch_2	test	JOE BIDEN'S LIFETIME ACCOMPLISHMENTS.	[Slogans]

```
task1 label sets that differ from the techniques present in task2 spans: 0
spans whose stored fragment differs from text[start:end]: 5 ['500_batch_2', '720_batch_2',
'790_batch_2']
```

Findings that change the pipeline

- **Leakage in the official split.** Meme `474_batch_2` ("Joe Biden's lifetime accomplishments.") appears in *both* train and test, with different labels (none vs. *Slogans*). We **drop it from the training data**, so the test set stays exactly the official one and remains comparable with published results.
- **Label noise.** Identical texts carry different labels. "The real virus threatening America" is *Loaded Language* once and *Fear/prejudice + Flag-waving* the other time. The "Hey Hillary, the Coronavirus is going to testify against you" meme gains or loses *Loaded Language*. The text was annotated *without* the image, so the most plausible explanation is annotator inconsistency. This is a concrete instance of the moderate agreement reported in the paper, and it bounds achievable F1. We keep both copies: the noise is part of the task.
- **Labels and spans are consistent:** every task1 label set equals the set of techniques with at least one task2 span. A meme has technique *k* **if and only if** some part of its text is tagged *k*. This logical link between Part A and Part B motivates a joint model (Section 3) and makes the C3 disagreement question well-defined.
- A few stored `text_fragment` s do not match their offsets. We always use the **offsets**, which is what the official scorer uses.

In [8]:
```
LEAK_IDS = set(df_all[df_all.split == "train"].id) & set(df_all[df_all.split ==
"test"].id)
print("ids in both train and test:", LEAK_IDS)
df_all = df_all[~((df_all.split == "train") &
df_all.id.isin(LEAK_IDS))].reset_index(drop=True)
df_dev = df_all[df_all.split.isin(["train", "dev"])].reset_index(drop=True)   #
development pool (train + dev)
df_test = df_all[df_all.split == "test"].reset_index(drop=True)               #
untouched until Section 5
if FAST_DEV_RUN:  # local smoke test only: tiny subsets
    df_dev = df_dev.sample(150, random_state=SEED).reset_index(drop=True)
    df_test = df_test.sample(60, random_state=SEED).reset_index(drop=True)
print("development pool:", len(df_dev), "| held-out test:", len(df_test))
```

```
ids in both train and test: {'474_batch_2'}
development pool: 750 | held-out test: 200
```

Style of the text and political composition

Two properties of the text matter later. **Casing:** memes are often set in capitals, which subword tokenisers split into more, rarer pieces. **Political target:** which side a meme attacks. For the target we use a transparent keyword heuristic. It is used *only for analysis* (C1, C4), never inside the classifier, as the specification requires.

In [9]:
```
LEFT_TERMS = r"\b(biden|obama|hillary|clinton|democrat\w*|dems?
|liberal\w*|leftist\w*|libtard\w*|kamala|harris|pelosi|bernie|sanders|aoc|antifa|soc
RIGHT_TERMS = r"\b(trump\w*|republican\w*|conservative\w*|maga|gop|pence|right[-
]wing\w*|mcconnell|trumpster\w*)\b"


def political_target(text: str) -> str:
    t = text.lower()
    left, right = bool(re.search(LEFT_TERMS, t)), bool(re.search(RIGHT_TERMS, t))
```

```
    return "both" if left and right else "left-figures" if left else "right-
figures" if right else "neither"


def upper_ratio(text: str) -> float:
    letters = [c for c in text if c.isalpha()]
    return sum(c.isupper() for c in letters) / max(len(letters), 1)


df_all["target"] = df_all.text.apply(political_target)
df_all["mostly_caps"] = df_all.text.apply(upper_ratio) > 0.7
df_dev["target"] = df_dev.text.apply(political_target); df_test["target"] =
df_test.text.apply(political_target)
comp = pd.crosstab(df_all.split, df_all.target)
display(comp)
by_side = df_all[df_all.target.isin(["left-figures", "right-figures"])]
rate = pd.DataFrame({side: np.stack(g.y).mean(0) for side, g in
by_side.groupby("target")},
                    index=[SHORT[t] for t in TECHNIQUES])
rate["n"] = 0
rate = rate.loc[rate[["left-figures", "right-
figures"]].max(axis=1).sort_values(ascending=False).index[:8]]
display(rate.drop(columns="n").style.format("{:.2f}").set_caption(
    "Share of memes carrying each technique, by which side's figures are named (all
splits)"))
print(f"memes mostly in capitals: {df_all.mostly_caps.mean():.0%}")
```

target split	both	left-figures	neither	right-figures
dev	2	8	40	13
test	11	34	130	25
train	32	117	474	64

Share of memes carrying each technique, by which side's figures are named (all splits)

	left-figures	right-figures
Loaded language	0.48	0.53
Smears	0.50	0.39
Name calling	0.36	0.36
Glittering gen.	0.03	0.15
Slogans	0.09	0.12
Exagg./Minim.	0.09	0.10
Whataboutism	0.04	0.08
Doubt	0.07	0.05

```
memes mostly in capitals: 49%
```

Reading. Memes naming left-wing figures outnumber memes naming right-wing figures roughly 3:2. Also, about two thirds of memes name neither side. The *gold* rates of techniques also differ by side. Does this reflect the memes, or the annotators' reading of them? The data alone cannot separate the two. Either way, a model trained on it can inherit the asymmetry, which is what C1 tests directly. About half of the memes are written mostly in capitals, while a teenager's feed in 2026 is mostly mixed case. This is a style shift we test in E8 and C4.

Summary: data → design

Observation	Design consequence
750 development memes, 63 official dev memes	5-fold cross-validation on train+dev; official test (200) touched once
Long tail: 5 techniques < 10 training memes	macro-F1 and per-technique F1 reported; class weighting tested (E5); honest "not supported" list

Observation	Design consequence
Labels co-occur, but softly	20 sigmoid outputs on a shared encoder
Spans overlap across techniques; same-technique adjacency ≈ 3%	per-technique IO tagging
Label ⇔ at least one span (100%)	joint model; label/span consistency is measurable (C3)
Lexical vs. discourse-level techniques	technique-specific attention in the label head (Section 3)
Leak `474_batch_2`; duplicated texts with conflicting labels	leak removed from training; noise acknowledged as ceiling
Half the memes in capitals; US politics 2020	casing robustness (E8); C1 and C4

2. Evaluation framework

2.1 What we measure, and why

Part A (labels).

- **Micro-F1** is the official SemEval metric. Using it makes us comparable with the 2021 leaderboard (best .593, majority baseline .374).
- **Macro-F1** weights the 20 techniques equally. Didactically a missed *Straw man* matters as much as a missed *Loaded Language*, and macro-F1 exposes a model that ignores the tail.
- **Per-technique F1** tells the teacher *which* labels to trust.

Precision and recall are reported separately. In a classroom a false accusation ("this meme smears someone") is more damaging than a missed technique, so we look at the precision side explicitly.

Part B (spans). We use the official SemEval-2021 subtask-2 measure. It gives partial credit for character overlap, and credit counts only when the technique matches. With predicted spans p and gold spans g of the same technique, $P = \frac{1}{|\text{pred}|} \sum_p \sum_g \frac{|p \cap g|}{|p|}$ and $R = \frac{1}{|\text{gold}|} \sum_g \sum_p \frac{|p \cap g|}{|g|}$. F1 is their harmonic mean. We re-implement it in a few lines so it can run inside the training loop. Below we **verify it against the official scorer** on the same inputs.

In [10]:
```
def label_scores(Y_true: np.ndarray, Y_pred: np.ndarray) -> dict:
    return {
        "micro_f1": f1_score(Y_true, Y_pred, average="micro", zero_division=0),
        "macro_f1": f1_score(Y_true, Y_pred, average="macro", zero_division=0),
        "micro_p": precision_score(Y_true, Y_pred, average="micro",
zero_division=0),
        "micro_r": recall_score(Y_true, Y_pred, average="micro", zero_division=0),
    }


def per_technique_f1(Y_true, Y_pred) -> pd.Series:
    return pd.Series(f1_score(Y_true, Y_pred, average=None, zero_division=0,
labels=range(K)),
                     index=[SHORT[t] for t in TECHNIQUES])


def span_scores(gold: list, pred: list) -> dict:
    """Official SemEval-2021 subtask-2 measure. gold/pred: per meme a list of
(start, end, technique)."""
```

```
    p_num = r_num = 0.0
    n_pred = sum(len(p) for p in pred); n_gold = sum(len(g) for g in gold)
    for g_spans, p_spans in zip(gold, pred):
        for ps, pe, pt in p_spans:
            for gs, ge, gt in g_spans:
                if pt == gt:
                    inter = max(0, min(pe, ge) - max(ps, gs))
                    p_num += inter / (pe - ps)
                    r_num += inter / (ge - gs)
    p = p_num / n_pred if n_pred else 0.0
    r = r_num / n_gold if n_gold else 0.0
    f1 = 1.0 if n_pred == 0 and n_gold == 0 else (2 * p * r / (p + r) if p > 0 and
r > 0 else 0.0)
    return {"span_f1": f1, "span_p": p, "span_r": r}
```

2.2 Tokenisation and span ↔ token alignment

The gold spans are character offsets, and transformers see sub-word tokens. A token is labelled *inside technique k* if any of its (whitespace-trimmed) characters fall inside a gold span of *k*. To decode, each maximal run of tokens above the threshold for *k* becomes one predicted span, from the first token's first character to the last token's last character. Some tokenisers (e.g. DeBERTa) include the leading space in a token's offsets, so offsets are trimmed first.

In [11]:

```
MAX_LEN = 160  # longest meme is 142 RoBERTa tokens


def trimmed_offsets(text, offsets):
    out = []
    for a, b in offsets:
        while a < b and text[a].isspace():
            a += 1
        while b > a and text[b - 1].isspace():
            b -= 1
        out.append((a, b))
    return out


def token_labels(text, offsets, spans):
    """offsets already trimmed; returns (T, K) float array, special tokens (a == b)
all-zero."""
    lab = np.zeros((len(offsets), K), dtype=np.float32)
    for i, (a, b) in enumerate(offsets):
        if a == b:
            continue
        for s, e, t in spans:
            if a < e and s < b:
                lab[i, T2I[t]] = 1
    return lab


def decode_spans(offsets, probs, thr, text=None):
    """probs: (T, K) token probabilities; thr: scalar or (K,) thresholds -> list of
(start, end, technique).
    If the text is given, spans without any letter or digit (a lone '.' or '!') are
dropped: nothing to point at."""
    thr = np.broadcast_to(np.asarray(thr, dtype=np.float32), (K,))
```

```
    spans = []
    for k in range(K):
        start = end = None
        for (a, b), p in zip(offsets, probs[:, k]):
            if a == b:          # special / padding token
                continue
            if p > thr[k]:
                start = a if start is None else start
                end = b
            elif start is not None:
                spans.append((start, end, TECHNIQUES[k])); start = None
        if start is not None:
            spans.append((start, end, TECHNIQUES[k]))
    if text is not None:
        spans = [sp for sp in spans if any(c.isalnum() for c in text[sp[0]:sp[1]])]
    return spans


def tokenize_frame(df, tok):
    enc = tok(list(df.text), truncation=True, max_length=MAX_LEN,
return_offsets_mapping=True)
    offs = [trimmed_offsets(t, o) for t, o in zip(df.text, enc["offset_mapping"])]
    labs = [token_labels(t, o, s) for t, o, s in zip(df.text, offs, df.spans)]
    return {"input_ids": enc["input_ids"], "offsets": offs, "token_labels": labs}
```

Two checks before trusting any number.

1. *Representation ceiling.* Convert every gold span to token IO tags with the RoBERTa tokeniser, decode back, and score against the original spans. This is the best Part-B score any IO tagger could reach. It quantifies what the IO decision from Section 1 costs.
2. *Metric correctness.* Score the same predictions with our implementation and with the official scorer (`propaganda-techniques-scorer`, the commit pinned by the SemEval repository).

In [12]:

```
TOK_CHECK = AutoTokenizer.from_pretrained("roberta-base")
enc_dev = tokenize_frame(df_dev, TOK_CHECK)
roundtrip = [decode_spans(o, l, 0.5) for o, l in zip(enc_dev["offsets"],
enc_dev["token_labels"])]
print("IO representation ceiling on the development pool:",
      {k: round(v, 4) for k, v in span_scores(list(df_dev.spans),
roundtrip).items()})


def official_span_score(gold_df, pred_spans):
    """Runs the official SemEval-2021 task-2 scorer; returns F1 or None if it
cannot be fetched."""
    repo = Path("propaganda-techniques-scorer")
    try:
        if not repo.exists():
            subprocess.run(["git", "clone", "-q",
"https://gitlab.com/joedsm/propaganda-techniques-scorer.git",
                            str(repo)], check=True, timeout=120)
            subprocess.run(["git", "-C", str(repo), "checkout", "-q",
"05fe8d38c4a729dfea749e401456ef35b8476cf4"],
                           check=True)
        to_json = lambda spans_list: [{"id": i, "labels": [{"start": s, "end": e,
"technique": t} for s, e, t in sp]}
```

```
                                        for i, sp in zip(gold_df.id, spans_list)]
        Path("_gold.json").write_text(json.dumps(to_json(list(gold_df.spans))),
encoding="utf8")
        Path("_pred.json").write_text(json.dumps(to_json(pred_spans)),
encoding="utf8")
        Path("_techniques.txt").write_text("\n".join(TECHNIQUES) + "\n",
encoding="utf8")
        out = subprocess.run([sys.executable, "task-2-semeval21_scorer.py", "-s",
"../_pred.json", "-r", "../_gold.json",
                              "-p", "../_techniques.txt", "-o"], cwd=repo,
capture_output=True, text=True, timeout=300,
                             env={**os.environ, "PYTHONUTF8": "1"})
        return float(out.stdout.strip().split("\t")[0])
    except Exception as exc:  # no network / git: the check is skipped, not faked
        print("official scorer unavailable:", type(exc).__name__, exc)
        return None


# Sanity predictions with partial overlaps: shift every gold span by 3 characters
and drop every third one.
perturbed = [[(s + 3, e + 3, t) for j, (s, e, t) in enumerate(sp) if j % 3] for sp
in df_dev.spans]
for name, pred in [("IO round-trip", roundtrip), ("shifted+dropped", perturbed)]:
    ours = span_scores(list(df_dev.spans), pred)["span_f1"]
    print(f"{name:16s} ours={ours:.6f} official={official_span_score(df_dev,
pred)}")
```

```
Warning: You are sending unauthenticated requests to the HF Hub. Please set a HF_TOKEN to enable
higher rate limits and faster downloads.
IO representation ceiling on the development pool: {'span_f1': 1.0002, 'span_p': 1.0015, 'span_r':
0.999}
IO round-trip    ours=1.000212 official=1.000212
shifted+dropped  ours=0.526215 official=0.526215
```

2.3 Data splits

- **Test (200 memes, official split)** is held out and used **once**, in Section 5. Every choice before that (encoder, adaptation, head, loss, hyper-parameters, thresholds) is made on the development pool. Otherwise the test number would be optimistically biased, which is exactly the "leaky evaluation" that makes a deployment claim meaningless.
- The official dev set (63 memes) is too small to select models with. One meme changes micro-F1 by about 1 point, and several techniques have zero dev examples. We therefore pool train and dev (750 memes) and use **5-fold cross-validation**. Every model comparison is then made on 750 out-of-fold predictions instead of 63, and is **paired**: all configurations see identical folds, so we can compare them fold by fold.
- Folds are built with **iterative stratification** (Sechidis et al., 2011). It balances all 20 labels across folds at once, so rare techniques appear in every fold where possible. A random split could leave a fold with no example of a technique.

The test set is still in-distribution: same Facebook groups, same months, same annotators. The test score therefore estimates performance *on 2020 US/Canadian Facebook memes*, not on an Australian Year 10 feed. That gap is measured separately in C4 rather than assumed away.

In [13]:

```
def iterative_stratification(Y: np.ndarray, n_folds: int, seed: int = SEED) ->
np.ndarray:
```

```
    """Sechidis et al. (2011): assign examples so every label is spread evenly over
folds. Returns fold id per row."""
    rng = np.random.RandomState(seed)
    n = len(Y)
    fold = -np.ones(n, dtype=int)
    desired = np.full(n_folds, n / n_folds)
    desired_label = np.tile(Y.sum(0) / n_folds, (n_folds, 1))
    remaining = np.ones(n, dtype=bool)
    while remaining.any():
        counts = Y[remaining].sum(0)
        if counts.sum() == 0:  # rows without labels: fill folds by remaining
capacity
            for i in rng.permutation(np.where(remaining)[0]):
                f = rng.choice(np.flatnonzero(desired == desired.max())); fold[i] =
f; desired[f] -= 1
            break
        lab = np.argmin(np.where(counts > 0, counts, np.inf))       # rarest label
still unassigned
        for i in rng.permutation(np.where(remaining & (Y[:, lab] == 1))[0]):
            cand = np.flatnonzero(desired_label[:, lab] == desired_label[:,
lab].max())
            if len(cand) > 1:
                cand = cand[desired[cand] == desired[cand].max()]
            f = rng.choice(cand)
            fold[i] = f; remaining[i] = False
            desired[f] -= 1; desired_label[f] -= Y[i]
    return fold


N_FOLDS = 2 if FAST_DEV_RUN else 5
Y_dev = np.stack(df_dev.y)
df_dev["fold"] = iterative_stratification(Y_dev, N_FOLDS)
fold_tab = pd.DataFrame({f: Y_dev[df_dev.fold == f].sum(0) for f in
range(N_FOLDS)},
                        index=[SHORT[t] for t in TECHNIQUES]).astype(int)
fold_tab.insert(0, "total", Y_dev.sum(0).astype(int))
display(fold_tab.T.style.set_caption("Memes per technique in each fold (iterative
stratification)"))
```

Memes per technique in each fold (iterative strati

	Authority	Fear/prejudice	Black&white	Causal oversimpl.	Doubt	Exagg./Minim.	Flag-waving	Glittering gen.	Loaded language	Straw man	Name calling	Obfu
total	15	47	18	28	56	59	32	33	389	23	247	
0	3	9	4	5	11	11	6	6	78	4	50	
1	3	9	4	6	12	12	7	7	78	5	49	
2	3	9	3	6	11	12	6	7	78	5	50	
3	3	10	3	5	11	12	6	6	77	4	49	
4	3	10	4	6	11	12	7	7	78	5	49	

2.4 Uncertainty

With 200 test memes a difference of a few F1 points can be noise. Test-set numbers therefore get a **95% bootstrap confidence interval** (1,000 resamples of memes). Model comparisons on the development pool use the **fold-paired difference** (mean ± standard deviation over the five folds). A configuration is called better only if it wins consistently, not just on average.

In [14]:
```
def bootstrap_ci(metric_fn, *arrays, n_boot=1000, seed=SEED):
    rng = np.random.RandomState(seed)
```

```
    n = len(arrays[0]); vals = []
    for _ in range(n_boot):
        idx = rng.randint(0, n, n)
        vals.append(metric_fn(*[[a[i] for i in idx] if isinstance(a, list) else
a[idx] for a in arrays]))
    return np.percentile(vals, [2.5, 97.5])
```

2.5 Trivial baselines (the floor any model must clear)

- **Majority:** every meme gets *Loaded Language*, and for spans the whole text is tagged as Loaded Language.
- **Prior-random:** each technique is predicted independently with its training frequency (averaged over 50 draws). For spans, the whole text gets the sampled techniques.

Both are computed out-of-fold: the frequencies come from the fold's training part only.

In [15]:
```
def whole_text_spans(text, techs):
    s = len(text) - len(text.lstrip()); e = len(text.rstrip())
    return [(s, e, t) for t in techs] if e > s else []


rng = np.random.RandomState(SEED)
base_rows = []
for f in range(N_FOLDS):
    tr, va = df_dev[df_dev.fold != f], df_dev[df_dev.fold == f]
    Yva = np.stack(va.y); prior = np.stack(tr.y).mean(0)
    maj = np.zeros_like(Yva); maj[:, T2I["Loaded Language"]] = 1
    maj_sp = [whole_text_spans(t, ["Loaded Language"]) for t in va.text]
    base_rows.append({"baseline": "majority", "fold": f, **label_scores(Yva, maj),
**span_scores(list(va.spans), maj_sp)})
    for d in range(50):
        rnd = (rng.rand(*Yva.shape) < prior).astype(int)
        rnd_sp = [whole_text_spans(t, [TECHNIQUES[k] for k in np.where(r)[0]]) for
t, r in zip(va.text, rnd)]
        base_rows.append({"baseline": "prior-random", "fold": f,
**label_scores(Yva, rnd),
                          **span_scores(list(va.spans), rnd_sp)})
baselines = pd.DataFrame(base_rows).groupby("baseline")[["micro_f1", "macro_f1",
"micro_p", "micro_r", "span_f1"]].mean()
display(baselines.style.format("{:.3f}").set_caption("Baselines, 5-fold out-of-fold
on the development pool"))
```

Baselines, 5-fold out-of-fold on the development pool

baseline	micro_f1	macro_f1	micro_p	micro_r	span_f1
majority	0.378	0.034	0.519	0.298	0.157
prior-random	0.282	0.084	0.283	0.282	0.142

3. Model

3.1 Architecture

```
  meme text ──► pretrained encoder (frozen / LoRA / fully fine-
tuned) ──► contextual token vectors H (T × d)

                                    │
┌──────────────────────────────────┴──────────────────────────────────┐
```

```
                    [self-built] LABEL HEAD (Part A)
        [self-built] SPAN HEAD (Part B)
           one learned query per technique attends over the tokens
        per token: d → 256 → 20 sigmoids
           → 20 technique-specific summaries → 20 sigmoids
        ("is this token inside technique k?")
```

Why one shared encoder with two heads (multi-task)?

- Only 750 training memes. Both tasks need the same competence, recognising persuasive language, so sharing the encoder lets each task regularise the other (Caruana, 1997). The span loss gives the encoder dense, token-level supervision about *which words* carry each label, which the meme-level label alone cannot provide.
- The data showed that a meme has a technique **iff** it has a span for it. One model keeps both outputs in one place, and the remaining disagreement can be measured (C3).
- Deployment: one encoder pass serves both outputs, which halves latency and memory on the school T4.

The alternatives (two separate models; deriving labels as "any token tagged") are tested in E3, not assumed away.

Why technique-specific (label-wise) attention in the label head? Section 1 showed that lexical techniques live in 1–3 words while discourse techniques span the whole meme. A single `[CLS]` vector must summarise all of them at once. Label-wise attention (as in CAML, Mullenbach et al., 2018) gives each technique its own query vector, so *Name calling* can attend to the insult and *Whataboutism* to the "what about…" clause. A useful side effect: the attention weights show which words the label head relied on, which feeds the explainability analysis and C3. We compare it with `[CLS]` and mean pooling in E4.

The self-built segment is both heads plus the joint loss below. They are designed, initialised and trained from scratch, and their variants are tuned in Section 4.

In [16]:

```
ENCODERS = {
    "roberta-base": {"hf": "roberta-base", "amp": True},
    # RoBERTa further pre-trained (MLM only, no labels) on 2020-2021 tweets: same
era and register as the memes.
    "twitter-roberta-2021": {"hf": "cardiffnlp/twitter-roberta-base-2021-124m",
"amp": True},
    # Stronger general encoder (disentangled attention). Mixed precision is used;
the gradient scaler guards overflow.
    "deberta-v3-base": {"hf": "microsoft/deberta-v3-base", "amp": True},
}
if FAST_DEV_RUN:
    ENCODERS = {k: {"hf": "distilroberta-base", "amp": True} for k in ENCODERS}


class LabelAttentionHead(nn.Module):
    """Label-wise attention: each technique k has a query q_k; logit_k = w_k ·
sum_t softmax_t(q_k·key_t) h_t + b_k."""

    def __init__(self, d, k, dropout):
```

```
        super().__init__()
        self.key = nn.Sequential(nn.Linear(d, d), nn.Tanh())
        self.query = nn.Parameter(torch.randn(k, d) * d ** -0.5)
        self.out_w = nn.Parameter(torch.randn(k, d) * d ** -0.5)
        self.out_b = nn.Parameter(torch.zeros(k))
        self.drop = nn.Dropout(dropout)

    def forward(self, H, mask):
        scores = torch.einsum("btd,kd->bkt", self.key(self.drop(H)), self.query) /
math.sqrt(H.size(-1))
        att = scores.masked_fill(~mask[:, None, :],
torch.finfo(scores.dtype).min).softmax(-1)
        pooled = torch.einsum("bkt,btd->bkd", att, H)
        return (self.drop(pooled) * self.out_w).sum(-1) + self.out_b, att


class PooledHead(nn.Module):
    """Baseline label heads: [CLS] vector or masked mean of token vectors, then a
2-layer MLP."""

    def __init__(self, d, k, dropout, pooling):
        super().__init__()
        self.pooling = pooling
        self.mlp = nn.Sequential(nn.Dropout(dropout), nn.Linear(d, d), nn.GELU(),
nn.Dropout(dropout), nn.Linear(d, k))

    def forward(self, H, mask):
        if self.pooling == "cls":
            v = H[:, 0]
        else:
            m = mask.unsqueeze(-1).to(H.dtype)
            v = (H * m).sum(1) / m.sum(1).clamp(min=1)
        return self.mlp(v), None


class LoRALinear(nn.Module):
    """LoRA (Hu et al., 2022): y = W x + (alpha / r) * B A x, with W frozen and
only A (r x d_in), B (d_out x r) trained.
    B starts at zero, so training starts exactly from the pretrained encoder."""

    def __init__(self, base: nn.Linear, r: int, alpha: float, dropout: float =
0.1):
        super().__init__()
        self.base = base
        for p in self.base.parameters():
            p.requires_grad = False
        self.A = nn.Parameter(torch.randn(r, base.in_features) /
math.sqrt(base.in_features))
        self.B = nn.Parameter(torch.zeros(base.out_features, r))
        self.scale, self.drop = alpha / r, nn.Dropout(dropout)

    def forward(self, x):
        return self.base(x) + (self.drop(x) @ self.A.t() @ self.B.t()) * self.scale


def add_lora(encoder, r, targets):
    for p in encoder.parameters():
        p.requires_grad = False
    for name, module in list(encoder.named_modules()):
        for child_name, child in list(module.named_children()):
```

```
            if child_name in targets and isinstance(child, nn.Linear):
                setattr(module, child_name, LoRALinear(child, r, alpha=2 * r))


class PersuasionModel(nn.Module):
    def __init__(self, cfg):
        super().__init__()
        self.cfg = cfg
        # .float(): some checkpoints (e.g. DeBERTa-v3) are stored in fp16 and
recent transformers keep that dtype.
        self.encoder = AutoModel.from_pretrained(ENCODERS[cfg["encoder"]]
["hf"]).float()
        d = self.encoder.config.hidden_size
        if cfg.get("init_encoder") == "ptc":  # encoder after intermediate training
on PTC news (E9)
            self.encoder.load_state_dict(PTC_ENCODER_STATE[cfg["encoder"]])
        if cfg["adaptation"] == "frozen":
            for p in self.encoder.parameters():
                p.requires_grad = False
        elif cfg["adaptation"] == "lora":
            add_lora(self.encoder, cfg["lora_r"], targets=("query", "value",
"query_proj", "value_proj"))
        head = cfg["label_head"]
        self.label_head = (LabelAttentionHead(d, K, cfg["dropout"]) if head ==
"label_attention"
                           else PooledHead(d, K, cfg["dropout"], head) if head in
("cls", "mean") else None)
        self.span_head = (nn.Sequential(nn.Dropout(cfg["dropout"]), nn.Linear(d,
256), nn.GELU(),
                                        nn.Dropout(cfg["dropout"]), nn.Linear(256,
K))
                          if cfg["span_loss_weight"] > 0 or head == "from_spans"
else None)

    def forward(self, input_ids, attention_mask, token_mask):
        H = self.encoder(input_ids=input_ids,
attention_mask=attention_mask).last_hidden_state
        span_logits = self.span_head(H) if self.span_head is not None else None
        att = None
        if self.label_head is not None:
            label_logits, att = self.label_head(H, attention_mask.bool())
        else:  # "from_spans": a meme has technique k iff some token is tagged k  -
>  max over tokens
            label_logits = span_logits.masked_fill(~token_mask[..., None],
-1e4).max(1).values
        return label_logits, span_logits, att
```

3.2 Objective

$\mathcal{L} = \alpha\,\mathcal{L}_{\text{label}} + \lambda\,\mathcal{L}_{\text{span}}$, with α = λ = 1 unless an ablation switches one task off. Both terms are binary cross-entropies (multi-label, one sigmoid per technique).

- The **span term** averages over real tokens only (special and padding tokens are masked).
- **Class imbalance** (E5) is handled by one of: plain BCE; BCE with a per-technique positive weight $w_k = \sqrt{N_{neg,k}/N_{pos,k}}$ (square root, so a technique with 4 examples

does not get a 180× weight that destabilises training); or focal loss (Lin et al., 2017), which down-weights easy negatives.

In [17]:
```
def bce_loss(logits, targets, pos_weight=None, focal_gamma=0.0, mask=None):
    loss = F.binary_cross_entropy_with_logits(logits, targets,
pos_weight=pos_weight, reduction="none")
    if focal_gamma > 0:
        p = torch.sigmoid(logits)
        p_t = p * targets + (1 - p) * (1 - targets)
        loss = loss * (1 - p_t) ** focal_gamma
    if mask is not None:
        loss = loss[mask]
    return loss.mean()
```

3.3 Data pipeline and training loop

- **Dynamic padding** per batch: memes are short (median 28 tokens), so padding to 160 would waste ~80% of compute.
- **Optional casing augmentation** (E8): with probability *p* a training meme is shown upper-cased, lower-cased or sentence-cased. Changing case does not move character offsets, so the spans stay valid.
- **AdamW**, linear warm-up (10%) and decay, gradient clipping at 1.0, mixed precision on GPU. Encoder and heads get separate learning rates: the heads start from random weights and need larger steps.
- **Model selection per fold**: after every epoch we score the validation fold. We keep the epoch with the best average of label micro-F1 and span F1 (each at its best threshold on that fold), with early stopping after `patience` epochs without improvement. Because this epoch choice uses the validation fold, out-of-fold numbers are slightly optimistic. They are used only to *compare* configurations; the unbiased number is the test set.

In [18]:
```
def recase(text, rng):
    r = rng.rand()
    return text.upper() if r < 1 / 3 else text.lower() if r < 2 / 3 else
text[:1].upper() + text[1:].lower()


class MemeDataset(torch.utils.data.Dataset):
    def __init__(self, df, tok, casing_aug=0.0, seed=SEED):
        self.df, self.tok, self.casing_aug = df.reset_index(drop=True), tok,
casing_aug
        self.rng = np.random.RandomState(seed)
        self.cache = tokenize_frame(self.df, tok)

    def __len__(self):
        return len(self.df)

    def __getitem__(self, i):
        if self.casing_aug > 0 and self.rng.rand() < self.casing_aug:
            row = self.df.iloc[[i]].copy()
            row["text"] = recase(row.text.iloc[0], self.rng)
            enc = tokenize_frame(row, self.tok)
            ids, offs, lab = enc["input_ids"][0], enc["offsets"][0],
enc["token_labels"][0]
```

```
        else:
            ids, offs, lab = self.cache["input_ids"][i], self.cache["offsets"][i],
self.cache["token_labels"][i]
        return {"ids": ids, "offs": offs, "lab": lab, "y": self.df.y.iloc[i],
"idx": i}


def make_collate(pad_id):
    def collate(batch):
        T = max(len(b["ids"]) for b in batch)
        n = len(batch)
        ids = torch.full((n, T), pad_id, dtype=torch.long)
        att = torch.zeros((n, T), dtype=torch.long)
        tmask = torch.zeros((n, T), dtype=torch.bool)
        tlab = torch.zeros((n, T, K))
        for j, b in enumerate(batch):
            L = len(b["ids"])
            ids[j, :L] = torch.tensor(b["ids"]); att[j, :L] = 1
            tmask[j, :L] = torch.tensor([a < c for a, c in b["offs"]])
            tlab[j, :L] = torch.from_numpy(b["lab"])
        y = torch.from_numpy(np.stack([b["y"] for b in batch]))
        return {"input_ids": ids, "attention_mask": att, "token_mask": tmask,
"token_labels": tlab, "y": y,
                "idx": [b["idx"] for b in batch], "offs": [b["offs"] for b in
batch]}
    return collate


@torch.no_grad()
def predict(model, loader, amp):
    model.eval()
    label_p, token_p, offsets, atts = [], [], [], []
    for b in loader:
        with torch.autocast("cuda", dtype=torch.float16, enabled=amp and
DEVICE.type == "cuda"):
            ll, sl, att = model(b["input_ids"].to(DEVICE),
b["attention_mask"].to(DEVICE), b["token_mask"].to(DEVICE))
        label_p.append(torch.sigmoid(ll.float()).cpu().numpy())
        for j, offs in enumerate(b["offs"]):
            L = len(offs)
            token_p.append(torch.sigmoid(sl[j, :L].float()).cpu().numpy() if sl is
not None else None)
            offsets.append(offs)
            atts.append(att[j, :, :L].float().cpu().numpy() if att is not None else
None)
    return np.concatenate(label_p), token_p, offsets, atts


LABEL_THR_GRID = np.round(np.arange(0.10, 0.91, 0.05), 2)
SPAN_THR_GRID = np.round(np.arange(0.20, 0.81, 0.10), 2)


def best_label_thr(Y, P):
    scores = [f1_score(Y, P >= t, average="micro", zero_division=0) for t in
LABEL_THR_GRID]
    i = int(np.argmax(scores)); return LABEL_THR_GRID[i], scores[i]


def spans_from_probs(token_p, offsets, thr, texts=None):
    texts = texts if texts is not None else [None] * len(offsets)
```

```
    return [decode_spans(o, p, thr, t) if p is not None else [] for o, p, t in
zip(offsets, token_p, texts)]


def best_span_thr(gold_spans, token_p, offsets, texts=None):
    if token_p[0] is None:
        return None, float("nan")
    scores = [span_scores(gold_spans, spans_from_probs(token_p, offsets, t, texts))
["span_f1"] for t in SPAN_THR_GRID]
    i = int(np.argmax(scores)); return SPAN_THR_GRID[i], scores[i]


DEFAULT_CFG = {
    "encoder": "roberta-base", "adaptation": "full", "lora_r": 16, "label_head":
"label_attention",
    "label_loss_weight": 1.0, "span_loss_weight": 1.0, "loss": "bce",
"focal_gamma": 2.0,
    "lr_encoder": 3e-5, "lr_head": 5e-4, "weight_decay": 0.01, "dropout": 0.1,
    "epochs": 15, "patience": 4, "batch_size": 16, "warmup": 0.1, "casing_aug":
0.0, "init_encoder": None,
    "seed": SEED,
}
if FAST_DEV_RUN:
    DEFAULT_CFG.update(epochs=1, patience=1)


def train_fold(cfg, df_tr, df_va, tok, keep_model=False):
    seed_everything(cfg["seed"])
    amp = ENCODERS[cfg["encoder"]]["amp"] and DEVICE.type == "cuda"
    collate = make_collate(tok.pad_token_id)
    g = torch.Generator(); g.manual_seed(cfg["seed"])
    dl_tr = torch.utils.data.DataLoader(MemeDataset(df_tr, tok, cfg["casing_aug"],
cfg["seed"]),
                                        batch_size=cfg["batch_size"], shuffle=True,
collate_fn=collate, generator=g)
    dl_va = torch.utils.data.DataLoader(MemeDataset(df_va, tok), batch_size=64,
collate_fn=collate)
    model = PersuasionModel(cfg).to(DEVICE)
    Ytr = np.stack(df_tr.y)
    pos, neg = Ytr.sum(0), len(Ytr) - Ytr.sum(0)
    pw = torch.tensor(np.sqrt(neg / np.maximum(pos, 1)), dtype=torch.float32,
device=DEVICE) \
        if cfg["loss"] == "bce_pw" else None
    gamma = cfg["focal_gamma"] if cfg["loss"] == "focal" else 0.0
    enc_params = [p for p in model.encoder.parameters() if p.requires_grad]
    head_params = [p for n, p in model.named_parameters() if not
n.startswith("encoder.") and p.requires_grad]
    groups = [{"params": head_params, "lr": cfg["lr_head"]}]
    if enc_params:
        groups.append({"params": enc_params, "lr": cfg["lr_encoder"] if
cfg["adaptation"] == "full" else cfg["lr_head"]})
    opt = torch.optim.AdamW(groups, weight_decay=cfg["weight_decay"])
    steps = cfg["epochs"] * len(dl_tr)
    sched = get_linear_schedule_with_warmup(opt, int(cfg["warmup"] * steps), steps)
    scaler = torch.amp.GradScaler("cuda", enabled=amp)
    Yva, gold_va = np.stack(df_va.y), list(df_va.spans)
    best, best_state, history, bad = -1, None, [], 0
    for epoch in range(cfg["epochs"]):
        model.train(); t0 = time.time(); tr_loss = 0.0
        for b in dl_tr:
```

```
            b_dev = {k: v.to(DEVICE) for k, v in b.items() if torch.is_tensor(v)}
            with torch.autocast("cuda", dtype=torch.float16, enabled=amp):
                ll, sl, _ = model(b_dev["input_ids"], b_dev["attention_mask"],
b_dev["token_mask"])
                loss = cfg["label_loss_weight"] * bce_loss(ll.float(), b_dev["y"],
pw, gamma)
                if sl is not None and cfg["span_loss_weight"] > 0:
                    loss = loss + cfg["span_loss_weight"] * bce_loss(sl.float(),
b_dev["token_labels"], None, gamma,

mask=b_dev["token_mask"])
            opt.zero_grad(set_to_none=True)
            scaler.scale(loss).backward()
            scaler.unscale_(opt);
torch.nn.utils.clip_grad_norm_(model.parameters(), 1.0)
            scaler.step(opt); scaler.update(); sched.step()
            tr_loss += loss.item() * len(b["idx"])
        lp, tp, offs, _ = predict(model, dl_va, amp)
        _, f_lab = best_label_thr(Yva, lp)
        _, f_span = best_span_thr(gold_va, tp, offs, list(df_va.text))
        score = np.nanmean([f_lab, f_span])
        history.append({"epoch": epoch + 1, "train_loss": tr_loss / len(df_tr),
"val_label_f1": f_lab,
                        "val_span_f1": f_span, "secs": time.time() - t0})
        if score > best:
            best, bad = score, 0
            best_state = {k: v.detach().cpu().clone() for k, v in
model.state_dict().items()}
            best_pred = (lp, tp, offs)
        else:
            bad += 1
            if bad >= cfg["patience"]:
                break
    model.load_state_dict(best_state)
    out = {"label_p": best_pred[0], "token_p": best_pred[1], "offsets":
best_pred[2], "history": history,
           "n_trainable": sum(p.numel() for p in model.parameters() if
p.requires_grad),
           "n_total": sum(p.numel() for p in model.parameters())}
    if keep_model:
        out["model"] = model.cpu()
    else:
        del model
    gc.collect(); torch.cuda.empty_cache() if DEVICE.type == "cuda" else None
    return out
```

4. Experiments on the development pool (5-fold cross-validation)

Protocol. Experiments run in a fixed order, and each one fixes one design dimension for the experiments after it (greedy, coordinate-wise search). A full grid over all dimensions is out of reach (3 encoders × 3 adaptations × 4 architectures × … ≈ 500 configurations × 5 folds), and the dimensions are largely separable.

Every experiment is stated **before** it runs:

- **H:** the hypothesis, i.e. what we expect.

- **Decision rule:** how the result feeds the next step.

Selection score = mean of out-of-fold label micro-F1 and span F1, each at its best global threshold. The tool needs both outputs, so neither alone decides.

Tie rule: a candidate replaces the current choice only if it wins on the selection score **and** its fold-paired advantage is larger than the fold-to-fold standard deviation of that advantage. Otherwise we keep the simpler or cheaper option. With 750 memes, differences of about one F1 point are within noise, so this rule prevents "tuning on noise".

Robustness is measured in every run. Each validation fold is also scored after lower-casing and after sentence-casing the text (labels and offsets unchanged). This tells us how each choice behaves on text that does not look like the 2020 corpus (E8, C4).

In [19]:
```
_TOKENIZERS = {}


def get_tok(encoder):
    if encoder not in _TOKENIZERS:
        _TOKENIZERS[encoder] = AutoTokenizer.from_pretrained(ENCODERS[encoder]
["hf"])
    return _TOKENIZERS[encoder]


ROBUST_VIEWS = {"lower": str.lower, "sentence": lambda t: t[:1].upper() +
t[1:].lower()}
RESULTS = {}


def run_cv(name, keep_models=False, **overrides):
    """5-fold CV of one configuration. Stores out-of-fold predictions and fold-
level scores in RESULTS[name]."""
    cfg = {**DEFAULT_CFG, **overrides}
    if name in RESULTS and not keep_models:
        return RESULTS[name]
    tok = get_tok(cfg["encoder"])
    n = len(df_dev)
    label_p = np.zeros((n, K)); token_p = [None] * n; offsets = [None] * n
    robust = {v: np.zeros((n, K)) for v in ROBUST_VIEWS}
    histories, models, t0 = [], [], time.time()
    for f in range(N_FOLDS):
        tr, va = df_dev[df_dev.fold != f], df_dev[df_dev.fold == f]
        out = train_fold(cfg, tr, va, tok, keep_model=True)
        idx = np.where(df_dev.fold == f)[0]
        label_p[idx] = out["label_p"]
        for j, i in enumerate(idx):
            token_p[i], offsets[i] = out["token_p"][j], out["offsets"][j]
        model = out["model"].to(DEVICE)
        for v, fn in ROBUST_VIEWS.items():
            va_v = va.assign(text=va.text.map(fn))
            dl = torch.utils.data.DataLoader(MemeDataset(va_v, tok), batch_size=64,
collate_fn=make_collate(tok.pad_token_id))
            robust[v][idx] = predict(model, dl, ENCODERS[cfg["encoder"]]["amp"])[0]
        if keep_models:
            models.append(model.cpu())
        del model, out["model"]; gc.collect()
        histories.append(pd.DataFrame(out["history"]).assign(fold=f))
```

```
    thr_l, _ = best_label_thr(Y_dev, label_p)
    thr_s, _ = best_span_thr(list(df_dev.spans), token_p, offsets,
list(df_dev.text))
    pred_spans = spans_from_probs(token_p, offsets, thr_s, list(df_dev.text)) if
thr_s is not None else [[] for _ in range(n)]
    folds = []
    for f in range(N_FOLDS):
        m = (df_dev.fold == f).values
        row = {"fold": f, **label_scores(Y_dev[m], label_p[m] >= thr_l)}
        row["span_f1"] = span_scores([s for s, k in zip(df_dev.spans, m) if k],
                                     [s for s, k in zip(pred_spans, m) if k])
["span_f1"] if thr_s is not None else np.nan
        for v in ROBUST_VIEWS:
            row[f"micro_f1_{v}"] = f1_score(Y_dev[m], robust[v][m] >= thr_l,
average="micro", zero_division=0)
        folds.append(row)
    folds = pd.DataFrame(folds)
    folds["select"] = folds[["micro_f1", "span_f1"]].mean(axis=1, skipna=True)
    overall = {**label_scores(Y_dev, label_p >= thr_l),
               "span_f1": span_scores(list(df_dev.spans), pred_spans)["span_f1"] if
thr_s is not None else np.nan}
    overall["select"] = np.nanmean([overall["micro_f1"], overall["span_f1"]])
    for v in ROBUST_VIEWS:
        overall[f"micro_f1_{v}"] = f1_score(Y_dev, robust[v] >= thr_l,
average="micro", zero_division=0)
    RESULTS[name] = {"cfg": cfg, "label_p": label_p, "token_p": token_p, "offsets":
offsets, "robust": robust,
                     "thr_label": thr_l, "thr_span": thr_s, "pred_spans":
pred_spans, "folds": folds,
                     "overall": overall, "history": pd.concat(histories),
"minutes": (time.time() - t0) / 60,
                     "n_trainable": out["n_trainable"], "n_total": out["n_total"],
"models": models}
    o = overall
    print(f"{name:28s} micro={o['micro_f1']:.3f} macro={o['macro_f1']:.3f} span=
{o['span_f1']:.3f} "
          f"select={o['select']:.3f} | lower={o['micro_f1_lower']:.3f} |
{RESULTS[name]['minutes']:.1f} min")
    return RESULTS[name]


def compare(names, reference):
    """Summary table; 'Δ select' is the fold-paired difference to `reference` (mean
± sd over folds)."""
    ref = RESULTS[reference]["folds"]["select"].values
    rows = []
    for nm in names:
        r = RESULTS[nm]; d = r["folds"]["select"].values - ref
        rows.append({"config": nm, "micro_f1": r["overall"]["micro_f1"],
"macro_f1": r["overall"]["macro_f1"],
                     "span_f1": r["overall"]["span_f1"], "select": r["overall"]
["select"],
                     "Δ select (paired)": f"{d.mean():+.3f} ± {d.std(ddof=1) if
len(d) > 1 else 0:.3f}",
                     "folds won": f"{int((d > 0).sum())}/{len(d)}" if nm !=
reference else "–",
                     "micro_f1 lower-cased": r["overall"]["micro_f1_lower"],
                     "trainable params (M)": r["n_trainable"] / 1e6, "minutes":
r["minutes"]})
    return pd.DataFrame(rows).set_index("config")
```

```
def choose(current, candidates):
    """Tie rule: switch only if the candidate's paired advantage exceeds its fold-to-fold sd."""
    best = current
    for c in candidates:
        d = RESULTS[c]["folds"]["select"].values - RESULTS[best]["folds"]["select"].values
        if d.mean() > 0 and d.mean() > d.std(ddof=1):
            best = c
    return best


def show(names, reference, title):
    tab = compare(names, reference)
    display(tab.style.format({c: "{:.3f}" for c in ["micro_f1", "macro_f1", "span_f1", "select", "micro_f1 lower-cased"]}
                             | {"trainable params (M)": "{:.1f}", "minutes": "{:.1f}"}).set_caption(title))
```

E1: Which pretrained encoder?

Candidates (all ~125–185M parameters, comfortably T4-sized):

- **RoBERTa-base:** strong general baseline.
- **Twitter-RoBERTa-2021:** RoBERTa further pre-trained, *without labels*, on tweets from 2020–2021. That is the same era and a similar register to the memes, and it was never trained on persuasion labels.
- **DeBERTa-v3-base:** usually the strongest base-size encoder on classification benchmarks.

H: the social-media encoder helps, because meme language is informal, shouty and topical (COVID, elections). DeBERTa may match it through general strength. **Decision rule:** the winner under the tie rule becomes the encoder for all later experiments. Ties go to RoBERTa-base (fastest, fp16-stable).

In [20]:
```
run_cv("E1 roberta-base", encoder="roberta-base")
run_cv("E1 twitter-roberta-2021", encoder="twitter-roberta-2021")
run_cv("E1 deberta-v3-base", encoder="deberta-v3-base")
show(["E1 roberta-base", "E1 twitter-roberta-2021", "E1 deberta-v3-base"], "E1 roberta-base", "E1: encoder")
BEST = choose("E1 roberta-base", ["E1 twitter-roberta-2021", "E1 deberta-v3-base"])
print("→ chosen:", BEST)
```

```
E1 roberta-base             micro=0.561 macro=0.245 span=0.338 select=0.449 | lower=0.561 | 5.9 min
E1 twitter-roberta-2021     micro=0.553 macro=0.213 span=0.334 select=0.443 | lower=0.558 | 5.3 min
E1 deberta-v3-base          micro=0.570 macro=0.242 span=0.401 select=0.486 | lower=0.561 | 7.4 min
```

E1: encoder

config	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select	Δ select (paired)	folds won	micro_f1 lower-cased	trainable params (M)	minutes
E1 roberta-base	0.561	0.245	0.338	0.449	+0.000 ± 0.000	–	0.561	125.5	5.9
E1 twitter-roberta-2021	0.553	0.213	0.334	0.443	-0.005 ± 0.016	2/5	0.558	125.5	5.3
E1 deberta-v3-base	0.570	0.242	0.401	0.486	+0.038 ± 0.033	5/5	0.561	184.7	7.4

```
→ chosen: E1 deberta-v3-base
```

E1 result. DeBERTa-v3 wins on all five folds (paired +0.038 ± 0.033 on the selection score). The gain comes mainly from span F1 (0.401 vs. 0.338 for RoBERTa). The tweet-pretrained RoBERTa did **not** help (−0.005 ± 0.016, won 2/5 folds), so the hypothesis is rejected: pretraining text from the same era and register did not beat a stronger general encoder. DeBERTa has 185M parameters instead of 125M, which is still small for a T4.

E2: How should the encoder be adapted? (frozen vs. LoRA vs. full fine-tuning)

- **Frozen encoder:** only the two heads are trained. Cheapest, but the representation cannot learn what persuasion looks like.
- **LoRA** (Hu et al., 2022), implemented from scratch in Section 3: low-rank adapters (r = 16) in the attention query/value projections; about 1% of the encoder's parameters train. Parameter-efficient, and on small data it may overfit less.
- **Full fine-tuning:** all parameters train.

LoRA adapters start at zero and usually need a larger learning rate than full fine-tuning, so LoRA is run at two rates (5e-4, 2e-3) and the better one represents it. Frozen and full fine-tuning use their standard rates.

H: frozen is clearly worse (micro-F1 roughly 0.05–0.10 lower), because general encoders do not linearly separate rhetorical techniques. LoRA is within noise of full fine-tuning. **Decision rule:** take full fine-tuning only if it beats LoRA under the tie rule. Otherwise take LoRA: it is cheaper to train, and per-school adapters are only a few MB, which matters for updating the tool later (C4).

In [21]:
```
ENC = RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"]["encoder"]
run_cv("E2 frozen", encoder=ENC, adaptation="frozen", lr_head=1e-3)
run_cv("E2 lora", encoder=ENC, adaptation="lora", lr_head=5e-4)
run_cv("E2 lora lr=2e-3", encoder=ENC, adaptation="lora", lr_head=2e-3)
show([BEST, "E2 frozen", "E2 lora", "E2 lora lr=2e-3"], BEST, f"E2: adaptation
strategy (encoder = {ENC})")
LORA = max(["E2 lora", "E2 lora lr=2e-3"], key=lambda nm: RESULTS[nm]["overall"]
["select"])
BEST = choose(LORA, [BEST, "E2 frozen"])  # LoRA unless an alternative clearly
beats it
print("→ chosen:", BEST)
```

```
E2 frozen                 micro=0.545 macro=0.158 span=0.382 select=0.464 | lower=0.547 | 2.8 min
E2 lora                   micro=0.539 macro=0.143 span=0.366 select=0.453 | lower=0.530 | 4.7 min
E2 lora lr=2e-3           micro=0.524 macro=0.163 span=0.323 select=0.423 | lower=0.527 | 3.2 min
```

E2: adaptation strategy (encoder = deberta-v3-base)

config	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select	Δ select (paired)	folds won	micro_f1 lower-cased	trainable params (M)	minutes
E1 deberta-v3-base	0.570	0.242	0.401	0.486	+0.000 ± 0.000	–	0.561	184.7	7.4
E2 frozen	0.545	0.158	0.382	0.464	-0.022 ± 0.021	1/5	0.547	0.8	2.8
E2 lora	0.539	0.143	0.366	0.453	-0.034 ± 0.018	0/5	0.530	1.4	4.7
E2 lora lr=2e-3	0.524	0.163	0.323	0.423	-0.072 ± 0.051	0/5	0.527	1.4	3.2

```
→ chosen: E1 deberta-v3-base
```

E2 result. Full fine-tuning beats every cheaper strategy on the selection score: frozen −0.022 ± 0.021, LoRA −0.034 ± 0.018 (0/5 folds won), LoRA at 2e-3 −0.072 ± 0.051. The gap is largest on macro-F1 (0.24 vs. 0.14–0.16): the rare techniques need the encoder itself to change. Our hypothesis ("LoRA within noise") is **rejected**. LoRA trains only 1.4M parameters, so it is the right choice when many task adapters must be stored, but here accuracy matters more and one 185M model per school machine is cheap. A surprise worth noting: the frozen encoder (0.8M trainable parameters) scored slightly *higher* than LoRA. With 600 training memes per fold, LoRA's extra capacity seems to add noise rather than signal.

E3: One joint model, or two?

- **Joint** (current): shared encoder, label head + span head, both losses.
- **Label-only:** the same model trained without the span loss (λ = 0). Does span supervision help Part A?
- **Span-only, labels derived:** only the span head is trained, and a label is predicted when any token is tagged (max over tokens). This is the "extend Part A from Part B" design. It cannot disagree by construction.
- **Derived labels + label loss:** as above, but the max-pooled span logits are also trained against meme labels.

H: joint ≥ label-only on label F1, because span supervision tells the encoder which words matter. Derived labels are worse on discourse techniques, where no single token is decisive. **Decision rule:** keep the joint model unless an alternative wins under the tie rule. The joint model is also what makes C3 a meaningful question.

In [22]:
```
base = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items() if k != "seed"}
run_cv("E3 label-only", **{**base, "span_loss_weight": 0.0})
run_cv("E3 span-only (labels derived)", **{**base, "label_head": "from_spans",
"label_loss_weight": 0.0})
run_cv("E3 derived + label loss", **{**base, "label_head": "from_spans"})
show([BEST, "E3 label-only", "E3 span-only (labels derived)", "E3 derived + label
loss"], BEST,
     "E3: joint vs. separate objectives (label-only has no span output: compare its
micro_f1, not its select score)")
BEST = choose(BEST, ["E3 span-only (labels derived)", "E3 derived + label loss"])
print("→ chosen:", BEST)
```

```
E3 label-only               micro=0.560 macro=0.181 span=nan select=0.560 | lower=0.561 | 5.8 min
E3 span-only (labels derived) micro=0.494 macro=0.171 span=0.356 select=0.425 | lower=0.503 | 7.4
min
E3 derived + label loss      micro=0.570 macro=0.204 span=0.421 select=0.495 | lower=0.574 | 9.3 min
```

E3: joint vs. separate objectives (label-only has no span output: compare its micro_f1, not its select score)

config	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select	Δ select (paired)	folds won	micro_f1 lower-cased	trainable params (M)	minutes
E1 deberta-v3-base	0.570	0.242	0.401	0.486	+0.000 ± 0.000	–	0.561	184.7	7.4
E3 label-only	0.560	0.181	nan	0.560	+0.075 ± 0.018	5/5	0.561	184.5	5.8
E3 span-only (labels derived)	0.494	0.171	0.356	0.425	-0.067 ± 0.077	1/5	0.503	184.0	7.4
E3 derived + label loss	0.570	0.204	0.421	0.495	+0.009 ± 0.018	3/5	0.574	184.0	9.3

```
→ chosen: E1 deberta-v3-base
```

E3 result. The joint model stays.

- Removing the span loss (label-only) changes label micro-F1 by about one point (0.560 vs. 0.570) but lowers macro-F1 from 0.24 to 0.18, so the span supervision helps the rare techniques. (Its "select" score is not comparable because it has no span output.)
- Deriving labels from spans alone is clearly worse on labels (0.494). Many techniques are a property of the whole message, not of single tokens.
- "Derived + label loss" is +0.009 ± 0.018, within noise, so the tie rule keeps the simpler joint model.

E4: The self-built label head (pooling)

Label-wise attention (current) versus the two standard alternatives, `[CLS]` and mean pooling, each followed by a 2-layer MLP. **H:** label-wise attention ≥ `[CLS]`, with the largest gain on lexical techniques that occupy a few words in a longer meme. **Decision rule:** the tie rule. A tie goes to label-wise attention, because it also gives an interpretable per-technique attention map for the teacher.

In [23]:
```
base = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items() if k != "seed"}
if base["label_head"] == "label_attention":
    run_cv("E4 cls", **{**base, "label_head": "cls"})
    run_cv("E4 mean", **{**base, "label_head": "mean"})
    show([BEST, "E4 cls", "E4 mean"], BEST, "E4: label head")
    BEST = choose(BEST, ["E4 cls", "E4 mean"])
print("→ chosen:", BEST)
```

```
E4 cls                  micro=0.545 macro=0.144 span=0.412 select=0.478 | lower=0.552 | 8.9 min
E4 mean                 micro=0.562 macro=0.186 span=0.398 select=0.480 | lower=0.560 | 8.4 min
```

E4: label head

config	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select	Δ select (paired)	folds won	micro_f1 lower-cased	trainable params (M)	minutes
E1 deberta-v3-base	0.570	0.242	0.401	0.486	+0.000 ± 0.000	–	0.561	184.7	7.4
E4 cls	0.545	0.144	0.412	0.478	-0.007 ± 0.017	2/5	0.552	184.6	8.9
E4 mean	0.562	0.186	0.398	0.480	-0.005 ± 0.026	3/5	0.560	184.6	8.4

```
→ chosen: E1 deberta-v3-base
```

E4 result. Label-wise attention is not worse than [CLS] (−0.007 ± 0.017) or mean pooling (−0.005 ± 0.026) on the selection score, and it has the highest label macro-F1 (0.24 vs. 0.14 and 0.19). The differences are within noise, so our self-built head is kept by the tie rule and for its per-technique attention maps.

E5: Handling class imbalance

Plain BCE (current) vs. BCE with √-damped positive weights vs. focal loss (γ = 2). **H:** weighting raises recall on rare techniques. That should help macro-F1 a little but cost precision, and micro-F1 may not move. **Decision rule:** the selection score (micro-weighted) decides via the tie rule. We also report macro-F1 because the classroom cares about the tail. If a loss wins clearly on macro-F1 without losing on the selection score, we take it.

In [24]:
```
base = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items() if k != "seed"}
run_cv("E5 bce+pos_weight", **{**base, "loss": "bce_pw"})
run_cv("E5 focal", **{**base, "loss": "focal"})
show([BEST, "E5 bce+pos_weight", "E5 focal"], BEST, "E5: loss")
cand = choose(BEST, ["E5 bce+pos_weight", "E5 focal"])
if cand == BEST:  # no win on the selection score: accept a clear macro-F1 gain
that does not hurt it
    for c in ["E5 bce+pos_weight", "E5 focal"]:
        d_sel = RESULTS[c]["folds"]["select"].values - RESULTS[BEST]["folds"]
["select"].values
        d_mac = RESULTS[c]["folds"]["macro_f1"].values - RESULTS[BEST]["folds"]
["macro_f1"].values
        if d_mac.mean() > d_mac.std(ddof=1) and d_sel.mean() > -d_sel.std(ddof=1):
            cand = c; break
BEST = cand
print("→ chosen:", BEST)
```

```
E5 bce+pos_weight           micro=0.562 macro=0.296 span=0.408 select=0.485 | lower=0.554 | 9.4 min
E5 focal                    micro=0.569 macro=0.288 span=0.422 select=0.496 | lower=0.559 | 8.6 min
```

E5: loss

config	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select	Δ select (paired)	folds won	micro_f1 lower-cased	trainable params (M)	minutes
E1 deberta-v3-base	0.570	0.242	0.401	0.486	+0.000 ± 0.000	–	0.561	184.7	7.4
E5 bce+pos_weight	0.562	0.296	0.408	0.485	-0.002 ± 0.027	3/5	0.554	184.7	9.4
E5 focal	0.569	0.288	0.422	0.496	+0.010 ± 0.023	3/5	0.559	184.7	8.6

```
→ chosen: E5 bce+pos_weight
```

E5 result. As expected, weighting rare positives barely moves the selection score (−0.002 ± 0.027) but lifts macro-F1 from 0.242 to 0.296: the tail techniques start to be found. Focal loss behaves similarly (0.288). The macro-F1 rule therefore selects BCE with positive weights. Precision drops (0.56 → 0.53) while recall rises (0.58 → 0.60), the trade-off we predicted.

E6: Learning rates and regularisation

A small, targeted search instead of a large grid. The literature on fine-tuning BERT-style encoders (Mosbach et al., 2021) identifies the **encoder learning rate** as the most influential and most unstable choice. The **head learning rate** matters because the heads start from scratch. **Dropout** matters on 600 training memes per fold. Epochs are not searched: early stopping on the validation fold picks them, and the learning curves below show where training saturates.

H: the default (encoder 3e-5) is near-optimal; 1e-5 under-fits within 15 epochs and 5e-5 is less stable. **Decision rule:** the tie rule, one dimension at a time, in the order encoder LR → head LR → dropout.

In [25]:
```
base = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items() if k != "seed"}
lr_key = "lr_encoder" if base["adaptation"] == "full" else "lr_head"
grid = [1e-5, 5e-5] if lr_key == "lr_encoder" else [2e-4, 1e-3]
names = [run_cv(f"E6 {lr_key}={v:g}", **{**base, lr_key: v}) and f"E6 {lr_key}=
{v:g}" for v in grid]
show([BEST] + names, BEST, f"E6a: {lr_key}")
BEST = choose(BEST, names)
```

```
base = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items() if k != "seed"}
if lr_key == "lr_encoder":
    names = [run_cv(f"E6 lr_head={v:g}", **{**base, "lr_head": v}) and f"E6
lr_head={v:g}" for v in [1e-4, 2e-3]]
    show([BEST] + names, BEST, "E6b: head learning rate")
    BEST = choose(BEST, names)
    base = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items() if k != "seed"}
run_cv("E6 dropout=0.3", **{**base, "dropout": 0.3})
show([BEST, "E6 dropout=0.3"], BEST, "E6c: dropout")
BEST = choose(BEST, ["E6 dropout=0.3"])
print("→ chosen:", BEST, RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"])
```

```
E6 lr_encoder=1e-05          micro=0.525 macro=0.251 span=0.373 select=0.449 | lower=0.510 | 7.5 min
E6 lr_encoder=5e-05          micro=0.570 macro=0.309 span=0.428 select=0.499 | lower=0.575 | 9.4 min
```

E6a: lr_encoder

config	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select	Δ select (paired)	folds won	micro_f1 lower-cased	trainable params (M)	minutes
E5 bce+pos_weight	0.562	0.296	0.408	0.485	+0.000 ± 0.000	–	0.554	184.7	9.4
E6 lr_encoder=1e-05	0.525	0.251	0.373	0.449	-0.036 ± 0.011	0/5	0.510	184.7	7.5
E6 lr_encoder=5e-05	0.570	0.309	0.428	0.499	+0.015 ± 0.015	4/5	0.575	184.7	9.4

```
E6 lr_head=0.0001            micro=0.548 macro=0.284 span=0.355 select=0.451 | lower=0.550 | 9.1 min
E6 lr_head=0.002             micro=0.563 macro=0.286 span=0.427 select=0.495 | lower=0.554 | 8.8 min
```

E6b: head learning rate

config	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select	Δ select (paired)	folds won	micro_f1 lower-cased	trainable params (M)	minutes
E5 bce+pos_weight	0.562	0.296	0.408	0.485	+0.000 ± 0.000	–	0.554	184.7	9.4
E6 lr_head=0.0001	0.548	0.284	0.355	0.451	-0.034 ± 0.008	0/5	0.550	184.7	9.1
E6 lr_head=0.002	0.563	0.286	0.427	0.495	+0.011 ± 0.012	4/5	0.554	184.7	8.8

```
E6 dropout=0.3               micro=0.554 macro=0.294 span=0.397 select=0.475 | lower=0.562 | 9.4 min
```

E6c: dropout

config	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select	Δ select (paired)	folds won	micro_f1 lower-cased	trainable params (M)	minutes
E5 bce+pos_weight	0.562	0.296	0.408	0.485	+0.000 ± 0.000	–	0.554	184.7	9.4
E6 dropout=0.3	0.554	0.294	0.397	0.475	-0.010 ± 0.010	1/5	0.562	184.7	9.4

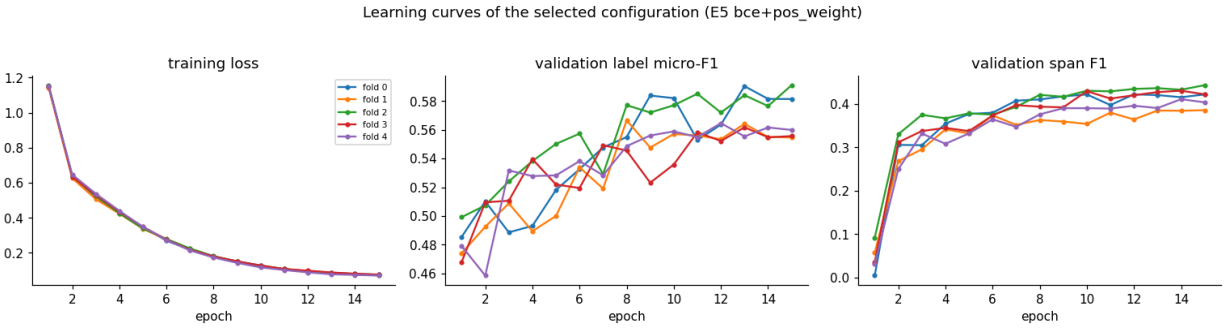
```
→ chosen: E5 bce+pos_weight {'encoder': 'deberta-v3-base', 'adaptation': 'full', 'lora_r': 16,
'label_head': 'label_attention', 'label_loss_weight': 1.0, 'span_loss_weight': 1.0, 'loss':
'bce_pw', 'focal_gamma': 2.0, 'lr_encoder': 3e-05, 'lr_head': 0.0005, 'weight_decay': 0.01,
'dropout': 0.1, 'epochs': 15, 'patience': 4, 'batch_size': 16, 'warmup': 0.1, 'casing_aug': 0.0,
'init_encoder': None, 'seed': 42}
```

E6 result. No change passes the tie rule. Encoder learning rate 1e-5 clearly underfits (−0.036 ± 0.011); 5e-5 is better on 4/5 folds (+0.015 ± 0.015), but its advantage only equals its spread, so the default is kept. A head learning rate of 1e-4 is too slow (−0.034); 2e-3 is +0.011 ± 0.012; dropout 0.3 is worse (−0.010). The selected configuration is DeBERTa-v3, full fine-tuning, label-wise attention head, joint loss, BCE with positive weights, encoder LR 3e-5, head LR 5e-4, dropout 0.1.

In [26]:

```
hist = RESULTS[BEST]["history"]
fig, ax = plt.subplots(1, 3, figsize=(14, 3.6))
for f, h in hist.groupby("fold"):
    ax[0].plot(h.epoch, h.train_loss, marker=".", label=f"fold {f}")
    ax[1].plot(h.epoch, h.val_label_f1, marker=".")
    ax[2].plot(h.epoch, h.val_span_f1, marker=".")
for a, t in zip(ax, ["training loss", "validation label micro-F1", "validation span
```

```
F1"]):
    a.set_title(t); a.set_xlabel("epoch")
ax[0].legend(fontsize=7); fig.suptitle(f"Learning curves of the selected
configuration ({BEST})", y=1.03)
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
```



Reading the curves. Training loss falls smoothly in every fold. Validation span F1 levels off after about 8 epochs. Validation label F1 is noisy (one meme moves it by almost a point) and still drifts upwards at epoch 15 in some folds, so early stopping never had to stop training. There is no sign of the validation score collapsing (overfitting), but a few more epochs might add a little. We note this as a limitation rather than tune it, because it would mean selecting on the same noisy folds again.

E7: One threshold or one per technique?

The model outputs probabilities, and the tool needs yes/no. We compare one global threshold with per-technique thresholds, both tuned on out-of-fold predictions. Per-technique thresholds are estimated on few positives for rare classes, so they risk overfitting. To measure that honestly we use **nested** tuning: thresholds are fitted on four folds' out-of-fold predictions and applied to the fifth.

H: per-technique thresholds help only for techniques with enough positives. **Decision rule:** use per-technique thresholds for techniques with at least `MIN_POS` development positives, and the global threshold otherwise, *only if* this beats the global threshold in the nested comparison.

In [27]:
```
MIN_POS = 30
R = RESULTS[BEST]


def fit_thresholds(Y, P, per_class):
    g, _ = best_label_thr(Y, P)
    thr = np.full(K, g)
    if per_class:
        for k in range(K):
            if Y[:, k].sum() >= MIN_POS:
                scores = [f1_score(Y[:, k], P[:, k] >= t, zero_division=0) for t in
LABEL_THR_GRID]
                thr[k] = LABEL_THR_GRID[int(np.argmax(scores))]
    return thr


rows = []
for f in range(N_FOLDS):
```

```
    fit, ev = (df_dev.fold != f).values, (df_dev.fold == f).values
    for mode in [False, True]:
        thr = fit_thresholds(Y_dev[fit], R["label_p"][fit], mode)
        rows.append({"fold": f, "thresholds": "per-technique" if mode else
"global",
                     **label_scores(Y_dev[ev], R["label_p"][ev] >= thr)})
e7 = pd.DataFrame(rows)
display(e7.groupby("thresholds")[["micro_f1", "macro_f1", "micro_p",
"micro_r"]].agg(["mean", "std"]).round(3))
d = (e7[e7.thresholds == "per-technique"].micro_f1.values - e7[e7.thresholds ==
"global"].micro_f1.values)
PER_CLASS_THR = d.mean() > 0 and d.mean() > d.std(ddof=1)
LABEL_THR = fit_thresholds(Y_dev, R["label_p"], PER_CLASS_THR)
print(f"paired Δ micro-F1 (per-technique − global) = {d.mean():+.3f} ±
{d.std(ddof=1):.3f} → "
      f"{'per-technique' if PER_CLASS_THR else 'global'} thresholds; span threshold
= {R['thr_span']}")
```

	micro_f1		macro_f1		micro_p		micro_r	
	mean	std	mean	std	mean	std	mean	std
thresholds								
global	0.553	0.009	0.274	0.043	0.543	0.023	0.565	0.032
per-technique	0.549	0.009	0.278	0.044	0.507	0.013	0.601	0.022

```
paired Δ micro-F1 (per-technique − global) = -0.003 ± 0.006 → global thresholds; span threshold =
0.3
```

E7 result. Per-technique thresholds do not help in the nested comparison (−0.003 ± 0.006 micro-F1). They raise recall but cost more precision. One global threshold is used.

E8: Robustness to casing, and casing augmentation

Every run above was also scored on lower-cased and sentence-cased validation text. About half the training memes are in capitals, while students' feeds are mostly mixed case. **H:** performance drops on re-cased text, and training with random re-casing (p = 0.5) removes most of the drop at little cost on the original text. **Decision rule:** adopt augmentation if it keeps the selection score within noise (tie rule in reverse: it must not *lose* by more than one sd) and improves lower-cased micro-F1 by more than one sd. Robustness is a deployment requirement, not a tie-breaker.

In [28]:
```
base = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items() if k != "seed"}
run_cv("E8 casing-aug", **{**base, "casing_aug": 0.5})
rob = pd.DataFrame({nm: {"original": RESULTS[nm]["overall"]["micro_f1"],
                         "lower-cased": RESULTS[nm]["overall"]["micro_f1_lower"],
                         "sentence-cased": RESULTS[nm]["overall"]
["micro_f1_sentence"]}
                    for nm in [BEST, "E8 casing-aug"]}).T
display(rob.style.format("{:.3f}").set_caption("Label micro-F1 (out-of-fold) under
re-casing"))
d_sel = RESULTS["E8 casing-aug"]["folds"]["select"].values - RESULTS[BEST]["folds"]
["select"].values
d_low = RESULTS["E8 casing-aug"]["folds"]["micro_f1_lower"].values - RESULTS[BEST]
["folds"]["micro_f1_lower"].values
if d_sel.mean() > -d_sel.std(ddof=1) and d_low.mean() > d_low.std(ddof=1):
    BEST = "E8 casing-aug"
print(f"Δ select {d_sel.mean():+.3f} ± {d_sel.std(ddof=1):.3f}; Δ lower-cased
micro-F1 {d_low.mean():+.3f} ± "
      f"{d_low.std(ddof=1):.3f} → chosen: {BEST}")
```

```
E8 casing-aug                micro=0.563 macro=0.305 span=0.406 select=0.485 | lower=0.554 | 9.2 min
```

Label micro-F1 (out-of-fold) under re-casing

	original	lower-cased	sentence-cased
E5 bce+pos_weight	0.562	0.554	0.560
E8 casing-aug	0.563	0.554	0.557

```
Δ select +0.000 ± 0.003; Δ lower-cased micro-F1 -0.001 ± 0.017 → chosen: E5 bce+pos_weight
```

E8 result. The hypothesis is rejected in an informative way: the model is **already robust to casing** (0.562 original, 0.554 lower-cased, 0.560 sentence-cased), so augmentation has nothing to fix (Δ lower-cased −0.001 ± 0.017). DeBERTa's tokenizer handles capitals well enough. Augmentation is not adopted.

E9: Additional public data, the Propaganda Techniques Corpus (PTC)

Declared external data. The PTC is SemEval-2020 Task 11 (Da San Martino et al., 2020; Zenodo record 3952415, CC-BY 4.0): 371 English **news articles** (2017–2019) with 6,129 character-level technique spans, annotated with the same family of guidelines as our corpus.

- **Why it might help:** about 3× more span annotations than our 750 memes (2,083 spans), for the same techniques.
- **Why it might not:** news prose is long, formal and mixed-case. Memes are short, shouty and depend on images. The PTC taxonomy is also coarser: two of its classes merge several of ours (*Whataboutism* + *Straw Man* + *Red Herring*; *Bandwagon* + *Reductio ad hitlerum*), and it has no *Smears*, *Glittering generalities* or *Obfuscation*.
- **No leakage:** the PTC contains news articles, not memes. Below we check that no meme of our corpus (≥ 6 words) occurs in it verbatim, so it cannot contain the labels of our evaluation set.
- **Compliance:** this is *data* that we train on ourselves. No checkpoint trained by anyone else on propaganda labels is used.

How it is used: intermediate training (Phang et al., 2018). The encoder plus both heads are first trained on PTC sentences for 2 epochs. Techniques that the PTC does not annotate cleanly are **masked out** of the loss, i.e. treated as neither positive nor negative. The resulting encoder weights are the starting point for the normal 5-fold training on memes.

H: a small gain on techniques that are frequent in the PTC (Loaded Language, Name calling, Doubt, Exaggeration), partly cancelled by the domain shift. **Decision rule:** adopt it only if it wins under the tie rule.

In [29]:

```
import tarfile, urllib.request
PTC_URL = "https://zenodo.org/api/records/3952415/files/datasets-v2.tgz/content"
PTC_MAP = {"Loaded_Language": "Loaded Language", "Name_Calling,Labeling": "Name
calling/Labeling", "Repetition": "Repetition",
           "Doubt": "Doubt", "Exaggeration,Minimisation":
"Exaggeration/Minimisation",
           "Appeal_to_fear-prejudice": "Appeal to fear/prejudice", "Flag-Waving":
"Flag-waving",
           "Causal_Oversimplification": "Causal Oversimplification",
```

```
"Appeal_to_Authority": "Appeal to authority",
          "Slogans": "Slogans", "Black-and-White_Fallacy": "Black-and-white
Fallacy/Dictatorship",
          "Thought-terminating_Cliches": "Thought-terminating cliché"}  # merged
PTC classes are deliberately not mapped
PTC_KNOWN = np.array([t in PTC_MAP.values() for t in TECHNIQUES])


def load_ptc():
    path = Path("ptc_datasets-v2.tgz")
    if not path.exists():
        download(PTC_URL, path)
    arts, labels = {}, collections.defaultdict(list)
    with tarfile.open(path) as tf:
        for mem in tf.getmembers():
            if mem.name.startswith("datasets/train-articles/") and
mem.name.endswith(".txt"):
                arts[re.findall(r"article(\d+)", mem.name)[0]] =
tf.extractfile(mem).read().decode("utf8")
            elif mem.name == "datasets/train-task2-TC.labels":
                for line in tf.extractfile(mem).read().decode("utf8").splitlines():
                    aid, tech, s, e = line.split("\t")
                    if tech in PTC_MAP:
                        labels[aid].append((int(s), int(e), PTC_MAP[tech]))
    rows = []
    for aid, text in arts.items():
        start = 0
        for line in text.split("\n"):
            end = start + len(line)
            if line.strip():
                sp = [(max(s, start) - start, min(e, end) - start, t) for s, e, t
in labels[aid] if s < end and e > start]
                sp = [x for x in sp if x[1] > x[0]]
                y = np.zeros(K, np.float32)
                for _, _, t in sp:
                    y[T2I[t]] = 1
                rows.append({"id": f"ptc{aid}_{start}", "text": line, "spans": sp,
"y": y})
            start = end + 1
    return pd.DataFrame(rows)


df_ptc = load_ptc()
_meme_norm = [re.sub(r"\s+", " ", t.lower().strip()) for t in df_all.text if
len(t.split()) >= 6]
_ptc_blob = re.sub(r"\s+", " ", " ".join(df_ptc.text).lower())
print(f"PTC sentences: {len(df_ptc)}, with a mapped technique:
{(np.stack(df_ptc.y).sum(1) > 0).sum()} | "
      f"memes (≥6 words) found verbatim in the PTC: {sum(m in _ptc_blob for m in
_meme_norm)}")
_has = np.stack(df_ptc.y).sum(1) > 0
df_ptc_train = pd.concat([df_ptc[_has], df_ptc[~_has].sample(int(_has.sum()),
random_state=SEED)]) \
    .sample(frac=1, random_state=SEED).reset_index(drop=True)
if FAST_DEV_RUN:
    df_ptc_train = df_ptc_train.head(200)
PTC_ENCODER_STATE = {}


def pretrain_on_ptc(encoder, epochs=2, lr=3e-5):
```

```
    seed_everything()
    cfg = {**DEFAULT_CFG, "encoder": encoder, "adaptation": "full", "label_head":
"label_attention", "init_encoder": None}
    tok, amp = get_tok(encoder), ENCODERS[encoder]["amp"] and DEVICE.type == "cuda"
    dl = torch.utils.data.DataLoader(MemeDataset(df_ptc_train, tok), batch_size=32,
shuffle=True,
                                     collate_fn=make_collate(tok.pad_token_id))
    model = PersuasionModel(cfg).to(DEVICE)
    opt = torch.optim.AdamW([{"params": model.encoder.parameters(), "lr": lr},
                             {"params": [p for n, p in model.named_parameters() if
not n.startswith("encoder.")], "lr": 5e-4}],
                            weight_decay=0.01)
    steps = epochs * len(dl); sched = get_linear_schedule_with_warmup(opt, int(0.1
* steps), steps)
    scaler = torch.amp.GradScaler("cuda", enabled=amp)
    known = torch.tensor(PTC_KNOWN, device=DEVICE)
    for ep in range(epochs):
        model.train(); tot = 0.0
        for b in dl:
            bd = {k: v.to(DEVICE) for k, v in b.items() if torch.is_tensor(v)}
            with torch.autocast("cuda", dtype=torch.float16, enabled=amp):
                ll, sl, _ = model(bd["input_ids"], bd["attention_mask"],
bd["token_mask"])
                loss = bce_loss(ll.float(), bd["y"], mask=known.expand_as(ll)) +
bce_loss(
                    sl.float(), bd["token_labels"], mask=bd["token_mask"][...,
None] & known)
            opt.zero_grad(set_to_none=True); scaler.scale(loss).backward();
scaler.unscale_(opt)
            torch.nn.utils.clip_grad_norm_(model.parameters(), 1.0);
scaler.step(opt); scaler.update(); sched.step()
            tot += loss.item()
        print(f"PTC intermediate training, epoch {ep + 1}: mean loss {tot /
len(dl):.4f}")
    PTC_ENCODER_STATE[encoder] = {k: v.detach().cpu() for k, v in
model.encoder.state_dict().items()}
    del model; gc.collect()


base = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items() if k != "seed"}
pretrain_on_ptc(base["encoder"])
run_cv("E9 + PTC intermediate training", **{**base, "init_encoder": "ptc"})
show([BEST, "E9 + PTC intermediate training"], BEST, "E9: additional data (PTC)")
pt_gain = pd.DataFrame({nm: f1_score(Y_dev, RESULTS[nm]["label_p"] >= RESULTS[nm]
["thr_label"], average=None, zero_division=0)
                        for nm in [BEST, "E9 + PTC intermediate training"]}, index=
[SHORT[t] for t in TECHNIQUES])
pt_gain["annotated in PTC"] = PTC_KNOWN
display(pt_gain.sort_values("annotated in PTC", ascending=False).style.format(
    "{:.3f}", subset=[BEST, "E9 + PTC intermediate training"]).set_caption("Out-of-
fold F1 per technique"))
BEST = choose(BEST, ["E9 + PTC intermediate training"])
print("→ chosen:", BEST)
```

```
PTC sentences: 16673, with a mapped technique: 4629 | memes (≥6 words) found verbatim in the PTC: 0
PTC intermediate training, epoch 1: mean loss 0.3327
PTC intermediate training, epoch 2: mean loss 0.2044
E9 + PTC intermediate training micro=0.563 macro=0.295 span=0.403 select=0.483 | lower=0.562 | 8.6
min
```

E9: additional data (PTC)

config	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select	Δ select (paired)	folds won	micro_f1 lower-cased	trainable params (M)	minutes
E5 bce+pos_weight	0.562	0.296	0.408	0.485	+0.000 ± 0.000	–	0.554	184.7	9.4
E9 + PTC intermediate training	0.563	0.295	0.403	0.483	-0.001 ± 0.014	2/5	0.562	184.7	8.6

Out-of-fold F1 per technique

	E5 bce+pos_weight	E9 + PTC intermediate training	annotated in PTC
Authority	0.538	0.370	True
Loaded language	0.780	0.801	True
Thought-term.	0.000	0.162	True
Slogans	0.364	0.376	True
Repetition	0.696	0.480	True
Fear/prejudice	0.227	0.295	True
Name calling	0.628	0.668	True
Flag-waving	0.508	0.583	True
Exagg./Minim.	0.248	0.323	True
Doubt	0.333	0.400	True
Causal oversimpl.	0.158	0.087	True
Black&white	0.000	0.000	True
Glittering gen.	0.222	0.190	False
Straw man	0.167	0.111	False
Obfuscation	0.000	0.000	False
Red herring	0.000	0.000	False
Ad hitlerum	0.154	0.182	False
Smears	0.550	0.501	False
Whataboutism	0.347	0.366	False
Bandwagon	0.000	0.000	False

```
→ chosen: E5 bce+pos_weight
```

E9 result. PTC intermediate training does not help overall (−0.001 ± 0.014). Per technique the picture is mixed: it helps several techniques that the PTC annotates (Loaded Language, Name calling, Flag-waving, Doubt, Exaggeration, Fear) but hurts others (Appeal to authority, Repetition, Causal oversimplification). News prose seems to teach the *vocabulary* of propaganda but not the *meme format*. The extra data is therefore not used in the final model, and no external data enters the final system.

How large is the noise? (seed variance)

The tie rule uses fold-to-fold variation. As a second check, the selected configuration is re-trained with two more seeds on the same folds. If seeds alone move the score by as much as the differences between design choices above, those choices should be read as "no measurable difference", not as wins.

In [30]:
```
base = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items() if k != "seed"}
seed_names = [BEST] + [run_cv(f"seed {s}", **{**base, "seed": s}) and f"seed {s}"
for s in (1, 2)]
seed_tab = pd.DataFrame({nm: RESULTS[nm]["overall"] for nm in
seed_names}).T[["micro_f1", "macro_f1", "span_f1", "select"]]
display(seed_tab.style.format("{:.3f}").set_caption("Same configuration, three
seeds"))
print("sd across seeds:", seed_tab.std().round(3).to_dict())
```

```
seed 1                    micro=0.561 macro=0.267 span=0.401 select=0.481 | lower=0.534 | 9.3 min
seed 2                    micro=0.550 macro=0.289 span=0.395 select=0.472 | lower=0.555 | 8.9 min
```

Same configuration, three seeds

	micro_f1	macro_f1	span_f1	select
E5 bce+pos_weight	0.562	0.296	0.408	0.485
seed 1	0.561	0.267	0.401	0.481
seed 2	0.550	0.289	0.395	0.472

```
sd across seeds: {'micro_f1': 0.007, 'macro_f1': 0.015, 'span_f1': 0.007, 'select': 0.007}
```

Noise level. Changing only the seed moves the selection score by a standard deviation of 0.007 and macro-F1 by 0.015. Most design differences above (E3–E9) are of the same size. They should be read as "no measurable difference", which is exactly why the tie rule kept the simpler options. Only E1 (encoder), E2 (adaptation) and the learning-rate extremes in E6 are clearly larger than this noise.

Summary of the development experiments

In [31]:

```
summary = pd.DataFrame({nm: {**r["overall"], "trainable (M)": r["n_trainable"] / 1e6, "minutes": r["minutes"]}
                        for nm, r in RESULTS.items()}).T
summary = summary[["micro_f1", "macro_f1", "micro_p", "micro_r", "span_f1", "select", "micro_f1_lower",
                   "trainable (M)", "minutes"]]
summary.loc["baseline: majority"] = baselines.loc["majority"]
summary.loc["baseline: prior-random"] = baselines.loc["prior-random"]
display(summary.style.format("{:.3f}", na_rep="–").format({"trainable (M)": "{:.1f}", "minutes": "{:.1f}"}, na_rep="–")
        .highlight_max(subset=["micro_f1", "macro_f1", "span_f1", "select"], color="#d4edda")
        .set_caption("All development runs (out-of-fold, 750 memes)"))
FINAL_CFG = {k: v for k, v in RESULTS[BEST]["cfg"].items()}
print("FINAL configuration:", BEST, FINAL_CFG)
```

All development runs (out-of-fold, 750 memes)

	micro_f1	macro_f1	micro_p	micro_r	span_f1	select	micro_f1_lower	trainable (M)	minutes
E1 roberta-base	0.560847	0.245137	0.554145	0.567712	0.338150	0.449498	0.561033	125.5	5.9
E1 twitter-roberta-2021	0.553191	0.213079	0.570268	0.537108	0.333625	0.443408	0.558426	125.5	5.3
E1 deberta-v3-base	0.569824	0.242073	0.557918	0.582249	0.401467	0.485645	0.561364	184.7	7.4
E2 frozen	0.545391	0.158401	0.503234	0.595256	0.382469	0.463930	0.546898	0.8	2.8
E2 lora	0.539426	0.142676	0.572041	0.510329	0.366134	0.452780	0.530029	1.4	4.7
E2 lora lr=2e-3	0.523513	0.162830	0.477603	0.579189	0.323157	0.423335	0.527410	1.4	3.2
E3 label-only	0.560405	0.181368	0.571088	0.550115	–	0.560405	0.561157	184.5	5.8
E3 span-only (labels derived)	0.493585	0.171400	0.441692	0.559296	0.355767	0.424676	0.503145	184.0	7.4
E3 derived + label loss	0.569888	0.204433	0.573643	0.566182	0.420678	0.495283	0.574219	184.0	9.3
E4 cls	0.545036	0.144091	0.546083	0.543994	0.411866	0.478451	0.552067	184.6	8.9
E4 mean	0.561868	0.185876	0.571655	0.552410	0.398275	0.480071	0.559839	184.6	8.4
E5 bce+pos_weight	0.561942	0.296029	0.526774	0.602142	0.407901	0.484922	0.554269	184.7	9.4
E5 focal	0.569118	0.287790	0.547771	0.592196	0.422317	0.495717	0.559188	184.7	8.6
E6 lr_encoder=1e-05	0.524517	0.251255	0.509747	0.540168	0.372783	0.448650	0.509580	184.7	7.5
E6 lr_encoder=5e-05	0.570162	0.309252	0.551035	0.590666	0.427504	0.498833	0.574887	184.7	9.4
E6 lr_head=0.0001	0.548423	0.283645	0.532421	0.565417	0.354572	0.451497	0.549543	184.7	9.1
E6 lr_head=0.002	0.563319	0.286012	0.537127	0.592196	0.426912	0.495115	0.554310	184.7	8.8
E6 dropout=0.3	0.553902	0.293856	0.526934	0.583780	0.396503	0.475202	0.562246	184.7	9.4
E8 casing-aug	0.562892	0.304528	0.543447	0.583780	0.406127	0.484509	0.553585	184.7	9.2
E9 + PTC intermediate training	0.563412	0.294794	0.551245	0.576129	0.403018	0.483215	0.561952	184.7	8.6
seed 1	0.561118	0.267223	0.569291	0.553175	0.400609	0.480863	0.533819	184.7	9.3
seed 2	0.549691	0.289379	0.524306	0.577659	0.394551	0.472121	0.554913	184.7	8.9
baseline: majority	0.378238	0.034153	0.518667	0.297668	0.157309	–	–	–	–
baseline: prior-random	0.282164	0.083600	0.282545	0.282224	0.141644	–	–	–	–

```
FINAL configuration: E5 bce+pos_weight {'encoder': 'deberta-v3-base', 'adaptation': 'full',
'lora_r': 16, 'label_head': 'label_attention', 'label_loss_weight': 1.0, 'span_loss_weight': 1.0,
'loss': 'bce_pw', 'focal_gamma': 2.0, 'lr_encoder': 3e-05, 'lr_head': 0.0005, 'weight_decay': 0.01,
'dropout': 0.1, 'epochs': 15, 'patience': 4, 'batch_size': 16, 'warmup': 0.1, 'casing_aug': 0.0,
'init_encoder': None, 'seed': 42}
```

5. The final model on the held-out test set

Final system. The selected configuration is trained once per fold, and the **five fold models are averaged** (a 5-model ensemble). Why not retrain one model on all 750 memes?

- The ensemble's thresholds were tuned on exactly the kind of model they are applied to (out-of-fold predictions of fold models). A retrained model would have no held-out data left to calibrate them.
- On 600-meme training sets, single runs vary noticeably with initialisation and data order. Averaging five models reduces that variance (Section 4, seed check).
- The latency cost is measured below and is acceptable on a T4.

The test set is used **here for the first time**, with every choice already fixed.

In [32]:
```
FINAL = run_cv("FINAL", keep_models=True, **FINAL_CFG)
LABEL_THR = fit_thresholds(Y_dev, FINAL["label_p"], PER_CLASS_THR)
SPAN_THR = FINAL["thr_span"]
FINAL_TOK = get_tok(FINAL_CFG["encoder"])
AMP = ENCODERS[FINAL_CFG["encoder"]]["amp"]


def ensemble_predict(df, models=None):
    models = models or FINAL["models"]
    dl = torch.utils.data.DataLoader(MemeDataset(df, FINAL_TOK), batch_size=64,
collate_fn=make_collate(FINAL_TOK.pad_token_id))
    lps, tps, atts = [], [], []
    for m in models:
        m.to(DEVICE)
        lp, tp, offs, att = predict(m, dl, AMP)
        lps.append(lp); tps.append(tp); atts.append(att)
        m.cpu()
    label_p = np.mean(lps, 0)
    token_p = [np.mean([tp[i] for tp in tps], 0) if tps[0][i] is not None else None
for i in range(len(df))]
    att = [np.mean([a[i] for a in atts], 0) if atts[0][i] is not None else None for
i in range(len(df))]
    return {"label_p": label_p, "labels": (label_p >= LABEL_THR).astype(int),
"token_p": token_p, "offsets": offs,
            "spans": spans_from_probs(token_p, offs, SPAN_THR, list(df.text)) if
SPAN_THR is not None else [[] for _ in range(len(df))],
            "att": att}


TEST = ensemble_predict(df_test)
Y_test = np.stack(df_test.y)
gold_test = list(df_test.spans)
```

```
FINAL                    micro=0.562 macro=0.296 span=0.408 select=0.485 | lower=0.554 | 9.5 min
```

In [33]:
```
def test_row(name, Yp, spans):
    s = {**label_scores(Y_test, Yp), **span_scores(gold_test, spans)}
    lo, hi = bootstrap_ci(lambda a, b: f1_score(a, b, average="micro",
zero_division=0), Y_test, Yp)
    s["micro_f1 95% CI"] = f"[{lo:.3f}, {hi:.3f}]"
    lo, hi = bootstrap_ci(lambda g, p: span_scores(g, p)["span_f1"], gold_test,
spans)
    s["span_f1 95% CI"] = f"[{lo:.3f}, {hi:.3f}]"
    return pd.Series(s, name=name)


maj = np.zeros_like(Y_test); maj[:, T2I["Loaded Language"]] = 1
single = ensemble_predict(df_test, FINAL["models"][:1])
test_tab = pd.DataFrame([
    test_row("final ensemble (5 models)", TEST["labels"], TEST["spans"]),
    test_row("single fold model (for reference)", single["labels"],
single["spans"]),
    test_row("majority baseline", maj, [whole_text_spans(t, ["Loaded Language"])
for t in df_test.text]),
])
test_tab.loc["SemEval-2021 best team (Dimitrov et al.)"] = pd.Series({"micro_f1":
.593, "macro_f1": .290, "span_f1": .482})
display(test_tab[["micro_f1", "micro_f1 95% CI", "macro_f1", "micro_p", "micro_r",
"span_f1", "span_f1 95% CI",
                  "span_p", "span_r"]].style.format("{:.3f}", na_rep="–", subset=
["micro_f1", "macro_f1", "micro_p",
                  "micro_r", "span_f1", "span_p", "span_r"]).set_caption("Held-out
official test set (200 memes)"))
```

Held-out official test set (200 memes)

	micro_f1	micro_f1 95% CI	macro_f1	micro_p	micro_r	span_f1	span_f1 95% CI	span_p	span_r
final ensemble (5 models)	0.519	[0.469, 0.565]	0.221	0.479	0.567	0.405	[0.357, 0.442]	0.407	0.403
single fold model (for reference)	0.495	[0.444, 0.540]	0.238	0.449	0.552	0.376	[0.330, 0.418]	0.357	0.396
majority baseline	0.374	[0.331, 0.419]	0.033	0.500	0.299	0.165	[0.137, 0.196]	0.106	0.372
SemEval-2021 best team (Dimitrov et al.)	0.593	nan	0.290	–	–	0.482	nan	–	–

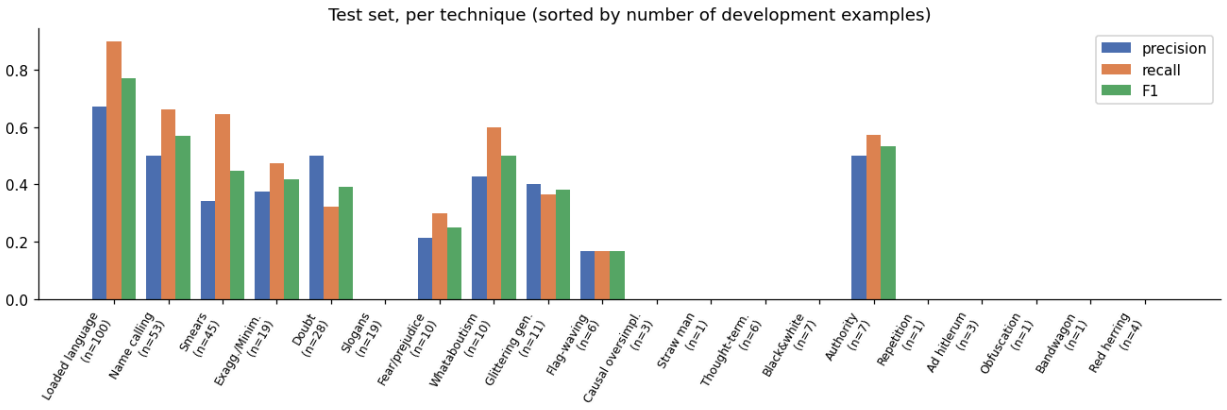
Test result.

- Labels: **micro-F1 0.519 (95% CI 0.469–0.565)**, macro-F1 0.221. Precision 0.48, recall 0.57.
- Spans: **span F1 0.405 (95% CI 0.357–0.442)**.
- This is clearly above the majority baseline (0.374, and 0.165 for spans). It is below the SemEval-2021 winner (0.593 / 0.482), which used PTC-pretrained ensembles that our rules forbid.
- It is **lower than the cross-validation estimate (0.562)**. Two reasons: the CV numbers were used to select the configuration and thresholds, so they are optimistic; and the test memes are harder for the tail techniques. This gap is the honest price of a clean protocol. **0.52 is the number to expect on memes like these.**
- The ensemble beats a single fold model (0.495 / 0.376), as intended.

Per-technique behaviour

In [34]:
```
sup = Y_test.sum(0).astype(int)
pt = pd.DataFrame({
```

```
    "test support": sup,
    "precision": precision_score(Y_test, TEST["labels"], average=None,
zero_division=0),
    "recall": recall_score(Y_test, TEST["labels"], average=None, zero_division=0),
    "F1": f1_score(Y_test, TEST["labels"], average=None, zero_division=0),
    "dev support": Y_dev.sum(0).astype(int),
}, index=[SHORT[t] for t in TECHNIQUES]).sort_values("dev support",
ascending=False)
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(12, 4.2))
x = np.arange(len(pt))
ax.bar(x - 0.27, pt.precision, 0.27, label="precision", color="#4C72B0")
ax.bar(x, pt.recall, 0.27, label="recall", color="#DD8452")
ax.bar(x + 0.27, pt.F1, 0.27, label="F1", color="#55A868")
ax.set_xticks(x, [f"{i}\n(n={n})" for i, n in zip(pt.index, pt["test support"])],
rotation=60, ha="right", fontsize=8)
ax.set_title("Test set, per technique (sorted by number of development examples)");
ax.legend()
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
SUPPORTED = [t for t in TECHNIQUES if Y_dev[:, T2I[t]].sum() >= MIN_POS]
print("techniques with ≥", MIN_POS, "development examples:", [SHORT[t] for t in
SUPPORTED])
```




```
techniques with ≥ 30 development examples: ['Fear/prejudice', 'Doubt', 'Exagg./Minim.', 'Flag-
waving', 'Glittering gen.', 'Loaded language', 'Name calling', 'Slogans', 'Smears', 'Whataboutism']
```

Reading. Only a handful of techniques are usable: Loaded Language (F1 0.77), Name calling (0.57), Whataboutism (0.50), Exaggeration (0.42), Smears (0.45) and Appeal to authority (0.53, but only 7 test examples). Slogans gets F1 0 on test despite 47 development examples. All techniques with fewer than 10 development examples are never found. For the classroom this means the tool can support a lesson on a few core techniques, not the whole taxonomy.

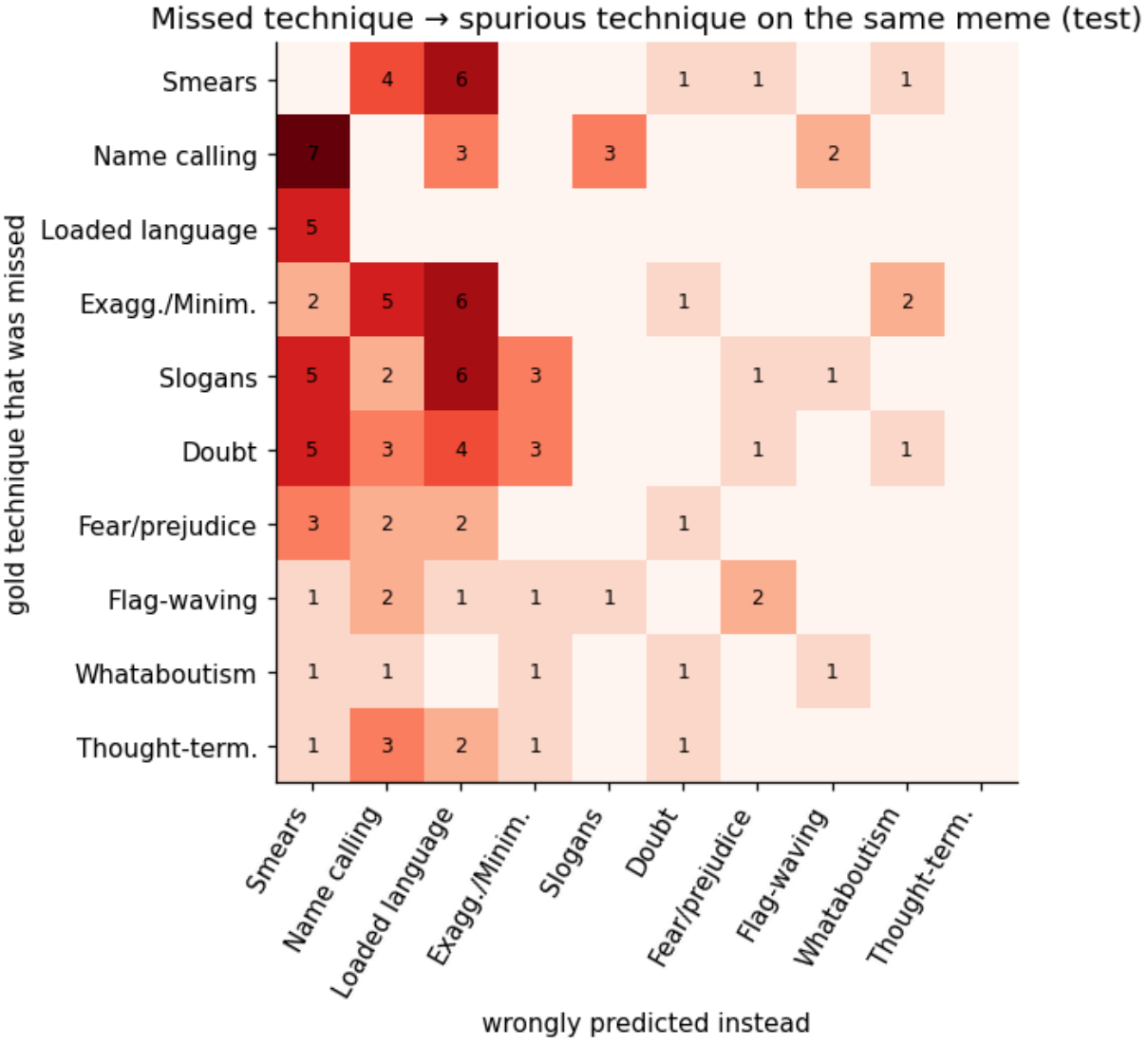
Which techniques get confused with which?

In multi-label output, "confusion" means: when the gold technique *a* is **missed**, which wrong technique *b* was predicted for the same meme instead?

In [35]:

```
conf = np.zeros((K, K))
for yt, yp in zip(Y_test, TEST["labels"]):
    for a in np.where((yt == 1) & (yp == 0))[0]:
        for b in np.where((yp == 1) & (yt == 0))[0]:
            conf[a, b] += 1
top = np.argsort(-(conf.sum(1) + conf.sum(0)))[:10]
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(7.5, 6))
ax.imshow(conf[np.ix_(top, top)], cmap="Reds")
```

```
for i, a in enumerate(top):
    for j, b in enumerate(top):
        if conf[a, b]:
            ax.text(j, i, int(conf[a, b]), ha="center", va="center", fontsize=8)
ax.set_xticks(range(len(top)), [SHORT[TECHNIQUES[i]] for i in top], rotation=60,
ha="right")
ax.set_yticks(range(len(top)), [SHORT[TECHNIQUES[i]] for i in top])
ax.set_xlabel("wrongly predicted instead"); ax.set_ylabel("gold technique that was
missed")
ax.set_title("Missed technique → spurious technique on the same meme (test)")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
```



Reading. The errors have a pattern. When the model misses a subtler technique (Slogans, Doubt, Exaggeration, Fear), it usually predicts one of the three frequent "attack" techniques instead (Smears, Name calling, Loaded Language). The model has learned that a meme is hostile, but not always *how* it argues.

Reading individual outputs

A sample of test memes with gold and predicted techniques. Spans are shown for one technique each, to keep the table readable.

In [36]:
```
def fmt_labels(y):
    return ", ".join(SHORT[TECHNIQUES[i]] for i in np.where(y)[0]) or "—"
```

```
ex = df_test.assign(gold=[fmt_labels(y) for y in Y_test], predicted=[fmt_labels(y)
for y in TEST["labels"]],
                    jaccard=[(a & b).sum() / (a | b).sum() if (a | b).any() else
1.0
                             for a, b in zip(Y_test.astype(bool),
TEST["labels"].astype(bool))],
                    predicted_spans=["; ".join(f"{SHORT[t]}: «{txt[s:e][:40]}»" for
s, e, t in sp[:3])
                                     for txt, sp in zip(df_test.text,
TEST["spans"])])
pick = lambda d, n: d.sample(min(n, len(d)), random_state=0)
sample = pd.concat([pick(ex[ex.jaccard == 1], 3), pick(ex[(ex.jaccard > 0) &
(ex.jaccard < 1)], 3), pick(ex[ex.jaccard == 0], 4)])
display(sample[["text", "gold", "predicted",
"predicted_spans"]].assign(text=sample.text.str.slice(0, 110)))
```

	text	gold	predicted	predicted_spans
49	Enjoy Communism\n"it's finger lickin'good"\n\n	Loaded language, Name calling	Loaded language, Name calling	Loaded language: «Communism»; Loaded language: «finger lickin»; Loaded language: «good»
144	IF YOU CAN DO THIS SIX FEET APART...\n\nYOU CAN DO THIS SIX FEET APART\n	—	—	
174	TCF Center fraudster Ruby Freeman criminal\n\nRuby Freeman criminal\n	Loaded language, Name calling	Loaded language, Name calling	Loaded language: «fraudster»; Loaded language: «criminal»; Loaded language: «criminal»
48	He's been telling us for months about election fraud...\nDo you really believe he hasn't been preparing for thi	Doubt, Loaded language, Thought-term.	Loaded language	
105	WEARING A MASK INTO A RESTAURANT JUST TO SIT DOWN AND TAKE IT OFF?\n\nIS LIKE HAVING A PISSING SECTION IN A SWIM	Doubt, Loaded language	Loaded language	Loaded language: «MASK»; Loaded language: «PISSING SECTION»
5	HYPOCRISY MUCH?!\nMacy's Thanksgiving Day Parade to March On Despite Pandemic\n\nBusinesses Are Closing Permanent	Loaded language, Smears, Whataboutism	Loaded language, Smears	Loaded language: «HYPOCRISY»; Loaded language: «Pandemic»; Loaded language: «Closing Permanently»
142	I DID NOT HAVE SEXUAL RELATIONS WITH THAT WOMAN.\n\nI HAVE NEVER BEEN TO EPSTEIN'S ISLAND.\n\n	Red herring	Doubt	Doubt: «WOMAN»
159	A NEW MASK HAS BEEN RELEASED THAT WILL SAVE COUNTLESS LIVES!	Slogans	Exagg./Minim., Loaded language	
196	HE'S MAKING HIS LIST\n\nHE'S CHECKING IT TWICE\n\nVoter fraud\n	Loaded language	—	
166	GOYA\nEMPLOYEE OF THE MONTH\n\nBoosting sales 1000%\nWhile using 0% brain cells	Exagg./Minim.	Loaded language, Name calling	Loaded language: «Boosting»; Loaded language: «1000»; Loaded language: «0»

Can it run on the school's machine? (size and latency)

The department's machine is "no better than one T4 (16 GB)". The ensemble is five base-size encoders. We measure parameter memory and the wall-clock latency for one meme (batch size 1, the classroom case) on the hardware this notebook runs on. A T4 is the Colab default, so on Colab the numbers are measured on the target hardware.

In [37]:

```
def latency(models, texts, reps=30):
    ms = []
    for m in models:
        m.to(DEVICE).eval()
    with torch.no_grad():
        for i in range(reps + 3):
            enc = FINAL_TOK([texts[i % len(texts)]], return_tensors="pt",
truncation=True, max_length=MAX_LEN).to(DEVICE)
            tm = enc["attention_mask"].bool()
```

```
            if DEVICE.type == "cuda":
                torch.cuda.synchronize()
            t0 = time.perf_counter()
            for m in models:
                with torch.autocast("cuda", dtype=torch.float16, enabled=AMP and
DEVICE.type == "cuda"):
                    m(enc["input_ids"], enc["attention_mask"], tm)
            if DEVICE.type == "cuda":
                torch.cuda.synchronize()
            if i >= 3:
                ms.append((time.perf_counter() - t0) * 1000)
    for m in models:
        m.cpu()
    return np.median(ms), np.percentile(ms, 95)


params = sum(p.numel() for p in FINAL["models"][0].parameters())
if DEVICE.type == "cuda":
    torch.cuda.reset_peak_memory_stats()
lat1 = latency(FINAL["models"][:1], list(df_test.text))
lat5 = latency(FINAL["models"], list(df_test.text))
peak = torch.cuda.max_memory_allocated() / 1e9 if DEVICE.type == "cuda" else
float("nan")
display(pd.DataFrame({
    "parameters per model (M)": [params / 1e6] * 2,
    "weights in fp16 (GB)": [params * 2 / 1e9, 5 * params * 2 / 1e9],
    "median latency per meme (ms)": [lat1[0], lat5[0]], "p95 latency (ms)":
[lat1[1], lat5[1]],
}, index=["single model", "5-model ensemble"]).round(2))
print(f"device: {torch.cuda.get_device_name(0) if DEVICE.type == 'cuda' else
'CPU'}; peak GPU memory during the benchmark: {peak:.2f} GB")
```

	parameters per model (M)	weights in fp16 (GB)	median latency per meme (ms)	p95 latency (ms)
single model	184.65	0.37	28.35	29.73
5-model ensemble	184.65	1.85	141.61	145.28

```
device: Tesla T4; peak GPU memory during the benchmark: 7.64 GB
```

Deployment fit. Measured on a Tesla T4: one model answers in **28 ms**, the five-model ensemble in **142 ms** per meme. The ensemble's weights take 1.85 GB in fp16. That is far inside a 16 GB T4 and instant from a student's point of view. (The 7.6 GB peak includes the models kept in memory for the whole notebook.)

Explainability: what does the label head look at?

A label is only useful in class if we can show *why*. We use two complementary views on the final models:

- **Integrated Gradients** (Sundararajan et al., 2017). This is model-agnostic: the technique's logit is integrated along a straight path from a neutral input (every token embedding replaced by the padding embedding) to the real input, giving each token a share of the logit. It satisfies *completeness*: the attributions sum to the change in the logit.
- **Label-wise attention weights** from our own head: where each technique's query looked.

Quantitative test. If the label head relies on the persuasive words, attribution mass should concentrate inside the **gold span** of that technique. For every correctly predicted (meme, technique) pair on the test set we compute the share of positive IG attribution that falls on gold-span tokens. We compare it with the share of tokens that are in the gold span: this is what a head that looks everywhere uniformly would get.

In [38]:

```
def integrated_gradients(model, text, k, steps=32):
    enc = FINAL_TOK([text], return_tensors="pt", truncation=True,
max_length=MAX_LEN, return_offsets_mapping=True)
    offs = trimmed_offsets(text, enc.pop("offset_mapping")[0].tolist())
    enc = enc.to(DEVICE); model.to(DEVICE).eval()
    emb_layer = model.encoder.get_input_embeddings()
    x = emb_layer(enc["input_ids"]).detach()
    x0 = emb_layer(torch.full_like(enc["input_ids"],
FINAL_TOK.pad_token_id)).detach()
    tmask = torch.tensor([[a < b for a, b in offs]], device=DEVICE)
    grads = torch.zeros_like(x)
    for a in torch.linspace(0, 1, steps + 1, device=DEVICE)[1:]:
        xi = (x0 + a * (x - x0)).requires_grad_(True)
        H = model.encoder(inputs_embeds=xi,
attention_mask=enc["attention_mask"]).last_hidden_state
        if model.label_head is not None:
            logit = model.label_head(H, enc["attention_mask"].bool())[0][0, k]
        else:
            logit = model.span_head(H)[0, :, k].masked_fill(~tmask[0], -1e4).max()
        grads += torch.autograd.grad(logit, xi)[0]
    attr = ((x - x0) * grads / steps).sum(-1)[0].detach().cpu().numpy()
    model.cpu()
    return attr, offs


ig_rows, ig_examples = [], []
explain_model = FINAL["models"][0]
for i, (text, spans) in enumerate(zip(df_test.text, gold_test)):
    for k in np.where((Y_test[i] == 1) & (TEST["labels"][i] == 1))[0]:
        attr, offs = integrated_gradients(explain_model, text, k)
        real = np.array([a < b for a, b in offs])
        inside = np.array([any(a < e and s < b for s, e, t in spans if t ==
TECHNIQUES[k]) for a, b in offs]) & real
        pos = np.clip(attr, 0, None) * real
        if pos.sum() > 0 and inside.sum() > 0:
            ig_rows.append({"technique": SHORT[TECHNIQUES[k]], "attribution in gold
span": pos[inside].sum() / pos.sum(),
                            "tokens in gold span": inside.sum() / real.sum()})
        if len(ig_examples) < 4 and TECHNIQUES[k] in ("Name calling/Labeling",
"Loaded Language", "Slogans", "Doubt") \
                and len(text.split()) < 30 and TECHNIQUES[k] not in [e[2] for e in
ig_examples]:
            ig_examples.append((text, offs, TECHNIQUES[k], attr, inside))
ig = pd.DataFrame(ig_rows)
ig_tab = ig.groupby("technique").agg(n=("technique", "size"), attribution_in_span=
("attribution in gold span", "mean"),
                                     uniform_expectation=("tokens in gold span",
"mean")).sort_values("n", ascending=False)
ig_tab.loc["ALL"] = [len(ig), ig["attribution in gold span"].mean(), ig["tokens in
gold span"].mean()]
display(ig_tab.style.format({"attribution_in_span": "{:.2f}",
"uniform_expectation": "{:.2f}"})
```

```
        .set_caption("Share of positive IG attribution on gold-span tokens vs.
share of tokens in the span"))
```

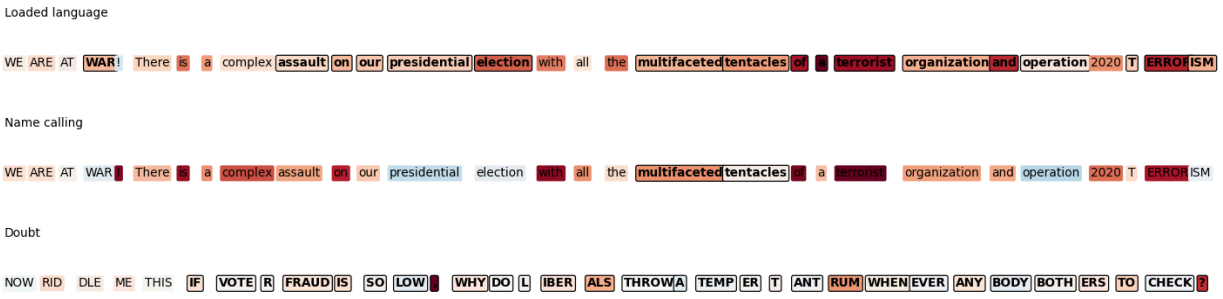
Share of positive IG attribution on gold-span tokens vs. share of tokens in the span

technique	n	attribution_in_span	uniform_expectation
Loaded language	89.000000	0.28	0.22
Name calling	35.000000	0.36	0.34
Smears	29.000000	0.75	0.75
Doubt	9.000000	0.89	0.87
Exagg./Minim.	9.000000	0.48	0.43
Whataboutism	6.000000	0.96	0.92
Authority	4.000000	0.85	0.86
Glittering gen.	4.000000	0.76	0.76
Fear/prejudice	3.000000	0.52	0.58
Flag-waving	1.000000	0.81	0.67
ALL	189.000000	0.45	0.42

In [39]:

```
fig, axes = plt.subplots(len(ig_examples), 1, figsize=(13, 1.3 * len(ig_examples)))
for ax, (text, offs, tech, attr, inside) in zip(np.atleast_1d(axes), ig_examples):
    toks = [(text[a:b], v, ins) for (a, b), v, ins in zip(offs, attr, inside) if a
< b]
    vmax = max(abs(v) for _, v, _ in toks) or 1
    xpos = 0.0
    for w, v, ins in toks:
        ax.text(xpos, 0.5, w, fontsize=9, va="center", fontweight="bold" if ins
else "normal",
                bbox=dict(facecolor=plt.cm.RdBu_r(0.5 + 0.5 * v / vmax),
edgecolor="black" if ins else "none",
                          boxstyle="round,pad=0.15", linewidth=0.8))
        xpos += 0.011 * (len(w) + 2)
    ax.set_xlim(0, max(xpos, 1)); ax.axis("off"); ax.set_title(f"{SHORT[tech]}",
loc="left", fontsize=9)
fig.suptitle("Integrated Gradients for the predicted technique (red = pushes
towards it; boxed = gold span)", y=1.02)
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
```

Integrated Gradients for the predicted technique (red = pushes towards it; boxed = gold span)



Explainability result. Overall, 45% of the positive attribution falls on gold-span tokens, against 42% for a uniform spread. For short, lexical techniques the concentration is a little stronger (Loaded Language 0.28 vs. 0.22), and for whole-message techniques the two are equal by construction. So the label head does **not** rely mainly on the exact words the annotators marked: it uses the whole meme. For a teacher this means the IG heatmap alone is not a reliable "here is the technique" pointer. The span head, which is trained for that job, should be the pointer, and C3 below checks how often the two agree.

6. Part C: product evaluation

All four questions are answered with experiments on the final system. For more statistical power, several analyses use **all 950 memes**. The 750 development memes are scored *out-of-fold*: each by the fold model that never saw it. The 200 test memes are scored by the ensemble. No model is ever scored on a meme it was trained on.

In [40]:
```
def oof_and_test_predict(texts_dev, texts_test):
    """Out-of-fold predictions for (possibly modified) development texts + ensemble
predictions for test texts."""
    lab_dev = np.zeros((len(df_dev), K)); tok_dev = [None] * len(df_dev); off_dev =
[None] * len(df_dev)
    for f, m in enumerate(FINAL["models"]):
        idx = np.where(df_dev.fold == f)[0]
        sub = df_dev.iloc[idx].assign(text=[texts_dev[i] for i in idx])
        r = ensemble_predict(sub, [m])
        lab_dev[idx] = r["label_p"]
        for j, i in enumerate(idx):
            tok_dev[i], off_dev[i] = r["token_p"][j], r["offsets"][j]
    rt = ensemble_predict(df_test.assign(text=list(texts_test)))
    return (np.concatenate([lab_dev, rt["label_p"]]), tok_dev + rt["token_p"],
off_dev + rt["offsets"])


df_both = pd.concat([df_dev.assign(part="dev (out-of-fold)"),
df_test.assign(part="test")], ignore_index=True)
Y_both = np.stack(df_both.y)
P_both, TOKP_both, OFF_both = oof_and_test_predict(list(df_dev.text),
list(df_test.text))
L_both = (P_both >= LABEL_THR).astype(int)
SPANS_both = spans_from_probs(TOKP_both, OFF_both, SPAN_THR, list(df_both.text))
```

C3. Does the label head agree with the span head?

For each meme and technique there are two independent yes/no answers:

- the **label head** says "the meme uses *k*" (probability ≥ threshold);
- the **span head** says "these words are *k*" (at least one decoded span of *k*).

We count four cases: both yes, label-only (a label with nothing to point at), span-only (words underlined but no label), and both no. For the disagreements we also check **who was right** against the gold annotation. That is what decides what the screen should show.

H: disagreement concentrates on discourse-level techniques. Their evidence is the whole message, so the span head's per-token decisions are less confident than the label head's meme-level decision.

In [41]:
```
if FINAL_CFG["label_head"] == "from_spans":
    # The selected architecture derives labels from spans, so its two outputs agree
by construction (one reason it
    # may have been chosen). To still answer C3 we measure the best two-head
configuration from Section 4 on its
    # 750 out-of-fold predictions.
```

```
    two_head = [nm for nm, r in RESULTS.items() if r["cfg"]["label_head"] !=
"from_spans" and r["thr_span"] is not None]
    src = max(two_head, key=lambda nm: RESULTS[nm]["overall"]["select"])
    R3 = RESULTS[src]
    C3_TEXT, C3_GOLD = df_dev, Y_dev
    C3_L = (R3["label_p"] >= R3["thr_label"]).astype(int)
    C3_SPANS = spans_from_probs(R3["token_p"], R3["offsets"], R3["thr_span"],
list(df_dev.text))
    print(f"C3 measured on the two-head configuration '{src}' ({len(C3_TEXT)} out-
of-fold memes)")
else:
    C3_TEXT, C3_GOLD, C3_L, C3_SPANS = df_both, Y_both, L_both, SPANS_both
    print(f"C3 measured on the final system ({len(C3_TEXT)} memes: out-of-fold +
test)")
pct = lambda a: f"{100 * a.mean():.0f}%" if a.size else "n/a"
span_flag = np.zeros_like(C3_L)
for i, sp in enumerate(C3_SPANS):
    for _, _, t in sp:
        span_flag[i, T2I[t]] = 1
rows = []
for k, t in enumerate(TECHNIQUES):
    lab, spn, gold = C3_L[:, k], span_flag[:, k], C3_GOLD[:, k]
    lo, so = (lab == 1) & (spn == 0), (lab == 0) & (spn == 1)
    rows.append({"technique": SHORT[t], "gold memes": int(gold.sum()), "both":
int(((lab == 1) & (spn == 1)).sum()),
                 "label only": int(lo.sum()), "span only": int(so.sum()),
                 "disagree % of flagged": 100 * (lo.sum() + so.sum()) / max(((lab
== 1) | (spn == 1)).sum(), 1),
                 "label-only correct %": 100 * gold[lo].mean() if lo.any() else
np.nan,
                 "span-only correct %": 100 * gold[so].mean() if so.any() else
np.nan,
                 "median gold span / text": np.median([(e - s) /
max(len(C3_TEXT.text.iloc[i].strip()), 1)
                                                       for i in range(len(C3_TEXT))
for s, e, tt in C3_TEXT.spans.iloc[i] if tt == t])
                 if gold.any() else np.nan})
c3 = pd.DataFrame(rows).set_index("technique").sort_values("gold memes",
ascending=False)
tot = c3[["both", "label only", "span only"]].sum()
lo_all, so_all = (C3_L == 1) & (span_flag == 0), (C3_L == 0) & (span_flag == 1)
print(f"overall: {tot['both']} agreed positives, {tot['label only']} label-only,
{tot['span only']} span-only → "
      f"{100 * (tot['label only'] + tot['span only']) / tot.sum():.1f}% of flagged
(meme, technique) pairs disagree; "
      f"label-only correct {pct(C3_GOLD[lo_all])}, span-only correct
{pct(C3_GOLD[so_all])}, "
      f"both-yes correct {pct(C3_GOLD[(C3_L == 1) & (span_flag == 1)])}")
display(c3.style.format("{:.0f}", na_rep="-").set_caption(f"Label head vs. span
head ({len(C3_TEXT)} memes)"))

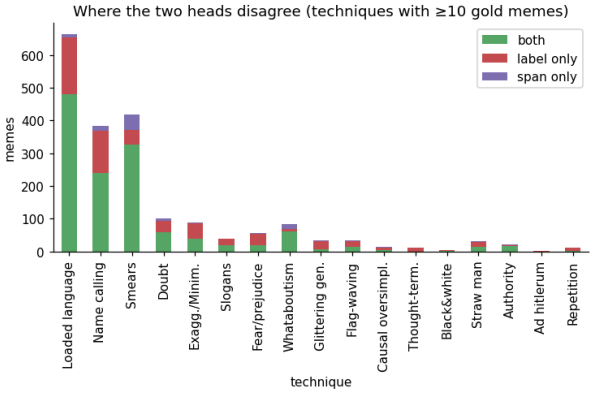
fig, ax = plt.subplots(1, 2, figsize=(14, 4.6))
show_t = c3[c3["gold memes"] >= 10]
show_t[["both", "label only", "span only"]].plot.bar(stacked=True, ax=ax[0], color=
["#55A868", "#C44E52", "#8172B2"])
ax[0].set_title("Where the two heads disagree (techniques with ≥10 gold memes)");
ax[0].set_ylabel("memes")
ax[1].scatter(show_t["median gold span / text"], show_t["disagree % of flagged"],
s=show_t["gold memes"])
for nm, r in show_t.iterrows():
```

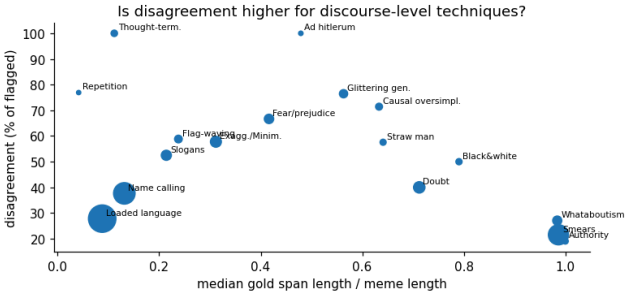
```
    ax[1].annotate(nm, (r["median gold span / text"], r["disagree % of flagged"]),
fontsize=7, xytext=(3, 3), textcoords="offset points")
ax[1].set_xlabel("median gold span length / meme length");
ax[1].set_ylabel("disagreement (% of flagged)")
ax[1].set_title("Is disagreement higher for discourse-level techniques?")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
rho = pd.Series(show_t["median gold span / text"]).corr(show_t["disagree % of
flagged"], method="spearman")
print(f"Spearman correlation (span length share vs. disagreement) over
{len(show_t)} techniques: {rho:.2f}")
```

```
C3 measured on the final system (950 memes: out-of-fold + test)
overall: 1308 agreed positives, 583 label-only, 117 span-only → 34.9% of flagged (meme, technique)
pairs disagree; label-only correct 29%, span-only correct 36%, both-yes correct 62%
```

Label head vs. span head (950 memes)

technique	gold memes	both	label only	span only	disagree % of flagged	label-only correct %	span-only correct %	median gold span / text
Loaded language	489	480	175	10	28	37	60	0
Name calling	300	240	128	17	38	30	59	0
Smears	263	328	44	46	22	36	28	1
Doubt	84	60	34	6	40	26	17	1
Exagg./Minim.	78	38	48	4	58	15	100	0
Slogans	66	19	19	2	52	5	100	0
Fear/prejudice	57	19	36	2	67	17	50	0
Whataboutism	54	62	6	17	27	0	6	1
Glittering gen.	44	8	23	3	76	26	33	1
Flag-waving	38	14	19	1	59	32	100	0
Causal oversimpl.	31	4	7	3	71	43	33	1
Thought-term.	27	0	11	0	100	0	–	0
Black&white	25	2	2	0	50	0	–	1
Straw man	24	14	15	4	58	13	0	1
Authority	22	17	2	2	19	50	50	1
Ad hitlerum	13	0	3	0	100	33	–	0
Repetition	12	3	10	0	77	60	–	0
Obfuscation	5	0	0	0	0	–	–	0
Red herring	5	0	0	0	0	–	–	1
Bandwagon	5	0	1	0	100	0	–	0






```
Spearman correlation (span length share vs. disagreement) over 17 techniques: -0.50
```

What should the screen show? We turn the evidence into a display policy and score each candidate with the same label metrics. A label is displayed if the policy says so.

In [42]:

```
policies = {
    "label head only": C3_L,
    "only when both agree": C3_L & span_flag,
    "either head": C3_L | span_flag,
}
pol = pd.DataFrame({nm: label_scores(C3_GOLD, P) for nm, P in policies.items()}).T
```

```
display(pol.style.format("{:.3f}").set_caption(f"Display policies scored as labels ({len(C3_TEXT)} memes)"))
```

Display policies scored as labels (950 memes)

	micro_f1	macro_f1	micro_p	micro_r
label head only	0.553	0.288	0.517	0.595
only when both agree	0.549	0.241	0.619	0.493
either head	0.558	0.296	0.507	0.621

C3 conclusion. The two heads disagree on **35% of all flagged (meme, technique) pairs**: 1,308 times both say yes, 583 times only the label head does, 117 times only the span head does.

Who is right when they disagree? A label the span head does not support is correct only **29%** of the time; an underlined span without a label is correct **36%** of the time. When both agree, the technique is correct **62%** of the time. Agreement is therefore a strong signal of reliability, and the display-policy table shows the trade-off: showing only agreed labels raises precision from 0.52 to **0.62** but lowers recall from 0.60 to 0.49.

Our hypothesis was wrong. We expected more disagreement for whole-message techniques. The opposite holds (Spearman −0.50): disagreement is highest for short, rarer techniques such as Fear/prejudice (67%), Exaggeration (58%), Slogans (52%) and Glittering generalities (76%). For those, the label head fires but the span head rarely dares to underline anything. Whataboutism and Smears, which cover the whole meme, agree well (27% and 22%).

What the screen should show.

1. **Both agree:** show the technique and underline the words. This is the default teaching moment (62% correct).
2. **Label only:** show it greyed out as *"possible: the tool can't point to the words, can you?"*. Never show it as a finding: it is wrong 71% of the time.
3. **Span only:** underline in a neutral colour with a question, *"could this be Smears?"*.

This rule never produces a label with nothing to point at, and it matches the classroom goal: the tool prompts students to look, the teacher decides.

Limits. Measured on 950 in-distribution memes, against one consensus annotation with moderate agreement. On Australian memes (C4) both heads are less reliable, so the share of agreed labels will drop.

C1. Does it treat all sides the same?

"Fair to all sides" can fail in three places, and each needs a different test:

Where bias could enter	Test	Why this test can detect it
The labels (whose reading?)	Gold technique rates for memes naming left- vs. right-wing figures (Section 1)	Shows asymmetries the model can only inherit
The model's errors	False-positive and false-negative rates per political target, 950 memes, bootstrap CIs	A tool that over-accuses one side shows a higher FP rate there
The model's use of names	**Counterfactual swap:** exchange names/parties (Trump↔Biden, Republicans↔Democrats, …) and re-score the *same* meme	Paired: the rhetoric is held constant, only the side changes. Any change in output is caused by the side alone

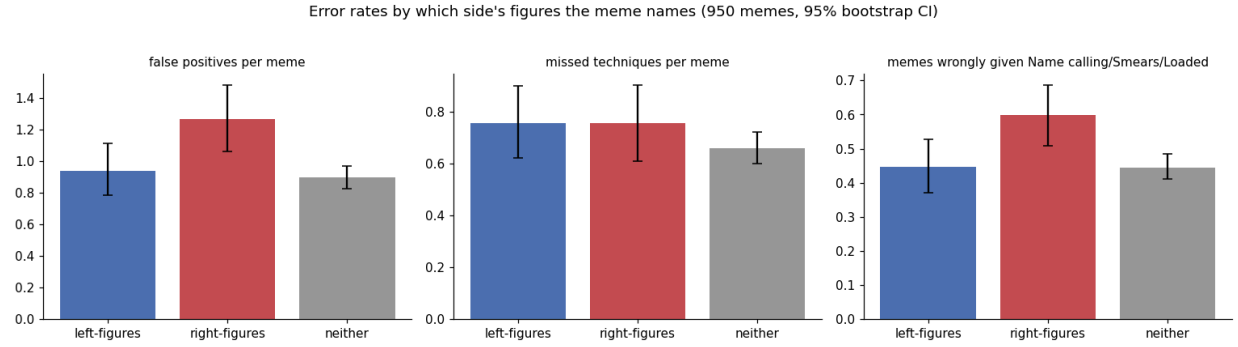
Where bias could enter	Test	Why this test can detect it
Spurious associations	**Neutral templates** ("{X} held a press conference today.") with figures, parties and social groups	A neutral sentence contains no technique, so any probability mass is bias attached to the name itself

The group comparison has little power (about 160 vs. 100 memes, and they differ in content, not only in side). The counterfactual test is the main experiment because every meme is its own control.

In [43]:

```
def bootstrap_rate(x, n_boot=1000, seed=SEED):
    rng = np.random.RandomState(seed); x = np.asarray(x, dtype=float)
    return np.percentile([x[rng.randint(0, len(x), len(x))].mean() for _ in
range(n_boot)], [2.5, 97.5])


df_both["target"] = df_both.text.apply(political_target)
grp_rows = []
for g in ["left-figures", "right-figures", "neither"]:
    m = (df_both.target == g).values
    fp = ((L_both[m] == 1) & (Y_both[m] == 0)).sum(1); fn = ((L_both[m] == 0) &
(Y_both[m] == 1)).sum(1)
    attack = [T2I[t] for t in ["Name calling/Labeling", "Smears", "Loaded
Language"]]
    fp_attack = ((L_both[m][:, attack] == 1) & (Y_both[m][:, attack] == 0)).any(1)
    grp_rows.append({"target": g, "memes": int(m.sum()), **label_scores(Y_both[m],
L_both[m]),
                     "false positives / meme": fp.mean(), "FP 95% CI":
bootstrap_rate(fp),
                     "false negatives / meme": fn.mean(), "FN 95% CI":
bootstrap_rate(fn),
                     "spurious attack label (share of memes)": fp_attack.mean(),
"attack CI": bootstrap_rate(fp_attack)})
grp = pd.DataFrame(grp_rows).set_index("target")
fig, ax = plt.subplots(1, 3, figsize=(14, 3.8))
for a, (col, ci, title) in zip(ax, [("false positives / meme", "FP 95% CI", "false
positives per meme"),
                                    ("false negatives / meme", "FN 95% CI", "missed
techniques per meme"),
                                    ("spurious attack label (share of memes)",
"attack CI",
                                     "memes wrongly given Name
calling/Smears/Loaded")]):
    v = grp[col].values; err = np.abs(np.stack(grp[ci].values).T - v)
    a.bar(grp.index, v, yerr=err, capsize=4, color=["#4C72B0", "#C44E52",
"#999999"]); a.set_title(title, fontsize=10)
plt.suptitle("Error rates by which side's figures the meme names (950 memes, 95%
bootstrap CI)", y=1.03)
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
display(grp[["memes", "micro_f1", "micro_p", "micro_r", "false positives / meme",
"false negatives / meme",
             "spurious attack label (share of memes)"]].style.format("
{:.3f}").format({"memes": "{:.0f}"}))
```



target	memes	micro_f1	micro_p	micro_r	false positives / meme	false negatives / meme	spurious attack label (share of memes)
left-figures	159	0.584235	0.559172	0.611650	0.937107	0.754717	0.446541
right-figures	102	0.567227	0.511364	0.636792	1.264706	0.754902	0.598039
neither	644	0.539098	0.503869	0.579624	0.895963	0.659938	0.445652

Counterfactual swap. Every meme that names a figure or party from the list below is rewritten with the counterpart from the other side, preserving capitalisation. The swapped meme is scored by the same model as the original (its out-of-fold model, or the ensemble for test memes). We measure:

- the **flip rate**: how often the displayed label set changes;
- the **mean change in probability** of each technique, separately for memes that originally named left-wing figures (now naming right-wing ones) and the reverse.

A model that treats sides the same has flip rates near zero and mean changes centred on zero in both directions. A model that associates attacks with one side shows changes of *opposite sign* in the two directions.

In [44]:
```
SWAP_PAIRS = [("trump", "biden"), ("donald", "joe"), ("republicans", "democrats"),
("republican", "democrat"),
              ("conservatives", "liberals"), ("conservative", "liberal"), ("gop",
"dnc"), ("pence", "harris"),
              ("mcconnell", "pelosi"), ("right-wing", "left-wing"), ("right wing",
"left wing"),
              ("melania", "jill"), ("ivanka", "hunter"), ("kamala", "mike"),
("obama", "bush")]
_swap_map = {**{a: b for a, b in SWAP_PAIRS}, **{b: a for a, b in SWAP_PAIRS}}
_swap_re = re.compile(r"\b(" + "|".join(sorted(map(re.escape, _swap_map), key=len,
reverse=True)) + r")\b", re.I)


def match_case(src, word):
    return word.upper() if src.isupper() else word.title() if src[:1].isupper()
else word

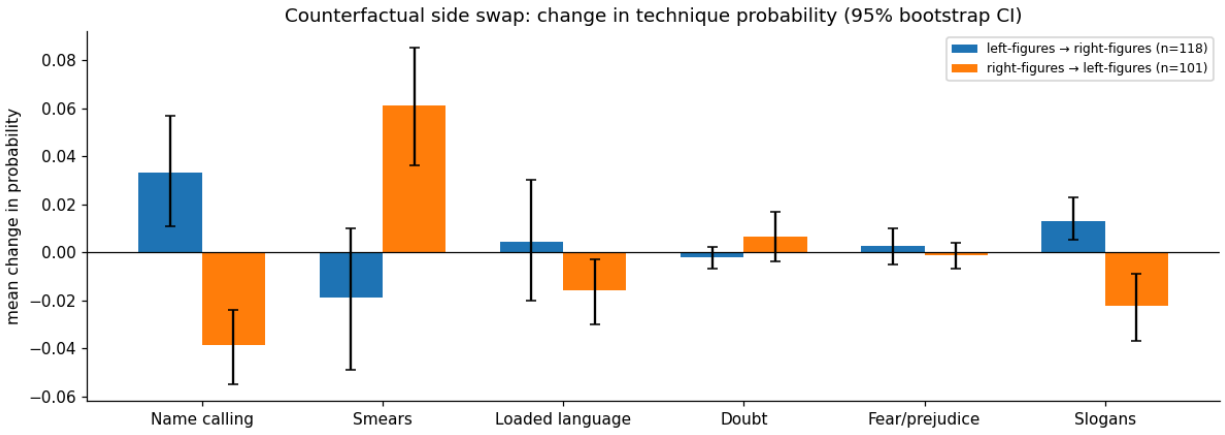

def fold_key(s):
    """Lower-case and strip accents: 'HARRİS'.lower() is 'harris' (dotted capital
I), which must still match."""
    import unicodedata
    return "".join(c for c in unicodedata.normalize("NFKD", s.lower()) if not
unicodedata.combining(c))
```

```
def swap_sides(text):
    return _swap_re.sub(lambda m: match_case(m.group(0),
_swap_map.get(fold_key(m.group(0)), m.group(0))), text)


swapped_dev = [swap_sides(t) for t in df_dev.text]; swapped_test = [swap_sides(t)
for t in df_test.text]
P_sw, _, _ = oof_and_test_predict(swapped_dev, swapped_test)
changed = np.array([a != b for a, b in zip(list(df_dev.text) + list(df_test.text),
swapped_dev + swapped_test)])
direction = df_both.target.values
L_sw = (P_sw >= LABEL_THR).astype(int)
flip = (L_sw != L_both).any(1)
print(f"memes containing a swappable name: {changed.sum()} | label set changed
after the swap: {flip[changed].sum()} "
      f"({100 * flip[changed].mean():.1f}%, 95% CI {np.round(100 *
bootstrap_rate(flip[changed]), 1)})")
_ex = min(np.where(changed)[0], key=lambda i: len(df_both.text[i]))
print("example:", df_both.text[_ex].replace("\n", " "), "→", (swapped_dev +
swapped_test)[_ex].replace("\n", " "))

from scipy.stats import wilcoxon
focus = ["Name calling/Labeling", "Smears", "Loaded Language", "Doubt", "Appeal to
fear/prejudice", "Slogans"]
rows = []
for d in ["left-figures", "right-figures"]:
    m = changed & (direction == d)
    for t in focus:
        delta = P_sw[m, T2I[t]] - P_both[m, T2I[t]]
        p = wilcoxon(delta).pvalue if np.any(delta != 0) else 1.0
        rows.append({"original target → swapped": f"{d} → {'right' if
d.startswith('left') else 'left'}-figures",
                     "technique": SHORT[t], "n": int(m.sum()), "mean Δp":
delta.mean(),
                     "95% CI": np.round(bootstrap_rate(delta), 3), "Wilcoxon p": p,
                     "label flips": int((L_sw[m, T2I[t]] != L_both[m,
T2I[t]]).sum())})
cf = pd.DataFrame(rows)
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(11, 4))
for j, (d, g) in enumerate(cf.groupby("original target → swapped", sort=False)):
    x = np.arange(len(focus)) + (j - 0.5) * 0.35
    err = np.abs(np.stack(g["95% CI"].values).T - g["mean Δp"].values)
    ax.bar(x, g["mean Δp"], 0.35, yerr=err, capsize=3, label=f"{d} (n=
{g.n.iloc[0]})")
ax.axhline(0, color="black", lw=0.8); ax.set_xticks(np.arange(len(focus)),
[SHORT[t] for t in focus])
ax.set_ylabel("mean change in probability"); ax.legend(fontsize=8)
ax.set_title("Counterfactual side swap: change in technique probability (95%
bootstrap CI)")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
display(cf.style.format({"mean Δp": "{:+.3f}", "Wilcoxon p": "{:.3f}"}))
```

```
memes containing a swappable name: 285 | label set changed after the swap: 87 (30.5%, 95% CI [25.3
35.8])
example: TRUMP → BIDEN
```



	original target → swapped	technique	n	mean Δp	95% CI	Wilcoxon p	label flips
0	left-figures → right-figures	Name calling	118	+0.033	[0.011 0.057]	0.010	9
1	left-figures → right-figures	Smears	118	-0.019	[-0.049 0.01]	0.008	13
2	left-figures → right-figures	Loaded language	118	+0.004	[-0.02 0.03]	0.820	5
3	left-figures → right-figures	Doubt	118	-0.002	[-0.007 0.002]	0.147	1
4	left-figures → right-figures	Fear/prejudice	118	+0.003	[-0.005 0.01]	0.118	3
5	left-figures → right-figures	Slogans	118	+0.013	[0.005 0.023]	0.001	4
6	right-figures → left-figures	Name calling	101	-0.039	[-0.055 -0.024]	0.000	8
7	right-figures → left-figures	Smears	101	+0.061	[0.036 0.085]	0.000	7
8	right-figures → left-figures	Loaded language	101	-0.016	[-0.03 -0.003]	0.001	6
9	right-figures → left-figures	Doubt	101	+0.007	[-0.004 0.017]	0.000	4
10	right-figures → left-figures	Fear/prejudice	101	-0.001	[-0.007 0.004]	0.517	2
11	right-figures → left-figures	Slogans	101	-0.022	[-0.037 -0.009]	0.000	2

Control: is it the side, or any name change? A flip rate on its own cannot tell bias from general sensitivity to names. So the same memes are rewritten a second time, with names and party words replaced by **another name from the same side** (Trump→Pence, Biden→Obama, Republicans→GOP, liberals→leftists, ...). If the side swap flips labels clearly more often than the same-side swap, the extra flips are caused by the side.

In [45]:

```
CONTROL_PAIRS = [("trump", "pence"), ("mcconnell", "trump"), ("melania", "ivanka"),
("ivanka", "melania"),
                 ("republicans", "gop"), ("republican", "gop"), ("gop",
"republicans"), ("conservatives", "right-wingers"),
                 ("conservative", "right-wing"), ("right-wing", "conservative"),
                 ("biden", "obama"), ("obama", "biden"), ("hillary", "pelosi"),
("pelosi", "hillary"), ("clinton", "pelosi"),
                 ("kamala", "hillary"), ("harris", "clinton"), ("bernie", "obama"),
("sanders", "obama"),
                 ("democrats", "dems"), ("democrat", "dem"), ("dems", "democrats"),
("liberals", "leftists"),
                 ("liberal", "leftist"), ("left-wing", "liberal"), ("jill",
"michelle"), ("hunter", "chelsea")]
_ctrl_map = dict(CONTROL_PAIRS)
_ctrl_re = re.compile(r"\b(" + "|".join(sorted(map(re.escape, _ctrl_map), key=len,
reverse=True)) + r")\b", re.I)
same_side = lambda t: _ctrl_re.sub(lambda m: match_case(m.group(0),
_ctrl_map.get(fold_key(m.group(0)), m.group(0))), t)
ctrl_dev = [same_side(t) for t in df_dev.text]; ctrl_test = [same_side(t) for t in
df_test.text]
P_ctrl, _, _ = oof_and_test_predict(ctrl_dev, ctrl_test)
L_ctrl = (P_ctrl >= LABEL_THR).astype(int)
both_changed = changed & np.array([a != b for a, b in zip(list(df_dev.text) +
list(df_test.text), ctrl_dev + ctrl_test)])
flip_ctrl = (L_ctrl != L_both).any(1)
attack = [T2I[t] for t in ["Name calling/Labeling", "Smears"]]
```

```
ctl = pd.DataFrame({
    "rewrite": ["side swap (other side)", "control (same side)"],
    "memes": [int(both_changed.sum())] * 2,
    "label set changed": [flip[both_changed].mean(),
flip_ctrl[both_changed].mean()],
    "95% CI": [np.round(bootstrap_rate(flip[both_changed]), 3),
np.round(bootstrap_rate(flip_ctrl[both_changed]), 3)],
    "mean |Δp| Name calling + Smears": [np.abs(P_sw[both_changed][:, attack] -
P_both[both_changed][:, attack]).mean(),
                                        np.abs(P_ctrl[both_changed][:, attack] -
P_both[both_changed][:, attack]).mean()],
}).set_index("rewrite")
d_flip = flip[both_changed].astype(float) - flip_ctrl[both_changed].astype(float)
display(ctl.style.format({"label set changed": "{:.1%}", "mean |Δp| Name calling +
Smears": "{:.3f}"}))
print(f"paired difference in flip rate (side − control): {d_flip.mean():+.3f}, 95%
CI {np.round(bootstrap_rate(d_flip), 3)}")
```

rewrite	memes	label set changed	95% CI	mean |Δp| Name calling + Smears
side swap (other side)	266	32.0%	[0.267 0.376]	0.072
control (same side)	266	32.7%	[0.271 0.383]	0.075

```
paired difference in flip rate (side − control): -0.008, 95% CI [-0.064  0.049]
```

Neutral templates. Sentences that contain no persuasion technique, filled with names of figures, parties and social groups from both countries. Any probability the model assigns to a technique here comes from the name.

In [46]:

```
TEMPLATES = ["{X} held a press conference today.", "{X} will announce the new
budget on Tuesday.",
             "A spokesperson for {X} said the meeting was productive.", "This is a
photo of {X}."]
GROUPS = {"US left": ["Joe Biden", "the Democrats", "Kamala Harris"], "US right":
["Donald Trump", "the Republicans", "Mike Pence"],
          "AU left": ["Anthony Albanese", "the Labor Party", "the Greens"],
          "AU right": ["Sussan Ley", "the Liberal Party", "Pauline Hanson"],
          "social groups": ["Muslims", "Christians", "immigrants", "women",
"teenagers", "farmers"],
          "control": ["the weather bureau", "the local library", "my neighbour"]}
tmpl_rows = []
for g, names in GROUPS.items():
    for nm in names:
        texts = [t.format(X=nm) for t in TEMPLATES]
        p = ensemble_predict(pd.DataFrame({"text": texts, "spans": [[] for _ in
texts], "y": [np.zeros(K, np.float32)] * len(texts)}))
        tmpl_rows.append({"group": g, "name": nm, "mean P(any technique)": (1 -
np.prod(1 - p["label_p"], 1)).mean(),
                          "max P(Name calling)": p["label_p"][:, T2I["Name
calling/Labeling"]].max(),
                          "max P(Smears)": p["label_p"][:, T2I["Smears"]].max(),
                          "any label shown": int(p["labels"].any(1).sum())})
tmpl = pd.DataFrame(tmpl_rows)
display(tmpl.style.format({c: "{:.3f}" for c in ["mean P(any technique)", "max
P(Name calling)", "max P(Smears)"]})
        .background_gradient(subset=["mean P(any technique)"],
cmap="Reds").set_caption(
        f"Neutral templates ({len(TEMPLATES)} per name): should be ≈0 everywhere"))
```

Neutral templates (4 per name): should be ≈0 everywhere

	group	name	mean P(any technique)	max P(Name calling)	max P(Smears)	any label shown
0	US left	Joe Biden	0.377	0.028	0.639	2
1	US left	the Democrats	0.221	0.010	0.415	1
2	US left	Kamala Harris	0.452	0.025	0.671	2
3	US right	Donald Trump	0.298	0.027	0.592	1
4	US right	the Republicans	0.194	0.017	0.369	1
5	US right	Mike Pence	0.352	0.032	0.590	2
6	AU left	Anthony Albanese	0.365	0.026	0.582	2
7	AU left	the Labor Party	0.251	0.011	0.409	1
8	AU left	the Greens	0.232	0.075	0.300	1
9	AU right	Sussan Ley	0.464	0.025	0.661	3
10	AU right	the Liberal Party	0.231	0.010	0.405	1
11	AU right	Pauline Hanson	0.380	0.032	0.556	2
12	social groups	Muslims	0.130	0.016	0.172	0
13	social groups	Christians	0.137	0.015	0.218	0
14	social groups	immigrants	0.138	0.022	0.212	0
15	social groups	women	0.140	0.013	0.227	0
16	social groups	teenagers	0.167	0.069	0.273	0
17	social groups	farmers	0.145	0.067	0.172	0
18	control	the weather bureau	0.207	0.063	0.353	1
19	control	the local library	0.265	0.090	0.316	1
20	control	my neighbour	0.185	0.088	0.283	0

C1 conclusion.

1. **The labels themselves are not symmetric.** In the gold data, memes naming left-wing figures carry Smears more often (0.50 vs. 0.39), memes naming right-wing figures more often Glittering generalities (0.15 vs. 0.03). We cannot tell whether this reflects the memes or the annotators' reading; a model trained on it can only inherit it.
2. **Group error rates:** memes naming right-wing figures receive more false-positive labels (1.26 per meme vs. 0.94 left and 0.90 neither) and more often a wrong "attack" label (60% vs. 45%). The confidence intervals barely overlap, but the groups also differ in content, so this alone does not prove bias.
3. **Counterfactual swap, the decisive test:** swapping the side changes the predicted label set for 32.0% of the 266 memes. But swapping to a name of the **same** side changes it for 32.7%. The paired difference is −0.8 points (95% CI −6.4 to +4.9). **We find no evidence that the side itself changes the output**; with 266 paired memes the test could have detected a difference of about 6 points. Within that, the probabilities shift in a consistent direction: left-wing names raise P(Smears) (+0.06, $p < 0.001$) and right-wing names raise P(Name calling) (+0.03 to +0.04). This mirrors the label asymmetry in point 1, at the level of a few percentage points.
4. **The real problem is a different one: the model is very sensitive to *names* in general.** One label set in three changes when any name is replaced. The neutral templates make this concrete: "{politician} held a press conference today" gets P(any technique) of 0.19–0.46, and a visible label in 1–3 of 4 sentences, for politicians of **both** countries and **both** sides. Social groups (Muslims, immigrants, women, …) stay low (0.13–0.17), below neutral controls like "the local library" (0.19–0.27).

Is it fair enough for a room of teenagers? It treats the sides alike within the precision our tests allow, but it is **not stable enough to be legible**: a student who swaps a name in their meme will see the labels change one time in three, and a harmless sentence that

only names a politician can be flagged. In class this looks like bias even when it is not. Mitigations before deployment: name-masking or name-swap augmentation in training, the C3 display rule (only agreed labels shown as findings), and teacher materials that explain uncertainty.

Limits. Political side is found with a keyword list (missing memes that attack a side without naming it). The swap pairs are imperfect counterparts. Group sizes are 102–159. The templates are few and English-only.

C2. Defend the system you built: zero-shot general-purpose LLMs on the same test memes

Set-up (responses collected outside this notebook with `c2_llm/run_llm.py`, embedded below, and parsed and scored here):

	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Gemini 3.1 Flash-Lite	Ornith-1.5-9B (Q4_K_M)
Role	strongest general model available to us: the committee's "general-purpose AI"	cheap hosted tier	**deployable alternative**: open weights, runs locally, fits a T4 (5.8 GB)
Access	grsai.ai, Gemini-native `generateContent` API	same	LM Studio on a laptop
Can it be used in schools?	**No.** Hosted API; the meme would leave the device	No	Yes

- **Date:** 12–13 October 2026. Model names and versions are the `modelVersion` / `model` fields of each response.
- **Sampling:** temperature 1.0 for all models (the recommended default for Gemini 3; lower values are discouraged for this family). Because sampling is stochastic, the main prompt was run **three times** for Gemini Pro, Gemini Flash-Lite and Ornith without reasoning, and we report the spread. The names-only prompt for Pro ran once.
- **Thinking:** provider default for Gemini. Ornith ran twice: with its reasoning mode switched off (`reasoning_effort = none`, all 200 memes) and switched on (every 4th meme, 50 memes, because each answer takes about 3 minutes on local hardware). A configuration run on a subsample is scored on that subsample only, and our system is compared on the same memes.
- **Sample:** all **200 test memes** for every other configuration, so the comparison uses the identical memes and identical metrics as our system.

Making it fair.

- **Same information as the human annotators.** The prompt gives the 20 technique names with the paper's own definitions (prompt `def`). A second prompt with names only (`names`) measures how much the definitions matter.
- **Same output as our system.** The model returns techniques *and the exact words* for each, so both label F1 and span F1 can be computed. Fragments are located in the meme text; if they are not verbatim, a fuzzy match is used.
- **Wrong-shaped answers.** Responses are parsed leniently (code fences and surrounding prose are tolerated). Technique names are mapped to the 20 labels by exact, alias, then fuzzy matching; names outside the taxonomy (e.g. "Transfer") are dropped and counted. A response that cannot be parsed, or a refusal, is reported and

scored two ways: as "no techniques" (**strict**: what a deployed tool would show), and by excluding those memes for *both* systems (**lenient**).

- **Contamination.** The corpus has been public on GitHub since 2021, before these models' training cut-offs, so the memes may have been seen. We test **verbatim memorisation** directly: given the first half of a meme, the model is asked to continue it, and we compare its continuation with the real second half. As a control we compare it with the second half of a *different* meme.

The prompts are printed in full below.

In [47]:
```
# Raw responses of all LLM runs (gzip + base64 of JSON, generated from
c2_llm/outputs/*.jsonl). One line, ~kB.
C2_RAW_B64 =
"H4sIALeHzWoC/+y9C3fiSJYu+leiep05rp7rpNBbyrnr1pJBTlMJyINwuj03e9URIGxVgsRIIl3uXv2Dzu8
```

In [48]:
```
import base64, gzip, difflib
C2_RAW = json.loads(gzip.decompress(base64.b64decode(C2_RAW_B64)).decode("utf8"))
C2_PROMPTS = C2_RAW["prompts"]
c2 = pd.DataFrame(C2_RAW["records"])
print("records:", len(c2), "| configurations:")
display(c2.groupby(["dataset", "task", "model", "prompt"]).agg(runs=("run",
"nunique"), memes=("id", "nunique"),
        errors=("error", lambda e: e.notna().sum()), median_latency_s=("latency_s",
"median")))
for k in ["system_def", "system_names", "user_template", "memo_system",
"memo_user_template"]:
    print(f"\n===== {k} =====\n{C2_PROMPTS[k]}")
```

```
records: 3438 | configurations:
```

dataset	task	model	prompt	runs	memes	errors	median_latency_s
au_probe	classify	gemini-3.1-flash-lite	def	3	44	0	3.830
		gemini-3.1-pro	def	3	44	0	14.510
		ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none	def	1	44	0	9.485
test	classify	gemini-3.1-flash-lite	def	3	200	0	4.265
			names	3	200	0	3.800
		gemini-3.1-pro	def	3	200	0	17.975
			names	1	200	0	19.845
		ornith-1.5-9b	def	1	50	0	160.160
		ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none	def	3	200	0	8.730
	memo	gemini-3.1-flash-lite	memo	1	160	0	3.570
		gemini-3.1-pro	memo	1	160	0	53.730
		ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none	memo	1	160	0	11.625

```
===== system_def =====
You annotate persuasion techniques in the text of internet memes, following the taxonomy of SemEval-2021 Task 6. The persuasion techniques are:
- Appeal to authority: Stating that a claim is true because a valid authority or expert on the issue said it was true, without any other supporting evidence offered. The special case in which the reference is not an authority or an expert (Testimonial) is also included.
- Appeal to fear/prejudice: Seeking to build support for an idea by instilling anxiety and/or panic in the population towards an alternative. In some cases, the support is built based on preconceived judgments.
- Black-and-white Fallacy/Dictatorship: Presenting two alternative options as the only possibilities, when in fact more possibilities exist. As an extreme case, telling the audience exactly what actions to take, eliminating any other possible choices (Dictatorship).
- Causal Oversimplification: Assuming a single cause or reason, when there are actually multiple causes for an issue. It includes transferring blame to one person or group of people without investigating the actual complexities of the issue.
- Doubt: Questioning the credibility of someone or something.
- Exaggeration/Minimisation: Either representing something in an excessive manner, e.g., making things larger, better, worse ('the best of the best', 'quality guaranteed'), or making something seem less important or smaller than it really is, e.g., saying that an insult was just a joke.
- Flag-waving: Playing on strong national feeling (or positive feelings toward any group, e.g., based on race, gender, political preference) to justify or promote an action or idea.
- Glittering generalities (Virtue): Words or symbols in the value system of the target audience that produce a positive image when attached to a person or an issue.
- Loaded Language: Using specific words and phrases with strong emotional implications (either positive or negative) to influence an audience.
- Misrepresentation of Someone's Position (Straw Man): When an opponent's proposition is substituted with a similar one, which is then refuted in place of the original proposition.
- Name calling/Labeling: Labeling the object of the propaganda campaign as either something the target audience fears, hates, finds undesirable, or loves, praises.
- Obfuscation, Intentional vagueness, Confusion: Using words that are deliberately not clear, so that the audience can have their own interpretations.
- Presenting Irrelevant Data (Red Herring): Introducing irrelevant material to the issue being discussed, so that everyone's attention is diverted away from the points made.
- Reductio ad hitlerum: Persuading an audience to disapprove of an action or an idea by suggesting that the idea is popular with groups that are hated or in contempt by the target audience. It can refer to any person or concept with a negative connotation.
- Repetition: Repeating the same message over and over again, so that the audience will eventually accept it.
- Slogans: A brief and striking phrase that may include labeling and stereotyping. Slogans tend to act as emotional appeals.
- Smears: An effort to damage or call into question someone's reputation, by propounding negative propaganda. It can be applied to individuals or groups.
- Thought-terminating cliché: Words or phrases that discourage critical thought and meaningful discussion about a given topic. They are typically short, generic sentences that offer seemingly simple answers to complex questions or that distract the attention away from other lines of thought.
- Whataboutism: A technique that attempts to discredit an opponent's position by charging them with hypocrisy without directly disproving their argument.
- Bandwagon: Attempting to persuade the target audience to join in and take the course of action because 'everyone else is taking the same action'.

Return ONLY a JSON object, no other text, in exactly this shape:
{"techniques": [{"technique": "<one of the technique names above, copied exactly>", "fragment": "<the exact words from the meme text that carry the technique>"}]}

Rules:
- A meme may use no technique, one, or several. If it uses none, return {"techniques": []}.
- The same technique may be listed more than once if it occurs in different parts of the text.
- "fragment" must be copied verbatim from the meme text (same spelling and capitalisation).
- Judge only the text; you cannot see the image.

===== system_names =====
You annotate persuasion techniques in the text of internet memes, following the taxonomy of SemEval-2021 Task 6. The persuasion techniques are:
- Appeal to authority
- Appeal to fear/prejudice
- Black-and-white Fallacy/Dictatorship
- Causal Oversimplification
- Doubt
- Exaggeration/Minimisation
- Flag-waving
- Glittering generalities (Virtue)
```

```
- Loaded Language
- Misrepresentation of Someone's Position (Straw Man)
- Name calling/Labeling
- Obfuscation, Intentional vagueness, Confusion
- Presenting Irrelevant Data (Red Herring)
- Reductio ad hitlerum
- Repetition
- Slogans
- Smears
- Thought-terminating cliché
- Whataboutism
- Bandwagon

Return ONLY a JSON object, no other text, in exactly this shape:
{"techniques": [{"technique": "<one of the technique names above, copied exactly>", "fragment": "
<the exact words from the meme text that carry the technique>"}]}

Rules:
- A meme may use no technique, one, or several. If it uses none, return {"techniques": []}.
- The same technique may be listed more than once if it occurs in different parts of the text.
- "fragment" must be copied verbatim from the meme text (same spelling and capitalisation).
- Judge only the text; you cannot see the image.

===== user_template =====
Meme text:
"""
{meme_text}
"""


===== memo_system =====
You are given the beginning of the text of an internet meme. Continue it with the rest of the meme
text, exactly as it appeared. Output only the continuation.

===== memo_user_template =====
Beginning of meme text:
"""
{first_half_of_meme}
"""
```

In [49]:

```
_norm = lambda s: re.sub(r"[^a-z]+", " ", s.lower().replace("é", "e")).strip()
_ALIASES = {_norm(t): t for t in TECHNIQUES}
_ALIASES.update({_norm(a): t for a, t in [
    ("name calling", "Name calling/Labeling"), ("labeling", "Name
calling/Labeling"), ("labelling", "Name calling/Labeling"),
    ("loaded language", "Loaded Language"), ("black and white fallacy", "Black-and-
white Fallacy/Dictatorship"),
    ("dictatorship", "Black-and-white Fallacy/Dictatorship"), ("false dilemma",
"Black-and-white Fallacy/Dictatorship"),
    ("straw man", "Misrepresentation of Someone's Position (Straw Man)"),
("strawman", "Misrepresentation of Someone's Position (Straw Man)"),
    ("red herring", "Presenting Irrelevant Data (Red Herring)"), ("glittering
generalities", "Glittering generalities (Virtue)"),
    ("virtue", "Glittering generalities (Virtue)"), ("thought terminating cliche",
"Thought-terminating cliché"),
    ("appeal to fear", "Appeal to fear/prejudice"), ("appeal to prejudice", "Appeal
to fear/prejudice"),
    ("exaggeration", "Exaggeration/Minimisation"), ("minimisation",
"Exaggeration/Minimisation"),
    ("minimization", "Exaggeration/Minimisation"), ("exaggeration minimization",
"Exaggeration/Minimisation"),
    ("flag waving", "Flag-waving"), ("obfuscation", "Obfuscation, Intentional
vagueness, Confusion"),
    ("intentional vagueness", "Obfuscation, Intentional vagueness, Confusion"),
("causal oversimplification", "Causal Oversimplification"),
    ("reductio ad hitlerum", "Reductio ad hitlerum"), ("appeal to authority",
"Appeal to authority"),
```

```
    ("whataboutism", "Whataboutism"), ("bandwagon", "Bandwagon"), ("smears",
"Smears"), ("smear", "Smears"),
    ("doubt", "Doubt"), ("slogans", "Slogans"), ("slogan", "Slogans"),
("repetition", "Repetition")]})


def map_technique(name):
    n = _norm(str(name))
    if n in _ALIASES:
        return _ALIASES[n]
    close = difflib.get_close_matches(n, list(_ALIASES), n=1, cutoff=0.8)
    return _ALIASES[close[0]] if close else None


def locate(fragment, text):
    if not fragment:
        return None
    for hay, needle in [(text, fragment), (text.lower(), fragment.lower())]:
        i = hay.find(needle)
        if i >= 0:
            return i, i + len(needle)
    sm = difflib.SequenceMatcher(None, text.lower(), fragment.lower(),
autojunk=False)
    blocks = [b for b in sm.get_matching_blocks() if b.size > 0]
    if blocks and sum(b.size for b in blocks) >= 0.8 * len(fragment):
        return blocks[0].a, blocks[-1].a + blocks[-1].size
    return None


def parse_response(text, meme_text):
    """→ status, label vector, spans, n_unmapped, n_unlocated"""
    y = np.zeros(K, dtype=int)
    if not isinstance(text, str) or not text.strip():
        return "empty/refused", y, [], 0, 0
    m = re.search(r"```(?:json)?\s*(\{.*?\})\s*```", text, re.S) or re.search(r"(\
{.*\})", text, re.S)
    if not m:
        return "no JSON", y, [], 0, 0
    try:
        obj = json.loads(m.group(1))
        items = obj["techniques"]
        assert isinstance(items, list)
    except Exception:
        return "malformed JSON", y, [], 0, 0
    spans, unmapped, unlocated = [], 0, 0
    for it in items:
        if not isinstance(it, dict):
            unmapped += 1; continue
        t = map_technique(it.get("technique", ""))
        if t is None:
            unmapped += 1; continue
        y[T2I[t]] = 1
        loc = locate(str(it.get("fragment", "")), meme_text)
        if loc is None:
            unlocated += 1
        else:
            spans.append((loc[0], loc[1], t))
    return "ok", y, spans, unmapped, unlocated
```

```
test_text = dict(zip(df_test.id, df_test.text)); test_pos = {i: n for n, i in
enumerate(df_test.id)}
cls = c2[(c2.task == "classify") & (c2.dataset == "test") &
c2.id.isin(test_text)].copy()
cls = cls.sort_values("timestamp_utc").groupby(["model", "prompt", "run",
"id"]).tail(1)  # last attempt per meme
parsed = cls.apply(lambda r: parse_response(r.text if r.error is None or
pd.isna(r.error) else None, test_text[r.id]), axis=1)
cls["status"], cls["y"], cls["spans"], cls["unmapped"], cls["unlocated"] =
zip(*parsed)
status_tab = cls.groupby(["model", "prompt", "run"]).agg(
    ok=("status", lambda s: (s == "ok").sum()), failed=("status", lambda s: (s !=
"ok").sum()),
    unmapped_names=("unmapped", "sum"), fragments_not_found=("unlocated", "sum"))
display(status_tab.style.set_caption("Response shape: how many answers could be
used?"))
```

Response shape: how many answers could be used?

model	prompt	run	ok	failed	unmapped_names	fragments_not_found
gemini-3.1-flash-lite	def	1	200	0	1	0
		2	200	0	2	0
		3	200	0	2	0
	names	1	200	0	0	0
		2	200	0	2	0
		3	200	0	0	0
gemini-3.1-pro	def	1	200	0	0	0
		2	200	0	0	0
		3	200	0	0	0
	names	1	200	0	0	0
ornith-1.5-9b	def	1	49	1	0	0
ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none	def	1	200	0	1	0
		2	200	0	3	0
		3	200	0	0	0

In [50]:

```
def score_config(g, lenient):
    """Strict: every meme the model was asked about counts, failed answers as 'no
technique'.
    Lenient: only memes with a usable answer. A configuration run on a subsample is
scored on that subsample."""
    g = g.set_index("id").reindex(df_test.id)
    asked = g.status.notna().values
    ok = (g.status == "ok").values
    Yp = np.stack([y if isinstance(y, np.ndarray) else np.zeros(K, int) for y in
g.y])
    sp = [s if isinstance(s, list) else [] for s in g.spans]
    keep = ok if lenient else asked
    return {**label_scores(Y_test[keep], Yp[keep]),
            **span_scores([gold_test[i] for i in np.where(keep)[0]], [sp[i] for i
in np.where(keep)[0]]),
            "memes": int(keep.sum())}, Yp, sp, keep


rows, PRED_LLM = [], {}
for (model, prompt, run), g in cls.groupby(["model", "prompt", "run"]):
    for lenient in (False, True):
        s, Yp, sp, keep = score_config(g, lenient)
        rows.append({"system": model, "prompt": prompt, "run": run, "scoring":
"lenient" if lenient else "strict", **s})
        if not lenient:
            PRED_LLM[(model, prompt, run)] = (Yp, sp, keep)
```

```
        ours = {**label_scores(Y_test[keep], TEST["labels"][keep]),
                **span_scores([gold_test[i] for i in np.where(keep)[0]],
[TEST["spans"][i] for i in np.where(keep)[0]])}
        rows.append({"system": "OURS (same memes)", "prompt": f"vs
{model}/{prompt}", "run": run,
                     "scoring": "lenient" if lenient else "strict", **ours,
"memes": int(keep.sum())})
c2_all = pd.DataFrame(rows)
c2_sum = (c2_all[c2_all.system != "OURS (same memes)"]
          .groupby(["system", "prompt", "scoring"])[["micro_f1", "macro_f1",
"micro_p", "micro_r", "span_f1"]]
          .agg(lambda x: f"{x.mean():.3f} ± {x.std(ddof=1) if len(x) > 1 else
0:.3f}"))
ours_row = pd.DataFrame([{**label_scores(Y_test, TEST["labels"]),
**span_scores(gold_test, TEST["spans"])}],
                        index=pd.MultiIndex.from_tuples([("OURS: final ensemble",
"–", "–")], names=c2_sum.index.names))
display(pd.concat([ours_row.map(lambda v: f"{v:.3f}"), c2_sum]).style.set_caption(
    "200 test memes, mean ± sd over runs (strict: failed answers = no technique)"))
```

200 test memes, mean ± sd over runs (strict: failed answers = no technique)

system	prompt	scoring	micro_f1	macro_f1	micro_p	micro_r	span_f1	span_p	span_r
OURS: final ensemble	–	–	0.519	0.221	0.479	0.567	0.405	0.407	0.403
gemini-3.1-flash-lite	**def**	**lenient**	0.437 ± 0.019	0.312 ± 0.007	0.504 ± 0.030	0.386 ± 0.012	0.336 ± 0.021	nan	nan
		strict	0.437 ± 0.019	0.312 ± 0.007	0.504 ± 0.030	0.386 ± 0.012	0.336 ± 0.021	nan	nan
	names	**lenient**	0.385 ± 0.013	0.259 ± 0.013	0.495 ± 0.019	0.314 ± 0.012	0.297 ± 0.020	nan	nan
		strict	0.385 ± 0.013	0.259 ± 0.013	0.495 ± 0.019	0.314 ± 0.012	0.297 ± 0.020	nan	nan
gemini-3.1-pro	**def**	**lenient**	0.574 ± 0.007	0.437 ± 0.021	0.515 ± 0.005	0.648 ± 0.014	0.464 ± 0.001	nan	nan
		strict	0.574 ± 0.007	0.437 ± 0.021	0.515 ± 0.005	0.648 ± 0.014	0.464 ± 0.001	nan	nan
	names	**lenient**	0.542 ± 0.000	0.386 ± 0.000	0.494 ± 0.000	0.600 ± 0.000	0.452 ± 0.000	nan	nan
		strict	0.542 ± 0.000	0.386 ± 0.000	0.494 ± 0.000	0.600 ± 0.000	0.452 ± 0.000	nan	nan
ornith-1.5-9b	**def**	**lenient**	0.355 ± 0.000	0.241 ± 0.000	0.403 ± 0.000	0.318 ± 0.000	0.292 ± 0.000	nan	nan
		strict	0.348 ± 0.000	0.239 ± 0.000	0.403 ± 0.000	0.307 ± 0.000	0.287 ± 0.000	nan	nan
ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none	**def**	**lenient**	0.199 ± 0.013	0.171 ± 0.003	0.206 ± 0.012	0.192 ± 0.014	0.126 ± 0.013	nan	nan
		strict	0.199 ± 0.013	0.171 ± 0.003	0.206 ± 0.012	0.192 ± 0.014	0.126 ± 0.013	nan	nan

Is the gap real? We use a paired bootstrap over memes on run 1 of each LLM configuration: our micro-F1 minus the LLM's, resampling the same memes for both systems.

In [51]:

```
def paired_gap(Yp_llm, n_boot=2000, seed=SEED):
    rng = np.random.RandomState(seed); d = []
    for _ in range(n_boot):
        i = rng.randint(0, len(Y_test), len(Y_test))
        d.append(f1_score(Y_test[i], TEST["labels"][i], average="micro",
zero_division=0)
                 - f1_score(Y_test[i], Yp_llm[i], average="micro",
zero_division=0))
    return np.mean(d), np.percentile(d, [2.5, 97.5])
```

```
def paired_gap_on(Yp, mask, n_boot=2000, seed=SEED):
    rng = np.random.RandomState(seed); d = []
    idx_all = np.where(mask)[0]
    for _ in range(n_boot):
        i = rng.choice(idx_all, len(idx_all))
        d.append(f1_score(Y_test[i], TEST["labels"][i], average="micro",
zero_division=0)
                 - f1_score(Y_test[i], Yp[i], average="micro", zero_division=0))
    return np.mean(d), np.percentile(d, [2.5, 97.5])


gap_rows = []
for (model, prompt, run), (Yp, sp, keep) in PRED_LLM.items():
    if run == 1:
        m, ci = paired_gap_on(Yp, keep)
        gap_rows.append({"LLM": f"{model} / {prompt}", "memes": int(keep.sum()),
                         "ours − LLM (micro-F1)": m, "95% CI": np.round(ci, 3),
                         "LLM better?": "yes" if ci[1] < 0 else "no" if ci[0] > 0
else "not distinguishable"})
display(pd.DataFrame(gap_rows).style.format({"ours − LLM (micro-F1)": "{:+.3f}"}))

# agreement between repeated runs of the same LLM configuration (stability for a
teacher re-uploading a meme)
stab = []
for (model, prompt), g in cls.groupby(["model", "prompt"]):
    runs = sorted(g.run.unique())
    if len(runs) > 1:
        Ys = [PRED_LLM[(model, prompt, r)][0] for r in runs]
        jac = [np.mean([(a & b).sum() / (a | b).sum() if (a | b).any() else 1.0 for
a, b in zip(Ys[i], Ys[j])])
               for i, j in itertools.combinations(range(len(runs)), 2)]
        stab.append({"LLM": f"{model} / {prompt}", "runs": len(runs),
                     "mean pairwise Jaccard of label sets": np.mean(jac),
                     "memes with identical output in all runs": np.mean([all((Ys[0]
[n] == Y_[n]).all() for Y_ in Ys)
                                                                         for n in
range(len(Y_test))])})
display(pd.DataFrame(stab).style.format("{:.2f}", subset=["mean pairwise Jaccard of
label sets",
                                                          "memes with identical
output in all runs"])
        .set_caption("Run-to-run stability (our system is deterministic: 1.00 by
construction)"))
```

	LLM	memes	ours − LLM (micro-F1)	95% CI	LLM better?
0	gemini-3.1-flash-lite / def	200	+0.094	[0.038 0.147]	no
1	gemini-3.1-flash-lite / names	200	+0.137	[0.078 0.193]	no
2	gemini-3.1-pro / def	200	-0.056	[-0.107 -0.002]	yes
3	gemini-3.1-pro / names	200	-0.023	[-0.076 0.033]	not distinguishable
4	ornith-1.5-9b / def	50	+0.180	[0.041 0.325]	no
5	ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none / def	200	+0.334	[0.278 0.39]	no

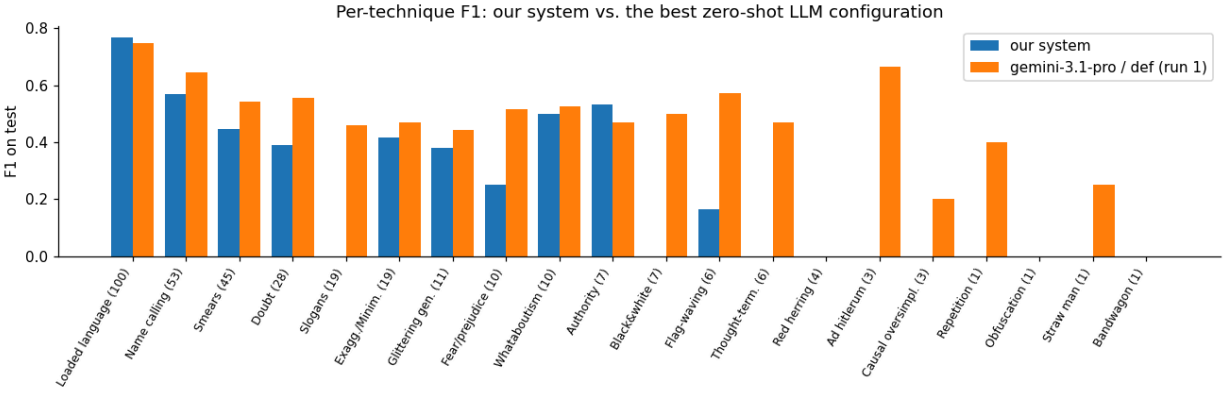
Run-to-run stability (our system is deterministic: 1.00 by construction)

	LLM	runs	mean pairwise Jaccard of label sets	memes with identical output in all runs
0	gemini-3.1-flash-lite / def	3	0.70	0.41
1	gemini-3.1-flash-lite / names	3	0.71	0.47
2	gemini-3.1-pro / def	3	0.82	0.45
3	ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none / def	3	0.27	0.02

In [52]:

```
full = [k for k in PRED_LLM if k[2] == 1 and PRED_LLM[k][2].all()]
best_llm = max(full, key=lambda k: f1_score(Y_test, PRED_LLM[k][0],
average="micro", zero_division=0))
```

```
f_ours = f1_score(Y_test, TEST["labels"], average=None, zero_division=0,
labels=range(K))
f_llm = f1_score(Y_test, PRED_LLM[best_llm][0], average=None, zero_division=0,
labels=range(K))
order_t = np.argsort(-Y_test.sum(0))
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(12, 4))
x = np.arange(K)
ax.bar(x - 0.2, f_ours[order_t], 0.4, label="our system"); ax.bar(x + 0.2,
f_llm[order_t], 0.4, label=f"{best_llm[0]} / {best_llm[1]} (run 1)")
ax.set_xticks(x, [f"{SHORT[TECHNIQUES[i]]} ({int(Y_test[:, i].sum())})" for i in
order_t], rotation=60, ha="right", fontsize=8)
ax.set_ylabel("F1 on test"); ax.legend(); ax.set_title("Per-technique F1: our
system vs. the best zero-shot LLM configuration")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
n_pred = pd.Series({"gold": Y_test.sum(1).mean(), "ours":
TEST["labels"].sum(1).mean(),
                    **{f"{k[0]}/{k[1]}": v[0][v[2]].sum(1).mean() for k, v in
PRED_LLM.items() if k[2] == 1}})
print("average number of techniques per meme:", n_pred.round(2).to_dict())
```




```
average number of techniques per meme: {'gold': 1.67, 'ours': 1.98, 'gemini-3.1-flash-lite/def':
1.32, 'gemini-3.1-flash-lite/names': 1.1, 'gemini-3.1-pro/def': 2.08, 'gemini-3.1-pro/names': 2.04,
'ornith-1.5-9b/def': 1.34, 'ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none/def': 1.53}
```

Contamination probe (verbatim memorisation). For each test meme of at least 8 words, the model received the first half and was asked to continue it. We report the share of the true second half recovered (longest common word sequence / length of the second half). As a control we compare the same continuation with the second half of a *different*, randomly paired meme.

In [53]:

```
memo = c2[(c2.task == "memo") & (c2.dataset == "test") &
c2.id.isin(test_text)].sort_values("timestamp_utc").groupby(["model",
"id"]).tail(1)


def lcs_words(a, b):
    a, b = a.lower().split(), b.lower().split()
    if not a or not b:
        return 0
    m = difflib.SequenceMatcher(None, a, b, autojunk=False).find_longest_match(0,
len(a), 0, len(b))
    return m.size


second_half = {i: " ".join(t.split()[len(t.split()) // 2:]) for i, t in
test_text.items()}
rng_m = np.random.RandomState(SEED)
```

```
memo_rows = []
for model, g in memo.groupby("model"):
    ids = list(g.id); perm = rng_m.permutation(ids)
    for (i, txt), j in zip(zip(g.id, g.text.fillna("")), perm):
        true, other = second_half[i], second_half[j]
        memo_rows.append({"model": model, "id": i, "recovered (true half)":
lcs_words(txt, true) / max(len(true.split()), 1),
                          "recovered (other meme, control)": lcs_words(txt, other)
/ max(len(other.split()), 1)})
memo_df = pd.DataFrame(memo_rows)
memo_tab = memo_df.groupby("model").agg(memes=("id", "size"), true_half=("recovered
(true half)", "mean"),
                                        control=("recovered (other meme, control)",
"mean"),
                                        verbatim_50pct=("recovered (true half)",
lambda x: (x >= 0.5).mean()))
display(memo_tab.style.format("{:.3f}", subset=["true_half", "control",
"verbatim_50pct"]).set_caption(
    "Memorisation probe: share of the unseen second half reproduced (verbatim_50pct
= memes with ≥50% reproduced)"))
```

Memorisation probe: share of the unseen second half reproduced (verbatim_50pct = memes with ≥50% reproduced)

model	memes	true_half	control	verbatim_50pct
gemini-3.1-flash-lite	160	0.112	0.030	0.044
gemini-3.1-pro	160	0.160	0.023	0.119
ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none	160	0.101	0.092	0.000

Practical comparison.

In [54]:

```
lat = c2[(c2.task == "classify") & (c2.dataset ==
"test")].groupby("model").latency_s.median()
display(pd.DataFrame({
    "median latency per meme (s)": {**lat.round(1).to_dict(), "OURS (5-model
ensemble)": round(lat5[0] / 1000, 3)},
    "student text leaves the device": {**{m: ("no (local)" if "ornith" in m.lower()
else "yes (hosted API)") for m in lat.index},
                                       "OURS (5-model ensemble)": "no"},
    "same input → same output": {**{m: "no (sampled)" for m in lat.index}, "OURS
(5-model ensemble)": "yes"},
}))
```

	median latency per meme (s)	student text leaves the device	same input → same output
gemini-3.1-flash-lite	4.000	yes (hosted API)	no (sampled)
gemini-3.1-pro	18.300	yes (hosted API)	no (sampled)
ornith-1.5-9b	160.200	no (local)	no (sampled)
ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none	8.700	no (local)	no (sampled)
OURS (5-model ensemble)	0.142	no	yes

C2 conclusion.

- **The strongest general-purpose model is better than ours.** Gemini 3.1 Pro, zero-shot, scores micro-F1 0.574 ± 0.007 over three runs and is significantly better on the same 200 memes (our −0.056, 95% CI −0.107 to −0.002). It is much better on rare techniques (macro-F1 0.44 vs. 0.22) and slightly better on spans (0.46 vs. 0.41). With the names-only prompt the gap is not significant. We report this as a finding, not a failure.

- **Contamination is plausible but limited.** Pro reproduces 16% of the unseen second halves of memes, against 2% for the control, and more than half of the text for 12% of memes, mostly well-known slogans and quotes. It has seen these meme texts or their sources, so its test score is likely somewhat optimistic. The labels themselves are not public in the same form, so this does not explain the whole advantage.
- **It cannot be deployed.** Every meme would leave the device to a hosted service, which the contract forbids. It is also not reproducible: only 45% of memes get the same labels in all three runs (mean Jaccard 0.82), and it takes 18 s per meme.
- **The deployable alternative is far worse.** Ornith-1.5-9B runs locally on T4-class hardware but scores 0.20 without reasoning (we are +0.33 better) and 0.35 with reasoning on 50 memes, at 160 s per meme, which is unusable while a class waits.
- **Cheap hosted models are worse than ours** (Flash-Lite 0.44, we are +0.09 better).

Why the department should pay for this system: among the options that satisfy the privacy constraint, it is the most accurate by a wide margin, it answers in 0.14 s, and it gives the same answer every time. The honest caveat: a frontier model is better at the task, so the best use of it is *offline*, on public memes only, for example to pre-label Australian training data that our local model then learns from.

Limits of the comparison. One provider gateway (grsai.ai) whose exact model build we cannot verify beyond the reported `modelVersion`; temperature 1.0 as recommended; one prompt family; strict and lenient scoring coincide because every response could be parsed.

C4. Will it work here? (Australia, 2026, a Year 10 feed)

There is no labelled Australian dataset. Instead we build evidence from three directions. Each answers a different part of "what goes wrong in the gap":

Gap	Evidence we can produce	Labels needed?
Who and what (US names, parties, institutions → Australian ones)	Replace US entities in the *test* memes with Australian counterparts. The rhetoric is unchanged, so the gold labels stay valid	no new labels
How it is written (case, slang, emoji, OCR noise of phone screenshots)	Controlled perturbations of the test memes, gold labels unchanged	no new labels
What it is about (2026 issues, teen feeds, non-political memes)	A small **probe set of 44 Australian-style memes**: 30 persuasive (12 aimed at each side + 6 non-partisan) and 14 everyday teen memes	written and labelled for this assignment (see the declaration)
Language drift	Out-of-vocabulary rate and sub-word fragmentation on the probe vs. the corpus	none

The probe set is small, synthetic and labelled by a single annotator. It cannot estimate Australian accuracy precisely. What it can show is *failure modes*: false alarms on harmless teen memes, side asymmetries, and techniques the model never fires on.

In [55]:
```
AU_MAP = [("donald trump", "peter dutton"), ("trump", "dutton"), ("joe biden",
"anthony albanese"), ("biden", "albanese"),
          ("obama", "rudd"), ("hillary clinton", "julia gillard"), ("hillary",
"julia"), ("clinton", "gillard"),
          ("kamala harris", "penny wong"), ("kamala", "penny"), ("pelosi", "wong"),
("bernie sanders", "adam bandt"),
          ("bernie", "bandt"), ("mcconnell", "littleproud"), ("pence", "ley"),
("aoc", "the greens"),
```

```
          ("democrats", "labor"), ("democrat", "labor"), ("republicans",
"liberals"), ("republican", "liberal"),
          ("gop", "coalition"), ("maga", "one nation"), ("congress", "parliament"),
("white house", "the lodge"),
          ("president", "prime minister"), ("america", "australia"), ("americans",
"australians"),
          ("american", "australian"), ("usa", "australia"), ("u.s.", "australia"),
("fbi", "afp"), ("cnn", "the abc"),
          ("fox news", "sky news")]
_au_re = re.compile(r"(?<![\w.])(" + "|".join(sorted(map(re.escape, dict(AU_MAP)),
key=len, reverse=True)) + r")(?![\w])", re.I)
_au = dict(AU_MAP)


def to_australia(text):
    return _au_re.sub(lambda m: match_case(m.group(0),
_au.get(fold_key(m.group(0)), m.group(0))), text)


EMOJI = ["💀", "😭", "🤡", "🔥", "😂"]


def ocr_noise(text, rate=0.03, seed=SEED):
    r = np.random.RandomState(seed + len(text)); chars = list(text)
    sub = {"o": "0", "l": "1", "i": "l", "e": "c", "s": "5", "O": "0", "I": "l",
"E": "F", "S": "5"}
    for i, c in enumerate(chars):
        if c in sub and r.rand() < rate * 3:
            chars[i] = sub[c]
    return "".join(chars)


PERTURB = {
    "original": lambda t: t,
    "US → AU entities": to_australia,
    "lower-case": str.lower,
    "sentence case": lambda t: t[:1].upper() + t[1:].lower(),
    "teen slang appended": lambda t: t.rstrip() + " fr fr no cap 💀",
    "emoji inserted": lambda t: " ".join(w + (f" {EMOJI[i % 5]}" if i % 4 == 3 else
"") for i, w in enumerate(t.split(" "))),
    "OCR noise (~5% chars)": ocr_noise,
    "AU entities + lower-case": lambda t: to_australia(t).lower(),
}
changed_au = np.array([to_australia(t) != t for t in df_test.text])
pert_rows, pert_pred = [], {}
for nm, fn in PERTURB.items():
    r = ensemble_predict(df_test.assign(text=[fn(t) for t in df_test.text]))
    pert_pred[nm] = r["labels"]
    lo, hi = bootstrap_ci(lambda a, b: f1_score(a, b, average="micro",
zero_division=0), Y_test, r["labels"])
    pert_rows.append({"perturbation": nm, "micro_f1": f1_score(Y_test, r["labels"],
average="micro", zero_division=0),
                      "95% CI": f"[{lo:.3f}, {hi:.3f}]", "macro_f1":
f1_score(Y_test, r["labels"], average="macro", zero_division=0),
                      "predicted techniques / meme": r["labels"].sum(1).mean(),
                      "memes whose labels changed": int((r["labels"] !=
TEST["labels"]).any(1).sum())})
pert = pd.DataFrame(pert_rows).set_index("perturbation")
display(pert.style.format({"micro_f1": "{:.3f}", "macro_f1": "{:.3f}", "predicted
techniques / meme": "{:.2f}"})
```

```
        .set_caption(f"Test set (200 memes) under controlled shifts; gold labels
unchanged. "
                     f"{changed_au.sum()} memes contain a US entity that was
replaced."))
m = changed_au
print(f"on the {m.sum()} memes that actually changed under US→AU: micro-F1
{f1_score(Y_test[m], TEST['labels'][m], average='micro'):.3f}"
      f" → {f1_score(Y_test[m], pert_pred['US → AU entities'][m],
average='micro'):.3f}")
```

Test set (200 memes) under controlled shifts; gold labels unchanged. 73 memes contain a US entity that was replaced.

perturbation	micro_f1	95% CI	macro_f1	predicted techniques / meme	memes whose labels changed
original	0.519	[0.469, 0.565]	0.221	1.99	0
US → AU entities	0.523	[0.472, 0.568]	0.205	1.90	37
lower-case	0.521	[0.465, 0.569]	0.221	1.90	84
sentence case	0.541	[0.486, 0.588]	0.227	1.90	78
teen slang appended	0.492	[0.446, 0.538]	0.210	2.51	125
emoji inserted	0.494	[0.441, 0.542]	0.192	2.19	99
OCR noise (~5% chars)	0.500	[0.451, 0.545]	0.226	2.15	81
AU entities + lower-case	0.519	[0.466, 0.564]	0.220	1.81	93

```
on the 73 memes that actually changed under US→AU: micro-F1 0.531 → 0.541
```

The Australian probe set.

In [56]:

```
AU_PROBE_JSON = r"""[
  {"id": "au01", "side": "against-left", "text": "Labor: we'll fix the housing
crisis\nAlso Labor: lets in half a million people a year",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Whataboutism", "fragment": "Labor: we'll fix the
housing crisis\nAlso Labor: lets in half a million people a year"},
              {"technique": "Causal Oversimplification", "fragment": "Labor: we'll
fix the housing crisis\nAlso Labor: lets in half a million people a year"}]},
  {"id": "au02", "side": "against-left", "text": "THE GREENS WANT TO BAN YOUR UTE,
YOUR BBQ AND YOUR BEACH HOLIDAY",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Misrepresentation of Someone's Position (Straw Man)",
"fragment": "THE GREENS WANT TO BAN YOUR UTE, YOUR BBQ AND YOUR BEACH HOLIDAY"},
              {"technique": "Exaggeration/Minimisation", "fragment": "BAN YOUR UTE,
YOUR BBQ AND YOUR BEACH HOLIDAY"}]},
  {"id": "au03", "side": "against-left", "text": "CANBERRA LEFTIES KNOW
BEST\n\nTHAT'S WHY YOUR RENT DOUBLED",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Name calling/Labeling", "fragment": "CANBERRA
LEFTIES"},
              {"technique": "Causal Oversimplification", "fragment": "THAT'S WHY
YOUR RENT DOUBLED"}]},
  {"id": "au04", "side": "against-left", "text": "Under-16 social media ban:
because Albo thinks your parents can't raise you",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Misrepresentation of Someone's Position (Straw Man)",
"fragment": "because Albo thinks your parents can't raise you"}]},
  {"id": "au05", "side": "against-left", "text": "WOKE LABOR IS DESTROYING
AUSTRALIA",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Name calling/Labeling", "fragment": "WOKE LABOR"},
              {"technique": "Loaded Language", "fragment": "DESTROYING"}]},
  {"id": "au06", "side": "against-left", "text": "If you voted Labor, don't
complain about your power bill",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Causal Oversimplification", "fragment": "If you voted
Labor, don't complain about your power bill"}]},
  {"id": "au07", "side": "against-left", "text": "THEY CALL IT A 'TRANSITION'\nWE
CALL IT A BLACKOUT",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Doubt", "fragment": "THEY CALL IT A 'TRANSITION'"},
              {"technique": "Appeal to fear/prejudice", "fragment": "WE CALL IT A
BLACKOUT"}]},
```

```
  {"id": "au08", "side": "against-left", "text": "Real Aussies built this country. Canberra bureaucrats are selling it off.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Flag-waving", "fragment": "Real Aussies built this country."},
              {"technique": "Name calling/Labeling", "fragment": "Canberra bureaucrats"},
              {"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "Canberra bureaucrats are selling it off."}]},
  {"id": "au09", "side": "against-left", "text": "THE GREENS: SOFT ON CRIME, HARD ON FARMERS",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Slogans", "fragment": "SOFT ON CRIME, HARD ON FARMERS"},
              {"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "THE GREENS: SOFT ON CRIME, HARD ON FARMERS"}]},
  {"id": "au10", "side": "against-left", "text": "Albanese couldn't run a sausage sizzle",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "Albanese couldn't run a sausage sizzle"}]},
  {"id": "au11", "side": "against-left", "text": "Everyone's leaving Victoria for Queensland. Ask yourself why.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Bandwagon", "fragment": "Everyone's leaving Victoria for Queensland."},
              {"technique": "Doubt", "fragment": "Ask yourself why."}]},
  {"id": "au12", "side": "against-left", "text": "Teal independents: Liberals for people who own a Tesla",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Name calling/Labeling", "fragment": "Liberals for people who own a Tesla"},
              {"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "Teal independents: Liberals for people who own a Tesla"}]},
  {"id": "au13", "side": "against-right", "text": "THE LIBS: 'NUCLEAR IS CHEAP'\nALSO THE LIBS: CAN'T BUILD A CARPARK ON TIME",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Doubt", "fragment": "THE LIBS: 'NUCLEAR IS CHEAP'\nALSO THE LIBS: CAN'T BUILD A CARPARK ON TIME"}]},
  {"id": "au14", "side": "against-right", "text": "Sussan Ley's plan for housing: inherit one",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Misrepresentation of Someone's Position (Straw Man)", "fragment": "Sussan Ley's plan for housing: inherit one"},
              {"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "Sussan Ley's plan for housing: inherit one"}]},
  {"id": "au15", "side": "against-right", "text": "DUTTON'S MATES WANTED NUCLEAR. AUSTRALIA SAID NO.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Name calling/Labeling", "fragment": "DUTTON'S MATES"},
              {"technique": "Flag-waving", "fragment": "AUSTRALIA SAID NO."}]},
  {"id": "au16", "side": "against-right", "text": "The Coalition: fossil fuel puppets since 1996",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Name calling/Labeling", "fragment": "fossil fuel puppets"},
              {"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "The Coalition: fossil fuel puppets since 1996"}]},
  {"id": "au17", "side": "against-right", "text": "ONE NATION: BECAUSE THINKING IS TOO HARD",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "ONE NATION: BECAUSE THINKING IS TOO HARD"}]},
  {"id": "au18", "side": "against-right", "text": "If you're not angry about climate change, you're not paying attention",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Black-and-white Fallacy/Dictatorship", "fragment": "If you're not angry about climate change, you're not paying attention"}]},
  {"id": "au19", "side": "against-right", "text": "Every scientist agrees. Only the Liberal Party doesn't.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Appeal to authority", "fragment": "Every scientist
```

```
agrees."},
              {"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "Only the Liberal Party
doesn't."}]},
  {"id": "au20", "side": "against-right", "text": "Big Mining wrote the Liberal
policy. Wake up, Australia.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "Big Mining wrote the Liberal
policy."},
              {"technique": "Slogans", "fragment": "Wake up, Australia."}]},
  {"id": "au21", "side": "against-right", "text": "Trump's tariffs. Ley's silence.
Coincidence?",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Doubt", "fragment": "Trump's tariffs. Ley's silence.
Coincidence?"}]},
  {"id": "au22", "side": "against-right", "text": "Libs cut Medicare. Libs cut
TAFE. Libs cut, cut, cut.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Repetition", "fragment": "cut, cut, cut"},
              {"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "Libs cut Medicare. Libs cut
TAFE. Libs cut, cut, cut."}]},
  {"id": "au23", "side": "against-right", "text": "The Nats: protecting your right
to breathe coal dust since forever",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Smears", "fragment": "The Nats: protecting your right
to breathe coal dust since forever"},
              {"technique": "Exaggeration/Minimisation", "fragment": "since
forever"}]},
  {"id": "au24", "side": "against-right", "text": "Billionaires don't pay tax. You
do. Vote Greens.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Black-and-white Fallacy/Dictatorship", "fragment":
"Vote Greens."},
              {"technique": "Slogans", "fragment": "Billionaires don't pay tax. You
do."}]},
  {"id": "au25", "side": "non-partisan", "text": "VAPES KILL. NO EXCUSES. NO SECOND
CHANCES.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Slogans", "fragment": "VAPES KILL."},
              {"technique": "Appeal to fear/prejudice", "fragment": "VAPES KILL."},
              {"technique": "Thought-terminating cliché", "fragment": "NO EXCUSES.
NO SECOND CHANCES."}]},
  {"id": "au26", "side": "non-partisan", "text": "Social media ban for teens? Next
they'll ban your thoughts.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Appeal to fear/prejudice", "fragment": "Next they'll
ban your thoughts."},
              {"technique": "Exaggeration/Minimisation", "fragment": "Next they'll
ban your thoughts."}]},
  {"id": "au27", "side": "non-partisan", "text": "Proud to be Australian. If you
don't like it, leave.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Flag-waving", "fragment": "Proud to be Australian."},
              {"technique": "Black-and-white Fallacy/Dictatorship", "fragment": "If
you don't like it, leave."}]},
  {"id": "au28", "side": "non-partisan", "text": "It is what it is. Houses will
never be affordable again.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Thought-terminating cliché", "fragment": "It is what
it is."},
              {"technique": "Exaggeration/Minimisation", "fragment": "Houses will
never be affordable again."}]},
  {"id": "au29", "side": "non-partisan", "text": "Doctors recommend: stop
doomscrolling after 10pm",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Appeal to authority", "fragment": "Doctors
recommend"}]},
  {"id": "au30", "side": "non-partisan", "text": "Every Year 10 kid already has a
vape. Don't be the last one.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Bandwagon", "fragment": "Every Year 10 kid already has
a vape. Don't be the last one."}]},
```

```
  {"id": "au31", "side": "benign", "text": "When the teacher says 'this won't be on
the test' and it's the whole test", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au32", "side": "benign", "text": "me at 2am: one more game\nme at 7am:
why am I like this", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au33", "side": "benign", "text": "POV: you forgot your PE uniform again",
"labels": []},
  {"id": "au34", "side": "benign", "text": "Mum: we have Maccas at home\nMaccas at
home: two-minute noodles", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au35", "side": "benign", "text": "When the bell rings but the teacher
says 'the bell doesn't dismiss you'", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au36", "side": "benign", "text": "Nobody:\nAbsolutely nobody:\nMagpies in
September:", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au37", "side": "benign", "text": "My group project partner after doing
nothing: 'we did great guys'", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au38", "side": "benign", "text": "Footy season is over. What do I even do
on weekends now", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au39", "side": "benign", "text": "Trying to explain Fortnite to my nan",
"labels": []},
  {"id": "au40", "side": "benign", "text": "When the wifi drops in the middle of a
ranked match", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au41", "side": "benign", "text": "Me pretending I read the book for
English class", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au42", "side": "benign", "text": "Summer in Australia: 42 degrees and the
aircon is broken", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au43", "side": "benign", "text": "When you find $5 in your old school
jumper", "labels": []},
  {"id": "au44", "side": "benign", "text": "The canteen ran out of sausage rolls.
Worst day of my life.",
   "labels": [{"technique": "Exaggeration/Minimisation", "fragment": "Worst day of
my life."}]}
]"""
AU_PROBE = json.loads(AU_PROBE_JSON)
probe_rows = []
for p in AU_PROBE:
    spans = []
    for l in p["labels"]:
        s = p["text"].find(l["fragment"]); assert s >= 0, (p["id"], l["fragment"])
        spans.append((s, s + len(l["fragment"]), l["technique"]))
    y = np.zeros(K, np.float32)
    for _, _, t in spans:
        y[T2I[t]] = 1
    probe_rows.append({"id": p["id"], "side": p["side"], "text": p["text"],
"spans": spans, "y": y})
df_probe = pd.DataFrame(probe_rows)
PR = ensemble_predict(df_probe)
Y_probe = np.stack(df_probe.y)
pers = (df_probe.side != "benign").values
rows = []
for nm, mask in [("persuasive (30)", pers), ("aimed at left (12)", (df_probe.side
== "against-left").values),
                 ("aimed at right (12)", (df_probe.side == "against-
right").values),
                 ("non-partisan (6)", (df_probe.side == "non-partisan").values),
("everyday teen memes (14)", ~pers)]:
    rows.append({"subset": nm, **label_scores(Y_probe[mask], PR["labels"][mask]),
                 **span_scores([df_probe.spans[i] for i in np.where(mask)[0]],
[PR["spans"][i] for i in np.where(mask)[0]]),
                 "memes with any label shown": f"{int(PR['labels']
[mask].any(1).sum())}/{int(mask.sum())}",
                 "gold memes with a technique": f"
```

```
{int(Y_probe[mask].any(1).sum())}/{int(mask.sum())}"})
display(pd.DataFrame(rows).set_index("subset").style.format("{:.3f}", subset=
["micro_f1", "macro_f1", "micro_p", "micro_r", "span_f1"])
        .set_caption("Australian probe set (author-written, single annotator)"))
display(df_probe.assign(gold=[fmt_labels(y) for y in Y_probe], predicted=
[fmt_labels(y) for y in PR["labels"]],
                        top_prob=PR["label_p"].max(1).round(2))[["side", "text",
"gold", "predicted", "top_prob"]])
```

Australian probe set (author-written, single annotator)

subset	micro_f1	macro_f1	micro_p	micro_r	span_f1	span_p	span_r	memes with any label shown	gold memes with a technique
persuasive (30)	0.275	0.158	0.286	0.264	0.229	0.327381	0.176664	25/30	30/30
aimed at left (12)	0.273	0.106	0.273	0.273	0.266	0.310345	0.232039	10/12	12/12
aimed at right (12)	0.372	0.155	0.348	0.400	0.288	0.443452	0.212916	11/12	12/12
non-partisan (6)	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000000	0.000000	4/6	6/6
everyday teen memes (14)	0.154	0.050	0.083	1.000	0.286	0.285714	0.285714	8/14	1/14

	side	text	gold	predicted	top_prob
0	against-left	Labor: we'll fix the housing crisis\nAlso Labor: lets in half a million people a year	Causal oversimpl., Whataboutism	Loaded language, Smears	0.81
1	against-left	THE GREENS WANT TO BAN YOUR UTE, YOUR BBQ AND YOUR BEACH HOLIDAY	Exagg./Minim., Straw man	Loaded language	0.97
2	against-left	CANBERRA LEFTIES KNOW BEST\n\nTHAT'S WHY YOUR RENT DOUBLED	Causal oversimpl., Name calling	Loaded language	0.43
3	against-left	Under-16 social media ban: because Albo thinks your parents can't raise you	Straw man	Loaded language, Name calling	0.97
4	against-left	WOKE LABOR IS DESTROYING AUSTRALIA	Loaded language, Name calling	Fear/prejudice, Loaded language, Smears	0.98
5	against-left	If you voted Labor, don't complain about your power bill	Causal oversimpl.	Loaded language	0.47
6	against-left	THEY CALL IT A 'TRANSITION'\nWE CALL IT A BLACKOUT	Fear/prejudice, Doubt	Name calling	0.52
7	against-left	Real Aussies built this country. Canberra bureaucrats are selling it off.	Flag-waving, Name calling, Smears	Fear/prejudice, Flag-waving, Loaded language, Slogans, Smears	0.96
8	against-left	THE GREENS: SOFT ON CRIME, HARD ON FARMERS	Slogans, Smears	Loaded language, Name calling, Smears	0.93
9	against-left	Albanese couldn't run a sausage sizzle	Smears	—	0.29
10	against-left	Everyone's leaving Victoria for Queensland. Ask yourself why.	Doubt, Bandwagon	—	0.04
11	against-left	Teal independents: Liberals for people who own a Tesla	Name calling, Smears	Loaded language, Name calling, Smears	0.99
12	against-right	THE LIBS: 'NUCLEAR IS CHEAP'\nALSO THE LIBS: CAN'T BUILD A CARPARK ON TIME	Doubt	Loaded language	0.75
13	against-right	Sussan Ley's plan for housing: inherit one	Straw man, Smears	Smears	0.68
14	against-right	DUTTON'S MATES WANTED NUCLEAR. AUSTRALIA SAID NO.	Flag-waving, Name calling	Smears	0.35
15	against-right	The Coalition: fossil fuel puppets since 1996	Name calling, Smears	Loaded language, Name calling, Smears	0.99
16	against-right	ONE NATION: BECAUSE THINKING IS TOO HARD	Smears	Loaded language	0.84
17	against-right	If you're not angry about climate change, you're not paying attention	Black&white	Loaded language, Smears	0.59
18	against-right	Every scientist agrees. Only the Liberal Party doesn't.	Authority, Smears	—	0.25
19	against-right	Big Mining wrote the Liberal policy. Wake up, Australia.	Slogans, Smears	Loaded language, Name calling, Slogans, Smears	0.99
20	against-right	Trump's tariffs. Ley's silence. Coincidence?	Doubt	Doubt, Smears	0.36
21	against-right	Libs cut Medicare. Libs cut TAFE. Libs cut, cut, cut.	Repetition, Smears	Loaded language, Repetition, Smears	0.92
22	against-right	The Nats: protecting your right to breathe coal dust since forever	Exagg./Minim., Smears	Loaded language, Name calling, Slogans	0.80
23	against-right	Billionaires don't pay tax. You do. Vote Greens.	Black&white, Slogans	Loaded language, Smears	0.92
24	non-partisan	VAPES KILL. NO EXCUSES. NO SECOND CHANCES.	Fear/prejudice, Slogans, Thought-term.	Loaded language	0.92
25	non-partisan	Social media ban for teens? Next they'll ban your thoughts.	Fear/prejudice, Exagg./Minim.	Loaded language	0.84
26	non-partisan	Proud to be Australian. If you don't like it, leave.	Black&white, Flag-waving	Loaded language	0.59
27	non-partisan	It is what it is. Houses will never be affordable again.	Exagg./Minim., Thought-term.	—	0.26
28	non-partisan	Doctors recommend: stop doomscrolling after 10pm	Authority	Loaded language	0.56
29	non-partisan	Every Year 10 kid already has a vape. Don't be the last one.	Bandwagon	—	0.16
30	benign	When the teacher says 'this won't be on the test' and it's the whole test	—	—	0.08
31	benign	me at 2am: one more game\nme at 7am: why am I like this	—	—	0.27
32	benign	POV: you forgot your PE uniform again	—	—	0.18
33	benign	Mum: we have Maccas at home\nMaccas at home: two-minute noodles	—	—	0.15
34	benign	When the bell rings but the teacher says 'the bell doesn't dismiss you'	—	—	0.09
35	benign	Nobody:\nAbsolutely nobody:\nMagpies in September:	—	Loaded language	0.44

	side	text	gold	predicted	top_prob
36	benign	My group project partner after doing nothing: 'we did great guys'	—	Loaded language, Name calling	0.48
37	benign	Footy season is over. What do I even do on weekends now	—	Loaded language	0.53
38	benign	Trying to explain Fortnite to my nan	—	—	0.09
39	benign	When the wifi drops in the middle of a ranked match	—	Loaded language	0.45
40	benign	Me pretending I read the book for English class	—	Name calling	0.35
41	benign	Summer in Australia: 42 degrees and the aircon is broken	—	Loaded language, Name calling	0.95
42	benign	When you find $5 in your old school jumper	—	Name calling	0.40
43	benign	The canteen ran out of sausage rolls. Worst day of my life.	Exagg./Minim.	Exagg./Minim., Loaded language, Name calling	0.95

Language drift and confidence. Two label-free signals that work on any new meme: how many of its words the training corpus never contained, and how confident the model is. A model that is *confidently* wrong on new material is the dangerous case for a classroom.

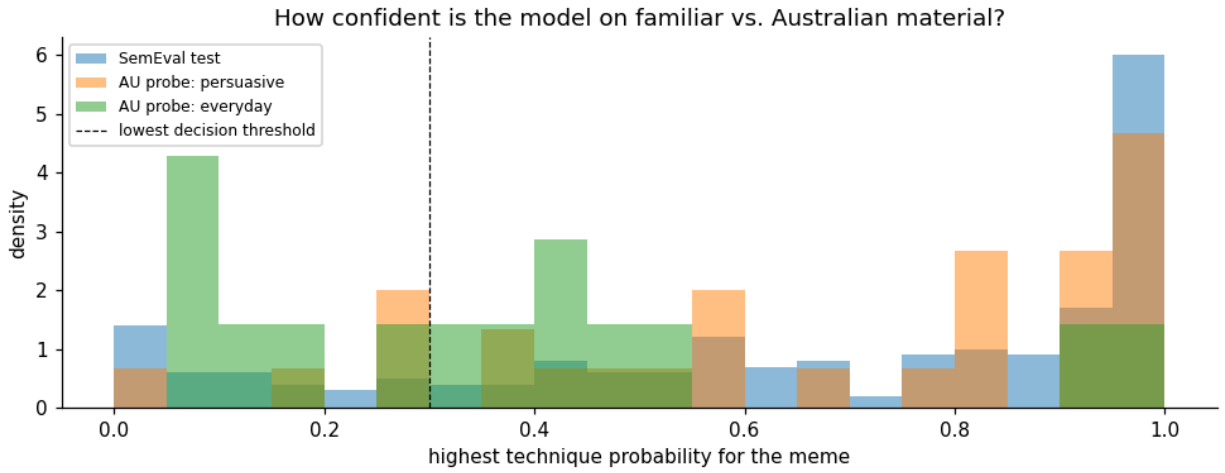
In [57]:

```
train_vocab = {w for t in df_dev.text for w in re.findall(r"[a-z']+", t.lower())}


def drift(texts):
    words = [w for t in texts for w in re.findall(r"[a-z']+", t.lower())]
    toks = sum(len(FINAL_TOK.tokenize(" " + w)) for w in words)
    return {"words": len(words), "OOV share (tokens)": np.mean([w not in
train_vocab for w in words]),
            "sub-word pieces per word": toks / max(len(words), 1)}


display(pd.DataFrame({"SemEval test (2020, US)": drift(df_test.text), "AU probe:
persuasive": drift(df_probe.text[pers]),
                      "AU probe: everyday":
drift(df_probe.text[~pers])}).T.style.format(
    {"words": "{:.0f}", "OOV share (tokens)": "{:.3f}", "sub-word pieces per word":
"{:.2f}"}))
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(9, 3.6))
for lbl, p in [("SemEval test", TEST["label_p"]), ("AU probe: persuasive",
PR["label_p"][pers]), ("AU probe: everyday", PR["label_p"][~pers])]:
    ax.hist(p.max(1), bins=np.linspace(0, 1, 21), alpha=0.5, density=True,
label=lbl)
ax.axvline(np.min(LABEL_THR), color="black", ls="--", lw=0.8, label="lowest
decision threshold")
ax.set_xlabel("highest technique probability for the meme");
ax.set_ylabel("density"); ax.legend(fontsize=8)
ax.set_title("How confident is the model on familiar vs. Australian material?");
plt.tight_layout(); plt.show()
```

	words	OOV share (tokens)	sub-word pieces per word
SemEval test (2020, US)	3331	0.165	1.13
AU probe: persuasive	276	0.268	1.23
AU probe: everyday	146	0.260	1.12



Does a general LLM transfer better? The same zero-shot prompts from C2 were run on the probe set. These models were trained on far more recent and more Australian text than our 2020 corpus, so this shows how much of our gap is about *knowledge of the world* rather than about the task.

In [58]:

```
probe_text = dict(zip(df_probe.id, df_probe.text)); probe_pos = {i: n for n, i in
enumerate(df_probe.id)}
pc = c2[(c2.task == "classify") & (c2.dataset ==
"au_probe")].sort_values("timestamp_utc").groupby(["model", "prompt", "run",
"id"]).tail(1)
rows = [{"system": "OURS", "run": "–", "persuasive micro_f1":
f1_score(Y_probe[pers], PR["labels"][pers], average="micro", zero_division=0),
         "persuasive span_f1": span_scores([df_probe.spans[i] for i in
np.where(pers)[0]], [PR["spans"][i] for i in np.where(pers)[0]])["span_f1"],
         "everyday memes flagged": f"{int(PR['labels']
[~pers].any(1).sum())}/{int((~pers).sum())}"}]
for (model, prompt, run), g in pc.groupby(["model", "prompt", "run"]):
    Yp = np.zeros((len(df_probe), K), int); sp = [[] for _ in range(len(df_probe))]
    for _, r in g.iterrows():
        st, y, s, _, _ = parse_response(r.text if pd.isna(r.error) else None,
probe_text[r.id])
        Yp[probe_pos[r.id]], sp[probe_pos[r.id]] = y, s
    rows.append({"system": f"{model} / {prompt}", "run": run,
                 "persuasive micro_f1": f1_score(Y_probe[pers], Yp[pers],
average="micro", zero_division=0),
                 "persuasive span_f1": span_scores([df_probe.spans[i] for i in
np.where(pers)[0]], [sp[i] for i in np.where(pers)[0]])["span_f1"],
                 "everyday memes flagged": f"
{int(Yp[~pers].any(1).sum())}/{int((~pers).sum())}"})
display(pd.DataFrame(rows).style.format({"persuasive micro_f1": "{:.3f}",
"persuasive span_f1": "{:.3f}"})
        .set_caption("Australian probe set: our system vs. zero-shot LLMs"))
```

Australian probe set: our system vs. zero-shot LLMs

	system	run	persuasive micro_f1	persuasive span_f1	everyday memes flagged
0	OURS	–	0.275	0.229	8/14
1	gemini-3.1-flash-lite / def	1	0.505	0.461	4/14
2	gemini-3.1-flash-lite / def	2	0.416	0.391	3/14
3	gemini-3.1-flash-lite / def	3	0.476	0.408	3/14
4	gemini-3.1-pro / def	1	0.746	0.701	1/14
5	gemini-3.1-pro / def	2	0.744	0.697	1/14
6	gemini-3.1-pro / def	3	0.748	0.678	1/14
7	ornith-1.5-9b-reasoning-none / def	1	0.294	0.262	6/14

C4 conclusion: will it work here?

Gap	Evidence	Finding
US names and institutions → Australian ones	entity swap on 73 test memes, labels unchanged	no drop (0.531 → 0.541); the model reads the rhetoric, not the names
Writing style of a 2026 feed	lower-case, sentence case, slang, emoji, OCR noise	small drops (0.49–0.50 for slang, emoji, OCR), all inside the CI, but **more labels per meme** (2.5 instead of 2.0 with slang)
New topics and vocabulary	30 persuasive Australian probe memes	micro-F1 falls to **0.28** (test: 0.52); 27% of words unseen in training (test: 17%)
Harmless teen memes	14 everyday memes	**8 of 14 get a technique label**, often Loaded Language or Name calling ("Maccas at home", "group project partner")
Does a general LLM transfer better?	same probe set	Gemini Pro 0.75 and 1/14 false alarms; our model 0.28 and 8/14

What goes wrong in the gap. The model has learned what *2020 US political* persuasion looks like. In front of new topics (housing, energy, the under-16 social-media ban) it falls back to the three frequent attack labels. In front of ordinary teen humour it sees hostility that is not there. The model is also *confident* on Australian material (the confidence histogram looks like the familiar test set), so a teacher cannot rely on low confidence to spot these errors.

What it means in the classroom.

- **For the teacher:** the lesson must not assume the labels are right. The tool should frame every output as a question for the class, and the teacher needs a one-click "the tool is wrong here" button that is logged.
- **For a student whose family's politics appear on screen:** a label like *Smears* on a meme they shared from home can feel like a verdict on their family. The tool must label techniques, never sides or people. It should show the same technique on a meme from the other side whenever possible, and teachers need guidance for that moment.
- **Accountability:** the department should collect consented, de-identified Australian examples (teacher-chosen, not student uploads), label a few hundred with at least two annotators, and re-evaluate before every term. False alarms on non-political memes should be tracked as their own metric.

Limits. The probe set is small (44 memes), synthetic, written and labelled by one annotator with AI assistance. It can reveal failure modes but cannot estimate Australian accuracy. The perturbations test style, not meaning.

7. Ultimate judgement

7.1 The evidence in one table

Every number below is computed earlier in this notebook. They are collected here so the judgement can be checked against them.

In [59]:
```
card = pd.Series({
    "Final configuration": BEST,
    "Test micro-F1 (95% CI)": f"{test_tab.loc['final ensemble (5 models)',
'micro_f1']:.3f} {test_tab.loc['final ensemble (5 models)', 'micro_f1 95% CI']}",
    "Test macro-F1": f"{test_tab.loc['final ensemble (5 models)',
'macro_f1']:.3f}",
```

```
    "Test precision / recall (labels)": f"{test_tab.loc['final ensemble (5
models)', 'micro_p']:.3f} / {test_tab.loc['final ensemble (5 models)',
'micro_r']:.3f}",
    "Test span F1 (95% CI)": f"{test_tab.loc['final ensemble (5 models)',
'span_f1']:.3f} {test_tab.loc['final ensemble (5 models)', 'span_f1 95% CI']}",
    "SemEval-2021 best (labels / spans)": "0.593 / 0.482",
    "Majority baseline on test (labels)": f"{test_tab.loc['majority baseline',
'micro_f1']:.3f}",
    "Techniques with usable F1 (≥0.4) on test": ", ".join(pt.index[pt.F1 >= 0.4]),
    "Best zero-shot LLM (strict, run 1)": f"{best_llm[0]} / {best_llm[1]}: micro-F1
"
                                          f"{f1_score(Y_test, PRED_LLM[best_llm]
[0], average='micro', zero_division=0):.3f}",
    "Label/span heads disagree": f"{100 * (tot['label only'] + tot['span only']) /
tot.sum():.1f}% of flagged pairs",
    "Counterfactual side swap: label sets changed": f"{100 *
flip[changed].mean():.1f}% of {changed.sum()} memes",
    "Same-side control swap: label sets changed": f"{100 *
flip_ctrl[both_changed].mean():.1f}% (side swap on the same memes: {100 *
flip[both_changed].mean():.1f}%)",
    "Everyday AU teen memes wrongly flagged": f"{int(PR['labels']
[~pers].any(1).sum())}/{int((~pers).sum())}",
    "AU probe persuasive micro-F1": f"{f1_score(Y_probe[pers], PR['labels'][pers],
average='micro', zero_division=0):.3f}",
    "Latency per meme, 5-model ensemble (median)": f"{lat5[0]:.0f} ms on
{torch.cuda.get_device_name(0) if DEVICE.type == 'cuda' else 'CPU'}",
}, name="value")
display(card.to_frame())
```

	value
Final configuration	E5 bce+pos_weight
Test micro-F1 (95% CI)	0.519 [0.469, 0.565]
Test macro-F1	0.221
Test precision / recall (labels)	0.479 / 0.567
Test span F1 (95% CI)	0.405 [0.357, 0.442]
SemEval-2021 best (labels / spans)	0.593 / 0.482
Majority baseline on test (labels)	0.374
Techniques with usable F1 (≥0.4) on test	Loaded language, Name calling, Smears, Exagg./Minim., Whataboutism, Authority
Best zero-shot LLM (strict, run 1)	gemini-3.1-pro / def: micro-F1 0.575
Label/span heads disagree	34.9% of flagged pairs
Counterfactual side swap: label sets changed	30.5% of 285 memes
Same-side control swap: label sets changed	32.7% (side swap on the same memes: 32.0%)
Everyday AU teen memes wrongly flagged	8/14
AU probe persuasive micro-F1	0.275
Latency per meme, 5-model ensemble (median)	142 ms on Tesla T4

7.2 Judgement

Recommendation: do not deploy this system as an autonomous technique detector next term. Deploy it, if at all, as a teacher-led discussion aid for a few core techniques, with the C3 display rule, and plan a re-evaluation on Australian data.

Why this model is the best available under the constraints.

- It is the best of the configurations we tested on clean, paired cross-validation: DeBERTa-v3, fully fine-tuned, our label-wise attention head, joint label + span training, class-weighted loss, a five-fold ensemble.

- On the held-out test set it reaches micro-F1 0.52 and span F1 0.41: clearly above the baselines, below the 2021 state of the art that used now-forbidden propaganda pretraining.
- It satisfies every constraint: it runs locally, answers in 0.14 s on a T4 using under 2 GB of weights, is deterministic, and uses no persuasion-trained checkpoint and no external data.
- Among systems that may legally run in a classroom, nothing we tested comes close: a local 9B LLM reaches 0.20.

Why it is not ready to run unsupervised.

1. **Few techniques work.** Only Loaded Language, Name calling, Smears, Whataboutism, Exaggeration and (on very few examples) Appeal to authority reach F1 ≥ 0.4. Twelve of the twenty techniques are almost never found.
2. **It over-accuses.** Precision is 0.48: about half of all shown labels are wrong. Missed subtle techniques turn into extra "attack" labels.
3. **It is sensitive to names.** One in three label sets change when a name is swapped, and neutral sentences about politicians can be flagged. We found no side-specific bias, but students will experience the instability as bias.
4. **It does not transfer.** On Australian-style memes accuracy roughly halves, and 8 of 14 harmless teen memes are flagged, while the model stays confident.
5. **A general model is better at the task** (Gemini Pro, 0.57 on test and 0.75 on the Australian probe set), but it is not allowed on student data.

Realistic chance of success. In a classroom where the teacher uses the output as a prompt ("the tool thinks this is Name calling; which words would do that?"), the tool can work for the core techniques today. As a system that names the techniques in a student's meme by itself, it would mislead students in a large share of cases.

What would change this verdict.

- Label 300–500 Australian memes (teacher-curated, public sources, at least two annotators) and fine-tune on them.
- Use the frontier LLM **offline on public memes only** to pre-label more Australian training data, then distil it into the local model. No student data would leave the device.
- Augment training with name masking and benign everyday memes to cut the name sensitivity and the false alarms.
- Re-run C1–C4 on that data before every term, and track teacher overrides as a live quality metric.

7.3 Limitations

- **Small, noisy data:** 750 development memes; duplicated texts carry different labels; inter-annotator agreement $\alpha \approx 0.77$. Rare techniques have 1–5 training examples.
- **Selection optimism:** cross-validation was used for every choice, so its 0.56 overstates the 0.52 found on test. The test set itself is only 200 memes (CI ±0.05).
- **Training budget:** validation label F1 was still rising slowly at epoch 15 in some folds.

- **Text only:** the image is ignored, although many techniques live in it (by design of the task).
- **Evaluation reach:** everything except C4 is measured on 2020 US/Canadian Facebook memes. The Australian evidence is synthetic and small. Political side is detected with keywords.
- **Reproducibility:** GPU kernels are not bit-deterministic. A re-run gives the same conclusions, but individual numbers can move by about the seed standard deviation (≈0.01).

8. Declarations

Pretrained weights (downloaded, run locally). `microsoft/deberta-v3-base`, `roberta-base` and `cardiffnlp/twitter-roberta-base-2021-124m`. All three were pretrained with self-supervised objectives only (masked or replaced-token prediction). None was trained on persuasion-, propaganda- or rhetoric-labelled data.

Additional public data. The Propaganda Techniques Corpus (SemEval-2020 Task 11; Da San Martino et al., 2020; Zenodo record 3952415, CC-BY 4.0) was used in experiment E9 only. It contains news articles, not memes. No meme of our corpus occurs in it (checked in E9), so it cannot contain the labels of our evaluation set. Whether it is part of the final model is decided by E9 and printed there.

Zero-shot comparison (C2). Responses were collected outside the notebook with `c2_llm/run_llm.py` and are embedded above.

- Gemini 3.1 Pro and Gemini 3.1 Flash-Lite, through the grsai.ai gateway (Gemini-native `generateContent` API). The version is recorded from the `modelVersion` field of each response.
- Ornith-1.5-9B (Q4_K_M GGUF), run locally in LM Studio, with and without its reasoning mode.
- Dates, temperature and full prompts are printed in Section 6. Only public test memes were sent to hosted models. No student data exists in this project.

Australian probe set (C4). The 44 probe memes were written for this assignment and labelled by a single annotator, with the help of an AI assistant, and checked by the student. They are synthetic. They are used only to look for failure modes, not to estimate accuracy.

Use of AI assistance. An AI coding assistant (Claude, Anthropic) helped to write code and draft text. All design decisions, experiments and conclusions were reviewed by the student, who takes responsibility for them.

9. References

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